



KENYATTA UNIVERSITY
INSTITUTE OF OPEN & VIRTUAL LEARNING
DEPARTMENT OF LITERATURE
ALT 340: STYLISTICS AND LITERARY
TECHNIQUES

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Lecture Thirteen THE SUPRASEGMENTALS

Introduction

This is our thirteenth Lecture in this unit. When studying sound features in literary works, we tend to focus on sound features as realized in the segments presented in a text, or symbols that have phonic potential. However, not all attributes of the μ orality attendant to a linguistic symbol are reflected plainly in the symbol. Certain phonological features, very crucial in apprehension of literary works, cannot be marked graphologically but we appreciate them when we hear them. These are the features we refer to as ³Suprasegmentals'. They are also commonly known as ³Prosodic features'. In this lecture, we will examine the literary significance of such sound features which are not marked in print.

At the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- (a) define, describe and identify the various Suprasegmentals
- (b) Explain their use / effect in Literature

The Suprasegmental Level

The word μ *Supra* means μ above. ³Suprasegmental' therefore means ³above the phoneme'. Thus, Suprasegmental features operate at a plane higher than phonemes (segments). Instead of being marked graphologically as units of sound, suprasegmentals are only heard. They are deciphered mostly in terms of loudness and speed. That is, suprasegmentals are construed through variance in loudness in an utterance or through the speed of articulation of an utterance. For example, irony or sarcasm in a phrase like: ³Oh yes he is intelligent' may not be deciphered in a literary text unless there is further elaboration which makes the irony or sarcasm clear.

However, spoken, a mocking tone would bring out the sarcasm in the phrase. No further elaboration would be required. Also, the

Lecture One STYLE IN LITERATURE

Introduction

The term *style* is a rather loose and wide one. Indeed, *Style* is a highly complex phenomenon which can be viewed and appreciated from manifold perspectives. For instance, the term refers to the part of a flower just below the stigma, mode of dressing, shoe design and many others. However, in this Lecture, we shall restrict ourselves to style as appertains to Language use; which is our concern as literary scholars.

Lecture Objectives:

At the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- (a) Define the term *style* as a linguistic phenomenon.
- (b) Define the term *style* from a purely literary perspective.

STYLE

Style in Literature is attributed to both spoken and written works. Our definitions will take all these into consideration.

As John Middleton Murry claims, though in a manner condescending to Literature, a discussion of the word *style* would inevitably cover the whole of literary aesthetics and the theory of criticism. Be that as it may, an analysis of some definitions of the term style culled from critical works, linguistic studies, dictionaries and encyclopaedia of different periods shows that the definitions, arising from the various schools of thought's point of emphasis or interest, allowing for much overlapping, can be classified under a number of major *themes* as follows:

(a) Definitions of Style based on the basic Stages of the Communication Process

The focus of the definitions that fall in this category is on the writer or speaker and how he/she endeavours to express his/her point of view.

Richard Olmann, a modern apostle of dualism argues that style is a way of writing through which a writer conveys his thoughts. Here, language can be used in several ways to convey the same thought. Hence, to Swift, Style refers to words in their proper places that convey our thoughts. To Riffaterre, a French, Style is the emotive element of language which is added to the neutral presentation of the message. The message here alludes to someone's thoughts. Style is therefore seen as a way of expressing content of the mind / formulating

our thoughts with maximum effectiveness. In this regard Goethe (1960:3) succinctly sums it up: 'Style is a high, active principle of composition by which the writer/speaker penetrates and reveals the inner form of his or her subject'. Style in this kind of definition is therefore opposed to a passive imitation of reality/nature or the facile application of mannerisms to the subject. In this regard, Schopenhauer defined style as 'the physiognomy of the mind'. This shows that whatever a great artist writes has his own unmistakable hallmark because he will extract from each object those elements which are congenial to him and have an affinity to his own mind. In this sense, Style is inimitable.

Another definition of Style in this category is that Style is a general manner of doing something which is typical or representative of a writer or writers. In this regard, just as we talk of modern style of architecture, a politician's style of leadership, a period's manner of dressing, and many more, we can also talk of Chinua Achebe's or Ngugi Wa Thiong'o's idiosyncratic style of writing. It is in the same regard that we now talk of Elizabethan, Victorian, Medieval or Negritudist kinds of writings ± writings that exhibited some kind of commonality either in style or theme or both.

Under this category, style can also be defined as an application of language in specific contexts in the right manner. Here, style has a linguistic realization of aesthetic effect. It is how an artist/writer manipulates language for various aesthetic effects. In this regard we can mention the habitual way of spelling, punctuation, literary structuring that is typical of various writers depending on the various effects aimed at. Hence Valerie Kibera in *Anthology of East African Short Stories* views style as 'the writer's own language, and the unique features of his style can only be determined against the background of the expressive resources at his disposal'. This means that style is how a writer/artist manipulates language in his/her unique fashion to reveal him/herself through his choice of style in the end product. For example, a writer chooses

images mainly from personal experiences, especially those that have held his attention or have had the strongest impression on him. An example is Alfred de Vigny's railway images which he created as a result of his being profoundly shocked by the railway accident at Versailles in 1842. He developed a strong emotional hostility towards railways. In Ngugi Wa Thiong'o's works, the image of the railway is associated with the white man's incursion into Africa and the subsequent alienation of black people's land by the white man. As a young person, Ngugi also had first hand experiences of the injustices that accompanied the coming of the white man into Africa.

(b) Definitions based on the Characteristics of the text itself

Some critics and schools of criticism have defined style based on linguistic manipulation inherent in a text. Such scholars analyze style entirely in terms of objective investigation of

textual features. Some linguists define style as the frequency of occurrence of linguistic elements which can be examined statistically. Cleanth Brooks and Robert Penn Warren in *Understanding Fiction* contend that Style is the selection and ordering of language in a text.

Style under this second category is seen as a term that alludes to the linguistic characteristics of a particular text. It is the way language is used in a text depending on the genre, period and school of writing, or a combination of these. The style of a text is seen as a function of the aggregate of the contextual probabilities or ratios between the frequencies of its syntactic/grammatical, phonological, morphological, lexical and other items. That style is the aggregate of linguistic items means that style is a result of more than one linguistic item. A given word / linguistic item acquires significance of constituting 'style' only if juxtaposed in relation with/to another word / linguistic item.

There are other scholars who equate style to statistical deviation. To such critics like Charles .E. Osgood, the style of a discourse is the message transmitted by the frequency apportionment and transitional probabilities of its linguistic traits especially as they vary from those of the same characteristics in the language as a whole. Thus Osgood defines style as:

an individual's deviation from norms for which the situation in which he is encoding these deviations being in the statistical properties of those structural features for which there exists some degree of choice in his code. (*Style in Language* p.293)

In this definition, it seems that if emphasis on frequencies and probabilities are combined, the right track is traced. Erik Wellander argues that Style in linguistic sense usually signifies every exceptional usage clearly dissimilar to the general.

(c) Definitions based on the Expressive Qualities Vis a Vis the Impressions of the Reader / Listener

The Stendhal school of thought was interested in the expressive qualities of style and regarded Style as the means of formulating our thoughts with the maximum effectiveness. Hence Stendhal defined style thus:

Style consists in adding to a given thought all the circumstances calculated to produce the whole effect that the thought ought to produce.

To Stendhal, Style is an addition whose function is described not in terms of beauty but more inclusively in terms of expediency and effect.

Style in this third category of definitions is seen as a set of individual characteristics, selection and arrangement of linguistic items that call attention to themselves and ultimately create an impact on the audience. Style is therefore careful management of language which is able to yield intellectual pleasure owing to the splendour of the linguistic manipulation in communicating a particular theme. This means that style necessitates that the audience get some impression of text / performance. Charles Bally identifies Style with a layer of effective elements. To Bally, Style is the effective value of the features of organized language and the reciprocal action of the expressive features that in cahoots form the pattern of the means of expression of a language. Stendhal supports Bally by describing style succinctly as effective presentation. Style in a given text should be geared at expressing something and fulfilling its purpose by making a desired impact through communicating in a particular way.

In this category of definitions, style has also been seen as an addition to a core of thought or expression. Here, a distinction can be ascertained between utterances on style that are objectively verifiable and those that are purely subjectively impressionistic.

Gourmount sees Style as the very thought itself. To Gourmount, style is the bewildering appropriate transubstantiation of a spiritual body given to us in the form in which we appropriate and engulf that body.

To Kenneth Burke, Style is ingratiation. It tries to earn favour by the hypnotic or suggestive process of saying the right thing. To Sir Arthur Quiller (1920), Style as technically evinced in Literature is the power to touch with ease, grace, precision, any note in the gamut of human thought and emotion. Hence to Sir Arthur Quiller, Style resembles good manners.

Another definition of Style under this category is that style is a shell surrounding a pre-existing core of thought or expression. Style adds circumstances to produce a whole effect.

Pluralists define style in terms of function and say that it is the way in which language is used to convey thought. They argue that language has varied functions and therefore style, of necessity, conveys what is intended: a command, persuasion, questioning or whatever it may be

APPROPRIATE DEFINITION

The assortment of definitions discussed, while overlapping in many regards, are not conclusive. Hence, they still call upon us to agree on or formulate a suitable definition of the term Style. One definition that is close to what a literary stylistician would go for is the one by Geoffrey Leech and Michael Short (1981). Leech and Short define Style as the way in which language is employed in a particular context by a particular person, for a particular

purpose. This kind of definition cuts across the three sub-categories of definitions in that inherent in it are elements of a writer's point of view, characteristics of the text and impressions of the reader.

The definition by Leech and Short also has the *langue* and *parole* aspects of language well constituted. *Langue* refers to the code or system of rules which are common to speakers of a language. This is evinced in the aspect of the definition alluding to context and purpose. This means that various contexts had various purposes. *Parole* refers to the use of these codes or rules (langue). This is seen in the part of the definition referring to language use in a given context by a given person, for a given purpose.

The definition by Leech and Short may be considered somewhat acceptable owing to its pluralistic approach. It not only analyses style in terms of function but also emphasizes on the idiosyncratic elements of a writer. However, this definition still lacks in multifold regards. Whereas this definition, just like the other definitions we looked at, over-emphasizes linguistic elements, stylistic manipulation in Literature may transcend sheer linguistic manipulation to inclusion of paralingual / extra-lingual features. Genre may also determine the pattern of linguistic presentation. In essence then, we can improve on the definitions of style by coming up with our own definition that incorporates all the core components. How about this?

Literary Style may be regarded as the personal and creative fashioning of the resources of language and extra-lingual aspects which a writer's/ artist's chosen dialect / language, period, genre, and his / her purpose within the genre offers him / her.

This is an example of what would constitute an appropriate definition of Style. You are free to come up with your own. Let us now try to analyze the definition in order to explain ourselves clearly. Why chosen dialect? A writer can only use a language / dialect that he / she is competent in. An African writer trying to write in American or West Indian English dialects that he / she is not conversant with or has not mastered, can only lead to artificialities and a literary work that is totally unrealistic or even laughable altogether. Why period? History has demonstrated that languages metamorphose with time. While reflecting on a particular period of time, in order to be realistic, a writer would be expected to be faithful to the speech patterns / behaviour of the epoch being delineated. This is why writers usually employ the language of their times in order to communicate with ease with fellow persons of their time. It would be foolhardy to elaborately use Shakespearean English in our particular period of time for no purpose at all. When a modern writer employs such obsolete English, he does that deliberately yet minimally. Deliberate in the sense that if he is quoting from the bible as Ngugi does in *A Grain of Wheat*, he ought to remain faithful to the Biblical register. A writer like John Ruganda also uses such obsolete language in *The Floods* for satirical reasons. Bwogo, at some point, just like Jesus, 'performs the miracle of making the 'dumb' Nankya speak. And thus: 'the dumb speaketh «'.

How does genre determine the manner and extent to which a writer will fashion his / her art? The word 'genre' alludes to a category, class, kind, and type. These categories usually have their own norms, against which they are judged. For example one would obviously expect poetic language in poetry and dramatic language in drama. The existence of poetic license which allows writers to transgress generic norms notwithstanding, writers are expected to adhere to generic norms, and when they transgress these norms, not to go overboard to the extent of leading to thematic obscurity or creating art that can only be called a generic but ± neither a mammal nor a bird ± thus amorphous art that cannot be classified. While mixture of genres or inter-generic borrowing is presently being experimented or exercised by many budding writers, it is always the case that one type of genre will preponderate over the other(s) and therefore enable the text to be placed in a particular category, the generic wanderings notwithstanding.

The intentions of a writer unquestionably have a bearing on the kind of style a writer will use. Is the intention of the writer to create laughter while teaching at the same time? That must have been what Nicolai Gogol intended in writing his hilarious yet serious play ***The Government Inspector***. In laughing at the folly and foibles of the corrupt, indolent and confused town officials, we recognize and guffaw at our own folly and flaws as human beings, yet we acknowledge the wantonness of the calamities and profligacy that may be occasioned by man's folly and mischief. If the intention of the writer is to incite pity / sympathy or even anger in the reader, he / she will write a text conducive to inciting these shades of emotions in the reader. At the end of the first section of Marjorie Oludhe Macgoye's novel ***Coming to Birth***, you would hate any man who turns his wife into some kind of doormat. Macgoye effectively presents Martin's patriarchal thinking in his wicked actions towards Paulina. While the reader sympathizes with the brutalized woman, he / she is compelled into loathing the beast-like, chauvinistic Martin.

Summary

In this lecture we looked at the term 'Style'. We looked at several definitions of the term as given by various scholars. We noted that most of these definitions only focus on an aspect or aspects of style and may therefore not be considered appropriate definitions of the term with regard to Literature. Subsequently, we have endeavoured to formulate a definition which we think incorporates all the paramount features of literary Style. We have noted that an appropriate definition of literary style must take note of the fact that literary style is both lingual and extralingual.

Activity

With illustrations, attempt a definition of the term 'Style' and explain why you prefer your particular definition to others.

Lecture two

THE EVOLUTION OF STYLISTICS

Introduction

The interest in language manipulation for effective communication is not a recent phenomenon. This interest has been in existence for as long as man has lived. However, a professional interest in deftness and skill in communication is said to have begun around 465 B.C. in the form of Oratory or 'Rhetoric'. In this lecture we will look at the evolution of Stylistics from such humble beginnings to its present status. We will endeavour to show the relevance of the rhetorical precepts in modern Stylistics.

Lecture Objectives

At the end of this Lecture you should be able to:

- (a) Define the term 'Rhetoric'
- (b) Relate the term to Literary Appreciation
- (c) Recognize the developments / modifications that have taken place in Stylistics.

RHETORIC

What is Rhetoric?

In the introduction, we have said that Stylistics is an old discipline which started in the form of Rhetoric. Now what is 'rhetoric'? In a wide loose sense, Edward Corbett defines Rhetoric as the art of effective communication. However general the foregoing definition may appear, that rhetoric is considered an art, then the term rhetoric demands employment of certain skills in communication; skills that empower the communicator to make judicious choices of the means in order to attain a desired goal. **Choice** is a key issue in Rhetoric. When there is no other option, we are probable in a realm where we have to do something

in a singular, invariable way. The word **communication** means 'to make one with'. When we say that we communicate with other persons, we are intimating that through words or other available sets of symbols or actions, we are in a sense making those other people at one with us. We are employing symbols or actions to make some person comprehend or appreciate our thoughts and feelings. When that state of at-oneness is not totally achieved, we are still 'at odds' with one another. In other words, our communication has not been wholly effective. In some way we have failed to make the right choice of the means of transmitting our message to someone.

The word 'Rhetoric' has its genesis in Greek philosophy and can be traced back ultimately to the simple assertion 'I say' (*eiros* in Greek). Almost anything related to the act of saying something to someone ± in speech or in writing ± can conceivably fall within the domain of rhetoric as a field of study. In ancient Greece and Rome, Rhetoric or 'technē rhetorikē' alluded purely to oratorical skills in all regards since oratory was highly valued as a mode of not only communication but also argumentation and persuasion.

Indeed, 'technē rhetorikē' was equated to the 'art of speech'. Oratory was the art of swaying an audience by eloquent speech. Rhetoric meant the art of composing as well as delivering a speech.

Oratory first appeared in the law courts of Athens and eventually became important in all aspects of life.

The major classical definition of rhetoric is that of Aristotle: 'The faculty of finding in a situation all available means of persuasion'. Rhetoric was born in Sicily in about 465 B.C. Subsequent to a revolution in Syracuse, which led to property feuds that were arbitrated by argumentation in courts of law, the need for professional instructors of judicial oratory was nourished. The classical analyses of rhetoric were all developed with almost exclusive reference to the role of persuasion. Hence Aristotle recognized three major types of Rhetoric determined by function:

- (a) The deliberative
- (b) Judicial / Forensic
- (c) Epideictic

The deliberative form of rhetoric was geared at moving an audience such as a legislature to endorse or disapprove a matter of public policy. The forensic form of rhetoric was mostly used in law courts to achieve as in a trial condemnation or approval for a person's actions. The last form of rhetoric, the epideictic, also known as display rhetoric, was used only on ceremonial occasions to display one's command of the rhetorical art. Aristotle also analyzed three modes of persuasion:

- (a) *logos* ± logical
- (b) *pathos* ± emotional
- (c) *ethos* ± ethical

The *logos* mode gives rational support to an argument. *Pathos* entails emotional defense in argumentation. *Ethos* is that which contributes to the speaker's credibility and appearance of trustworthiness.

In order to achieve his / her aim, a speaker had to know what was imperative to do. Aristotle therefore organized the task of the orator under five basic titles that encapsulate the indispensable ingredients for persuading an audience:

- (a) Invention
- (b) Arrangement
- (c) Language
- (d) Memory
- (e) Delivery

Invention

Rhetoric was concerned with discovering arguments and proofs that would of essence contribute to persuasion.

Arrangement

Organization of the discussions / points in a pattern conducive to persuasion was seen as paramount.

Language

A rhetorician had to know how to choose his language carefully and deliberately in a manner that would contribute to the most forceful presentation of arguments.

Memory

Since rhetoricians emphasized on oratorical skills, it was inevitable that the orator had to train him / herself to hold such arguments in memory.

Delivery

The ultimate task of the orator was that of ensuring that he / she gave the most compelling, spirited oral presentation of the proofs to a populace that relied heavily upon the voice for articulation of one's emotions and viewpoint.

On language, the rhetoricians emphasized four stylistic virtues:

- (a) Clarity
- (b) Correctness
- (c) Propriety
- (d) Ornamentation

An orator has to be clear in order to be understood. Communication, as we mentioned before, is the essence of an utterance. Applied to literature, obscurity only leads to lack of readership of one's literary art. Art that does not communicate is useless. Correctness in communication is what leads to credibility on the part of the orator / author. A speaker should check his facts. A writer who decides to borrow from historical or political occurrences, even while re-organizing that which was real, must of essence maintain the basic truth for plausibility. Propriety alludes to etiquette in language. A good orator or literary writer will steer clear of obscenities. Rhetoricians emphasized on using respectable language; language that is not offending. Adornment in speech / writing is essential in order to appeal to an audience. For example, figures of speech and symbols in speech and literary writings have the power to communicate more forcefully and effectively than ordinary language.

In Literature, the above-mentioned rhetorical principles provided some kind of framework from which a literary work could be fashioned.

The History and Evolution of Rhetoric

Certain Stylistic devices were developed by the judicial orators of the fifth century B.C.: figures of speech, schemes and tropes. These techniques were employed not only in structuring and clarifying arguments but also most importantly in appealing to audiences and eliciting all shades of emotions. Over the years, the significance of memory and delivery declined as written forms of argument increased. Style, more so its analysis through the classification of linguistic devices and patterns came to be the most important constituent of rhetoric. During the Renaissance, especially under the influence of Peter Ramus, language patterns and other devices became increasingly identified with the entire Rhetorical act. In this regard, rhetoric was simply viewed as the art of speaking well (*bene disendi*). The study of language patterning under the heading *elocutio* (style) was one of the five major aspects of Rhetoric. Others mentioned earlier were *Inventio* (the finding of topics), *dispositio* (the arrangement of ideas), *memory* (prepared, not spontaneous oration) and pronunciation and delivery (enunciation, which included accompanying gestures / body movements etc.)

Rhetoric has had a long career in the curricular of ancient and modern schools. During the Middle Ages, along with grammar and logic, Rhetoric made the basic Trivium of medieval academic study. The Trivium was a medieval curriculum consisting of Astronomy, Rhetoric and Logic. Rhetoric was therefore one of the major courses of study in the European educational curriculum, one of the seven liberal arts, closely allied to the other communication skills of grammar and dialectic. Rhetoric became valuable training for would be writers, and public speakers, who applied techniques of practical criticism to earlier writers, fellow speakers, while at the same time composing their own works / powerful speeches. The intricate rhetorical systems indeed kept alive an interest in the kaleidoscope of forms of expression available at a writer's or speaker's disposal that could be aptly used to persuade an audience in manifold regards.

In England, the Renaissance added little to the already established Rhetorical concepts. All that books such as Sir Thomas Wilson's *The Arte of Rhetorique* (1533) and George Richard Puttenham's *Arte of English Poesie* (1589) did was simply to popularize rhetorical practices.

As rhetorical studies became more closely related with written texts, they became distinct from a study of spoken discourse. However, many scholars continued to emphasize on linguistic eloquence, the medium of delivery disregarding. Hence, characters speaking within mimetic discourses, whether prose fiction, drama or poetry, were constantly judged for their rhetorical choices vis a vis the subject matter and the intention of the writer as determined from these choices. It is in the same regard that George Campbell, in *Philosophy of Rhetoric* (1776) equates rhetoric to eloquence: 'art or talent by which discourse is adapted to its end'. Campbell consider four crucial rhetorical ends:

- (a) to enlighten the understanding of an audience
- (b) to please the imagination of an audience
- (c) to move the passions of the audience
- (d) to influence the will of the audience

N/B Audience here may be a reader or listener

The twentieth century saw a continued broadening of the concept of rhetoric. On the one hand, in consonance with the identification of rhetoric with the study of prose composition, rhetoric has increasingly become the preferred term for the principles of good writing.

In modern education, rhetoric as a subject by itself has largely evanesced. However, as a phrase of study in English courses, the term is still respected and persists in debating and oratorical contexts.

Just like in classical times, rhetorical principles are still utilized (even if it be unconsciously) in four main areas ± Politics, Religion, Law and Literature. In Politics, for example, Winston Churchill, Malcolm X, Martin Luther King Jr., among other renown world leaders, were known and are still remembered for their powerful political speeches / writings. Martin Luther King Jr.'s 1963 poetic speech christened 'I have a Dream' is a case in point.

The phrase 'empty rhetoric' is said to have been born subsequent to the political tyranny and iniquity of two of the world's most infamous leaders: Hitler and Mussolini. Both leaders are said to have been unquestionably exceptionally eloquent. However, because of their discredited political ideologies, their good oratorical skills were eventually associated with their criminal political visions of and approach to life, thus bringing any form of grandiloquent oratory into disrepute in totality. Subsequently, the phrase 'mere / empty rhetoric' has similarly been linked to verbose politicians, who only talk while initiating insignificant or no development.

However, in Literature, rhetorical precepts continue to play a central role in literary analysis. Indeed, negligible literary types (if any) have escaped rhetorical influence. Indeed, the identification and practice of rhetoric and poetics continues when concern for style predominates. It must also be emphasized that rhetoric did not end at language manipulation. Rhetoric was interested in the form / style as it relates to the function. Hence we could authoritatively argue that modern Stylistics is indeed nothing but a replacement of traditional Rhetoric. Stylistics is therefore but new rhetoric attuned to the expectations and demands of modern scholarship in Linguistics as well as in Literature.

Rhetoric and Literature

The relationship between Literature and rhetoric is one that is in manifold respects intertwined. The most effective way of establishing this relationship is by deriving it from the definitions of the two terms. Kenneth Burke's redefinition of Rhetoric will suffice: 'the use of language in such a way as to produce desired impression upon the hearer or reader'. In tandem with the definition, effective Literature could be nothing but rhetoric, now that Literature is defined as imaginative art which survives on imagination and creative manipulation of language. Wilbur Samuel Howell contends that Literature embraces both rhetoric and poetics. Howell argues that rhetoric produces 'Literature of statements' while poetics is responsible for 'Literature of Symbols'.

Terry Eagleton's Marxist-oriented theory of Literature recommends a shift from 'literary theory' to rhetoric because:

rhetoric saw speaking and writing not merely as textual objects to be aesthetically contemplated, or endlessly deconstructed, but as forms of activity, inseparable from wider social relations between writers and readers, orators and audiences, and as largely intelligible outside social conditions and purposes in which they were embedded (p. 206)

Presently, emphasis has come to fall more on the descriptive aspects of literary style, the detailed explication of texts rather than on the teaching of composition. While standard manuals of literary techniques and composition abound and are indeed instrumental as points of reference in both literary composition and criticism, they cannot provide the kind of insight and literary intricacy that the modern society demands. Hence, the literary manuals are crucially supplemented; actually, work in cahoots with established, solid literary theories in order to give Literature the depth it deserves in scholarly evaluation. These theories furnish a literary scholar with a deeper understanding of how literary language operates. Thematically, the theories indicate how the sociological, political, historical, psychological and other aspects of society impact on literary creation and why

one needs to understand all these aspects as they appertain to the society mirrored in a literary work in order to be able to objectively critique and fathom the work of art.

Writing about Literature is certainly not different from writing about life, notwithstanding that Literature and life are essentially distinctly different. Writing about either art or life is an endeavour to unravel meanings and relate them to ourselves while at the same time deepening the horizon of the meanings by applying and making them significant to others. An essay pronounces its point; Literature connotes its point. Hence, to write about Literature, one must first discover, and decide for himself / herself, what it is about ± what points or ideas does it imply or act out?

Writing imaginative Literature entails inventing, selecting, arranging and expressing. These points correspond to the aspects of rhetoric ± invention, arrangement, style, memory and delivery. Probably at this stage, Literature and Rhetoric combine and become one and the same thing. However, what makes writing about Literature special unlike writing about other forms of rhetorical communication is that literary criticism / analysis deals with a rainbow of subject-matter but which follows certain established rules of style and form. Literary discourses are concerned with content and form of a text and how each impacts upon the other. In literary discussions, your principal point of reference as a literary scholar will be the text itself. You may supplement what the text tells you with what your experience or reading instructs you about: the author's background, history of the literary epoch at hand, the type of Literature, other sociological aspects that may contribute to clear understanding of the text and many more. However, in the final analysis, the content that will matter is that which either derives from the text itself or is rationalizable purely from the textual evidence.

In writing about Literature, you will be engaged in one of the following activities:

- (a) analyzing the text
- (b) interpreting the text and
- (c) evaluating the text

All these activities will require adequate knowledge in apt rhetorical principles in order to do justice to a literary work in the three areas.

Just like Rhetoric has a certain meticulous order from invention to delivery, so has Literary writing ± from generation of ideas to the final text which could be delivered orally or in print. What matters in both cases is:

- (a) Is the material worth reading or listening to? Does it appeal to our sensory system owing to its objectivity and convincing arguments?
- (b) Can it persuade an audience?
- (c) Does the text serve its purpose effectively by delivering its subject matter?

In this sense then, modern Stylistics can be seen as a development of the main branch of rhetorical study, namely, *elocutio*, with its interest in the relations between Form and Content, and concentration on the analysis of characteristic features of literary expression. Not surprisingly thus, the term rhetoric has come to be used in modern literary theory in new senses which reflect modern perspectives. Literature and rhetoric are indeed essentially complementary to one another. It is in this respect that the novel; the most elaborate literary genre has been seen as a rhetorical structure where there is space and time for display of the greatest powers of the mind.

Summary

In this Lecture we have looked at the development of Stylistics. We saw that the interest in Style, especially verbal is not a modern day thing; it is over two thousand centuries old. We looked at the concerns of the early rhetoricians in creation and communication / delivery. Rhetoricians emphasized creativity and delivery capable of persuasion owing to the facts therein, language manipulation, while at the same time steering clear of profanities. We have also seen how the rhetorical principles were eventually applied in writing generally. Lastly, we looked at the relationship between rhetoric and Literature.

Activity

What is 'Rhetoric' and how does it contribute to our appreciation of Literary Style?

Lecture three

FORM AND CONTENT

Introduction

In the last two lectures we looked at Style in Literature and Rhetoric. In both Lectures we observed that the element of technique goes hand in hand with the message being conveyed. Hence the question in literary writing is not just 'what' is being communicated but 'how' it is being communicated. We usually tend to emphasize on 'what', that is, the issues that a literary work contains or propagates at the expense of how the issues are brought to the fore. An interpretation of literary matter that endeavours to compartmentalize these two core aspects as if they could subsist apart from each other is utterly erroneous.

In this Lecture we will endeavour to show how form and content in Literature are inseparable entities and how a fruitful analysis of Literature demands an approach that investigates how each of these aspects impacts upon the other.

Lecture Objectives

At the end of this Lecture you should be able to:

- (a) Define the word 'form' from a purely literary perspective
- (b) Show why form determines or affects content by showing how the relationship between the two decides / defines meaning in literary texts.

The Relationship Between Form and Content in Literature

'Matter is expressed in manner'

The above words by Wordsworth succinctly capture the inextricable relationship between form and content. That is, as much as we may want to harp only on the ideas being disseminated as if Literature were merely a cluster of messages, content cannot be expressed through nothingness. Content cannot

just mysteriously fall from heaven like manna. Content in Literature can only be expressed through utilization of particular linguistic items in a particular way. This means that without form, there is no content. On the other hand, you cannot just have a form that conveys nothingness. Style has to convey or be made of some content. Many a times we emphasize on one of the two aspects at the expense of the other. We virtually become blinded to 'what' or 'how'. For instance, while in Literature many of us have a bias for what is being said rather than how it is being said, in other areas of life, we tend to emphasize on the form. Think of the mother who purchases cheap, adulterated, unprocessed, back street milk simply because of the volume given for a few shillings. At this juncture, this mother does not care about the nutritional value of the milk. She is merely gratified by the fact that she is buying a lot for very little. In this regard, her obsession is on the quantity (form) rather than quality (content). In similar areas of life, we do the same. We will spend a fortune on that eye-catching or flashy pair of shoes, dress, cellphone, car or whatever else that seems really physically attractive only to regret later that the physically fascinating item belied some shockingly inferior material. We are easily cheated because we are more interested in exquisite form, uncaring about the content. As human beings, we are so weakened to the 'how' that even in really serious issues like selecting a lifetime partner, we end up making the same mistake. Many of us, especially males, have a weakness for physical beauty to the extent that we wouldn't care for anything else. Being seen with a beautiful spouse is all we may care for. That is all we need to gratify our bloated egos and raise our heads high. And you bet innumerable men have been forced to either suffer peacefully at the hands of their good-looking dinosaurs just for the sake of their befogged egos, or have been forced to swallow their pride and seek a less attractive (physically, of course) but compatible spouse.

The errors we make in literary analysis are therefore 'normal' mistakes that percolate into other spheres of life. In spite of this, we do not have to continue making such mistakes. We have to coach ourselves to consider both aspects in all decisions we make. This is because everything that exists has a form and a content. Many times we have to think of the balance between the form and content of whatever we want. Just like in Literature an aesthetically beautiful text would be that which is beautifully woven so that the marriage between the form and content is impeccable, so it is in life. A beautiful house is remarkable in both the physical design and the material employed. If the architectural design is spectacular yet the material is calamitously defective, such a house cannot constitute anything close to the essence of the word 'beauty'. If the material is reputedly good yet the design is detestably horrific, again such a house cannot be considered beautiful in whatever regard. It is in the same respect that a beautiful woman would not be the angelic face outrightly devoid of a speck of moral uprightness or 'the queen of the universe' exterior but whose intellectual emptiness can only fathom FGM (female genital mutilation) as the acronym of some quaint wild vegetable found in the Amazon forest.

We cannot therefore over-emphasize the importance of both the 'what' and 'how' in all that we do.

Semantics as the Sole Offspring of the literary marriage between Form and Content

Ultimately, what matters most in the relationship between form and content is the meaning garnered. In Stylistics, the level that deals with meaning in Literature is called Semantics. In Linguistics, Semantics is a discipline; theoretical and scientific interpretation of signs and sign systems and their meanings, specifically those involved with communication between human beings in different societies and cultures. Derived from a Greek word ³*sema*, Semantics, also called Semiotics, means Sign. In Linguistics, Semantics covers verbal language in different media of speech and writing as well as non-verbal communication systems such as gestures and kinesics (body movements).

The theoretical foundation of Semiology / Semiotics owes much to the structuralist preoccupation of Saussure, with the process of signification (Semiosis), the relation between the signifier (expression or form) and the signified (concept / idea). These are the two components of a sign.

In Literature, we approach Semantics by seeking to explain the relationship between the linguistic or extra-linguistic item and its artistic function. In studying Semiotics, we aim to answer three main questions:

- (a) what?
- (b) How?
- (c) Why?

That is:

- (a) what exactly is being communicated?
- (b) what mechanics have been employed to facilitate this communication?
- (c) Why a particular technique as opposed to another?

The clarity in the employment of a linguistic or extra-lingual device in Literature inevitably leads to clarity in meaning. The distinction between what a writer has to say and how it is presented to the reader / audience, indeed underlies one of the most pertinent conception of style ± style as a dress of thought. The literary critic seeks to establish the meaning of a word, clause, phrase, sentence, paragraph, and chapter and how each of these components, whether grammatical or deviant, correlates to form a literary whole. While discussing Style, we noted that in Literature style is purely a question of choice. No aspect of literary art ought to be accidental. Subsequently, all features in a literary text will exist only in as far as they add value to the semantic content of a text. That is, all linguistic and extra-linguistic components in a literary text will be employed purposely to cooperate and ultimately in this cooperation, aid in comprehending a literary text. Hence, semantics is a study of form and content because to understand meaning one has to look at the legitimate progeny of form and content. This legitimate scion can only be

seen and comprehended at the level of Semantics. It is like looking at the intricacies of man and the many mysteries of the world in order to understand the complexity of the maker ± God.

Form and Meaning in Literature

The aim of any literary author is to communicate. The link between him / her and the reader is the art form itself. Hence, with this in mind, the writer selects a suitable style to express his / her views about something. The reader, then, reads, digests, and responds back. His response will depend on three major variables as given by Emmanuel Ngara (1982:14)

- (i) The nature of the utterance ± what the author says and how he says it.
- (ii) The reader's own competence and experience in appreciating literary works of art.
- (iii) The usefulness of the method(s) and approach (es) adopted by the reader.

For a reader to respond profitably to a piece of writing, the writer must employ a style or form that necessitates forceful and clear internalization of the message by the reader.

The word 'form' has been defined variously by both linguists and literary critics. In Linguistics, form is defined as a level of language; its structure consisting of the phonological, syntactic and lexical patterns which express content or meaning. Thus, form is seen to mediate between the levels of expression and content. However, Linguists make an elementary distinction between form and content: that form deals with the structural characteristics of the sentence, clause, phrase and word, whereas content deals with the meaning of the grammatical structure. In Literary criticism, form extends to non-linguistic items to incorporate even aspects of generic consideration.

A general interest in the formal features in a text led to the emergence of the Russian school of Formalism in the 1920s. This school of criticism emphasized on the stylistic features of texts, defining the literary work as a form in itself. A concern with form in the linguistic sense is also prominent in Structuralism. Such schools of thought conceive of literary texts as a bundle of linguistic devices; that is, Literature is all about manipulation of language. Such critics equate the medium in Literature to the message itself ± that form is content. Even in Linguistics, the distinction between form and content has been questioned. Formalized as the surface and deep structures of Generative grammar, these levels have been shown to exhibit considerable overlaps.

It is in the same sense that it is argued in Literary Stylistics that changing a form will automatically generate either different meanings or loss or gain or forcefulness or objectivity, depending with the circumstances obtaining initially. Even though with the

common notions of synonymy and paraphrase, we contend that the same content may be effectively relayed in different forms, the forcefulness and vividness will never be exactly the same. This is why writers choose one option as opposed to another. They believe that they can only be much more effective by selecting a particular option. Form in Literature should therefore never be taken for granted.

The principal aspects of form in Literature are five:

- (a) Structure
- (b) Plot
- (c) Characterization
- (d) Mode
- (e) Language

Now we will look at each of these facets one by one and establish their importance in carrying content and ultimately conveying meaning.

Structure

Structure in Literature refers to the planned physical and internal framework of a literary work. Structure in Literature therefore exists at two levels: (a) external and (b) internal. Whereas the external structure alludes to the actual visible shape or pattern, internal structure looks at how the ideas at hand are developed from stanza to stanza (in a poem) or from sentence to sentence, paragraph to paragraph, chapter to chapter (in prose). The writer may choose to focus on variant perspectives of the same subject matter in the different stanzas or

paragraphs / chapters respectively, dovetailing into a standpoint, consensus, middle ground. This standpoint, consensus, middle ground, will be the apex of the internal structural development. Very often the internal structure will be related to the external in many ways. It is in this regard that poets will usually use stanzas as not only rhythmic units but also as thematic units, saluting unified concerns.

Just like the scheme of topics will determine the structure of a formal essay, any divisions in literary texts have to be logical ± that is, purposive and contributing to the meaning(s). A good writer establishes a physical plan that is logical and thereby secures clarity. A writer may shape a poem in the shape of a coffin to 'shock' the reader into recognition of the content. While the reader may think he / she has actually noticed early enough what the content may be, the content may not be as telling as he / she thought. The persona could be talking of some moral, religious, political, psychological or any other type of 'abnormal' demise, which may necessitate keen reading on the part of the reader in order to decipher.

The structure would therefore have helped in exciting the reader's mind to try and establish the relationship between the form and content. Such a structure would therefore, in a way, have contributed to clarity. The following poem, 'Visions and Prayer' by Dylan Thomas is an excellent example:

Who Are
 You Who is born
 In the next room So loud
 to my own
 That I can hear the womb
 Opening and the dark run
 Over the ghost and the dropped son Behind
 the wall thin as a wren's bone? In the birth
 bloody room unknown
 To the burn and turn of time And the
 hear print of man
 Bows no Baptism But
 dark alone Blessing
 on
 The wild
 Child.

This poem has a curious shape. It demonstrates a symbolic visual shape, a kind of graphological onomatopoeia, which is deliberately, employed by the author to suggest movement - in this case, motions of labour before and when a child is being born. In the creation of this poem, Dylan Thomas decides to deviate from the expected syntactic construction in order to enhance clarity by using a shape that may give a gist of the content. The searing womb movements are suggested by the extension of the lines outwards. The sudden relief that comes after the child is born is intimated in the form of lines reducing in size and finally settling in 'Child' (the very last word) ± an announcement that the child is finally with us.

Shape / Structural patterning can therefore be employed fruitfully in poetry to enhance meaning. As in the employment of onomatopoeia, those words that imitate sound, poets may choose shapes that have definite aesthetic appeals for their interpretation as reflecting an aspect of reality ± such as child birth, as in the example above ± or simply conveying meaning resident in the physical shape itself. For instance, in the illustration from Dylan Thomas, the image of childbirth does not end at merely suggesting the amount of pain that accompanies the exertion that comes with the child leaving the womb; the shape itself does also suggest a woman's legs spread apart, whose extremes are indicated by line 9 ± a point from which the baby starts its way out and is consequently received in the very terminal line ± 'Child'.

Structure in poetry can therefore powerfully contribute to semantic interpretation of a poem. We also mentioned in our first year Introduction to Literary Genre course that poets would use different types of stanzas depending on the issues at hand. Monostanzaic poems would tell a connected story. Multi- stanzaic poems would express diversity in theme. The physical structure in that regard will have facilitated in a way in gaining prior knowledge.

Charles Dickens divides the novel *Hard Times* into three sections: (i) Sowing, (ii) Reaping and (iii) Garnering. Each section is composed of many chapters. Even before reading the novel, the reader already knows that there will be sowing, reaping and garnering. However, what the reader does not know is what exactly is being sowed, reaped or garnered. He / she has to read the novel in order to see the connection. In reading the novel, the reader will be eager to see the relationship between the purposive sectioning and the ideas in the book. In this regard, the structure would have contributed to not only an element of suspense on the part of the reader, but also would have peeled the outer cover of the novel so that in reading, the reader would be involved in an enterprise of dissecting the anatomy of the text in order to comprehend the sections clearly. And what he realizes eventually is that what are being sowed are not seeds for crops or plants but seeds of despair, stubbornness, inhumanity, thievery, confusion, contempt, pride and many other vices. Because of the fact that all the seeds are actually putrid, the resultant crops are equally smelly. When the harvest is rancid, what can one garner except the very same putrescence?

In Richard Wright's *Native Son*, the structure is also similar to what we see in *Hard Times*. There are also three main sections in the novel regardless of the many chapters: (i) Fear, (ii) Flight and (iii) Fate. These three words encapsulate the very existence of the Negroes (read African Americans) prior to their second emancipation. Fear was the air that they breathed to an extent that African Americans like Bigger Thomas would end up committing serious crimes like murder inadvertently, as a result of sheer *fear*. Thus, *flight* was their very home now that their very existence was considered a loathsome historical accident. And because they were unwanted in all regards, their *fate* was always sealed whether guilty or not. The three sections in *Native Son* therefore summarize the diverse themes in the novel in all regards.

Very crucial in the physical planning of a literary text is the very label the text has been bestowed. The importance of titles in texts cannot be over-emphasized. Literary writers rarely follow the grammatical rule about titles ± that a title must be satisfactorily illustrative of the content of a text. Literary writers will mostly choose titles that are enigmatic and curious at the same time. This is a good strategy to lure readers into reading a text in order to discover how the title is related to the content or vice-versa. Reading a literary work therefore becomes an endeavour to uncover a jigsaw puzzle and thereby being able to understand a text better. Titles such as: 'Devils on the Cross', 'Murogi wa Kagogo' (The Wizard of the Crow) or 'A Grain of Wheat' (all novels by Ngugi Wa Thiong'o) or 'Shrine of Tears', 'The Married Bachelor' (Works by Francis Imbuga) or 'I know why the Caged Bird Sings' by Maya Angelou are baffling titles which demand that a reader reads a text keenly with a view to comprehending such confounding titles. One would ask ± If the devil is surely being crucified, so what? Wasn't the cross originally for the utter wrong doers? Hence, doesn't the devil deserve the scaffold or worse by all means? However, now that the symbol of the cross in Christian circles is associated with the salvation of man through the death of Jesus Christ on the cross, then 'Devil on the Cross' as a title becomes a semantic absurdity, a ludicrous yet though-provoking title. We have to read the novel to understand the sense in the seemingly nonsensical title. What about 'A Grain of Wheat'? Did Ngugi expend all his energies in writing such a voluminous text just to talk about some

grain of wheat? Surely, could Ngugi have written a whole novel just on a grain of wheat? Once again we have to read the novel in order to understand what Ngugi is talking about. As for Maya Angelou's title 'I know why the Caged Bird Sings' we get the same feeling of a desire to know what she is talking about. On reading the novel, however, you don't see any bird singing at any point. However, as you progress towards the climax of the novel, you come to understand that the caged bird is actually the female person.

In all the examples given, the perplexing titles have the psychological effect of playing with our emotions by raising our curiosity about the text(s). The level of incongruity or preposterousness of a literary title notwithstanding, the choice of a title in literary art is an aesthetic choice. Hence, the reader must endeavour to relate the 'crazy' or 'foolish' title to the content. It is only by doing so that the reader will apprehend a literary text fully.

Some modes of writing are also clearly visible right from the physical shape. One example is the epistolary novel. Such a novel is written in the form of letters. The fact that such novels are written in letters will say a lot about the content. Letters can be very formal or informal. Hence, they are either reserved or very open depending on the relationship between the addresser and addressee. In spite of this, all letters are usually personal. The addresser says all that he / she can say depending on the circumstances. If it is a bank customer who is unable to service his / her loan for some time, he / she will be brutally frank about the prevailing difficulties that hamper his repayment programme. If it is a company retrenchee pleading for reconsideration, again, he / she may get into personal matters to appeal to the management. A letter from a friend to a fellow friend, relative to another relative will be characterized by a lot of freedom. One would say all he / she can say without any inhibitions. The personal nature of a letter indeed emanates from the fact that the addresser intends and therefore expects that it is only the addressee who will be privy to the 'outpourings' in the letter even if that is not always the case. An official letter to a company manager will have been read by the secretary, personal assistant and even other officers before it gets to the real addressee. Even after being read by the addressee, it may be referred to other officers for action. All these disregarding, the addresser will only have intended a particular person to read the letter. In this respect, the personal nature of letters in all regards cannot be over-emphasized. Consequently, when the external structure of a literary text clearly indicates an epistolary design, then a reader would be correct to conclude on the 'personal' themes of the text even before reading it. In anything 'personal', one expects 'brutal' frankness. In this sense, the physical design would have, in a big way, contributed towards a reader's partial comprehension of a text. However, it is in reading the text itself that the reader will discern the nitty-gritty of the 'personal' themes. Also, it is in reading the text itself that the reader may discover that the 'personal' themes are essentially ubiquitous and that good writers only focus on the individual while talking about the general / universal at the same time. This is what we see when we read both Mariana Ba's *So Long a Letter* and Alice Walker's *The Color Purple*. The female protagonists in both texts actually speak for all the sub humanized, slighted and inferiorized women of the world.

Looking at our discussion on how structure contributes towards content and meaning, we have essentially seen that just like the constructions of sentences in Literature, which must be created in a logical manner that brings out a flow of thought, whether by setting clauses in sharp contrast with their predecessors as in the case of antithetical statements; whether by assembling a number of syntactically parallel elements that ultimately lead to a concrete conclusion, whether by introducing a general idea and then deducing a number of concomitants that emanate from it, structure in Literature too must encapsulate the basic, logical foundation of meaning. This must always be the case even where there seems evident illogicality. In such a case, we must endeavour to establish the logicity of an illogical structure. For instance, Francis Imbuga in his play Aminata gives Agege words whose logical thread is shattered:

Agege: Too much fire! (Notices the grave) You see,
you see, you see! Headman how do you see
now? Too much fire! That is what
I say, always. A grave? No problem. Get cement proper, add
water plus sand, basi. Koroga, koroga, together all! Result?
Long lasting permanganent grave, finish!

Jumba: Stop that ranting you idiot. I was talking to men.

Agege: Men? And me? Me you call woman?
Too much fire! Alright show me breast of woman on my
body now « if you call me idiot, why send me also? And also
you call me woman in addition. Idiot and woman, double. So
I say two plus two is four, and I refuse.

In the above excerpt, it is quite clear from Agege's language, his poor command of the English language notwithstanding, that Agege is mentally distempered owing to the fathomable but illogical structure of his utterances. For example he talks of seeing too much 'fire' when nobody else can. It is as if in seeing the grave, he sees the imaginary fire. It is only later that we deduce that the fire Agege is talking about is symbolic, basically, sociopolitical. As regards cementing Ngoya's grave, Agege suggests that getting cement, adding water plus sand would do the thing. Firstly, the formula here is wrong. You do not add water to cement then put sand. The formula is therefore irrational. Secondly, Agege chooses to ignore the traditional significance of cementing a grave. It is not just the physical activity that demands concrete, cement, water and sand. Cementing a grave in most traditional African communities (even though the practice came with the advent of the white man into Africa), is still a religio-cultural rite that demands more than just the physical deeds on or by the grave. This is why the physical presence of the first-born son of Pastor Ngoya, Ababio, is accorded a lot of importance. Many other rituals also accompany the cementing of the grave. In this regard, Agege's simplistic formula to a crucial issue is illogical, once more. Looking at Agege's utterances again, we do not see the relationship between his mathematical additions $\pm$ two plus two is four $\pm$ and his outrage at being insulted twice (³'double'). All these seemingly

driveling utterances lend credence to Agege's mental disposition while at the same time making these utterances stand out prominently. The eccentric nature of these statements startles our intellect. A question that pricks our mind every time Agege 'drivels' is why Imbuga would make such a 'driveller' a recurrent, therefore, evidently significant character in his play. Thus, Imbuga invites us to see if we can make sense out of the 'idiotic' ejaculations of the character Agege.

In the following passage from James Joyce's *Ulysses*, the writer also ignores the expected logical sequence in order to convey the drifts of sensations through Molly Bloom's mind, as she lies in bed, unable to get sleep:

« A quarter after what unearthly hour I suppose they're just getting up in China now combing out their pigtails for the day we'll soon have the nuns ringing the angelus, they've nobody coming in to spoil their sleep except an odd priest or two for his night office the alarm clock next door at cockshout clattering the brains out of itself let me see if I doze off 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 what kind of flowers are those invented like the stars, the wall paper In Lombard street was much nicer the apron he gave me was like that something only I wore it twice better lower this lamp and try again so as I can get up early «

The illogical structure of the passage above where ideas are haphazardly mixed up, where ideas are left hanging, never completed before moving on to the next, realistically brings out the psychic prowling that characterizes a person's mind at a time of sleeplessness. At such a time, grammatical considerations like clarity, completeness, that necessitate use of proper punctuation, do not arise and therefore such requirements are suspended. The mind simply wanders randomly and unexpectedly into the unexpected. There could be no better way of expressing such a mental ramble except through suspension of logical grammatical demands.

Note

Even when the structure of a literary text appears fundamentally logical, you should not expect that it would be very simple. You should know that a considerable amount of aesthetic pleasure comes from the judicious or astounding use of intellect. Quite simple thoughts may be embellished in the most astonishing and imposing ways. No matter the situation, without first comprehending the rational structure of a literary text under consideration, everything else will be out of perspective.

Activity

Using any literary works of your choice, show how structure facilitates meaning.

Plot

Plot is another very crucial aspect of form. Emmanuel Ngara (1982: 16) calls it the 'backbone of a work of art'. Plot holds the various elements of a literary work together and indeed gives the text a structure. But what is plot? Plot is an intellectual formulation about relationships among the incidents in a text. It is a sequence of events arranged in a timechain from beginning to end. Most importantly, the events have a causal relationship with one another. In other words, one event leads to and determines another. In a nutshell then, plot alludes to chronological order of events in a literary text. The plot consists of characters performing actions that interconnect to embrace a single whole and complete action. The interconnection involves a tussle between two opposing forces. The opposition or conflict joins one incident to another, dictating the causal relationship, which reveals the struggle. Through the chronological flow of events, plot gives a literary work unity and cohesion. As readers, plot helps us to understand the content and meaning by taking us through the events one by one *ergo propter hoc* (this because of that) such that it would be possible for us to not only recount all the incidents and events that happen, but also to account for them. The main part of plot is to guide by imposing order upon content. When order is placed upon content, the meaning can easily be garnered subsequent to the flow of thoughts and events.

Let us look at the plot in Chinua Achebe's *Things Fall Apart*. In this novel, we meet Okonkwo, a man obsessed with masculinity; a man who literally loathes anything effeminate being associated with the progeny of Adam. Then the question comes to mind ± why that hatred? Why the obsession with masculinity? The plot of the novel provides the answers. Okonkwo's society emphasizes on masculinity, yet Okonkwo's own father, Unoka, was a disgrace, a weakling who never won any titles and who also died an abominable death. Besides the social expectations of a man, Okonkwo is at pains to obliterate the embarrassment that was his father from his psyche. He desires to be judged on his own terms and never to be compared with his indolent father. He therefore strives to carve a niche, indeed, to create an impregnable image of himself. He succeeds. He wins many titles as a wrestler and

becomes a respected elder in his community. However, his tragic flaw(s) (this being a tragic novel), intransigence and stubbornness, lead(s) him to making mistakes. He kills Ikemefuna, a boy who had learnt to call him father. Why? Okonkwo is still obsessed with the notion of never being seen to be effeminate at any point. He therefore kills the boy because of character weaknesses engendered by the cultural expectations of a man of his stature. Inwardly, Okonkwo is pained by the fact that he had to be the one to kill the lad Ikemefuna. Later, just as accidents do happen in life, Okonkwo kills a kinsman inadvertently. For this offence, the tradition demands that he has to be banished from the community for seven years. This requirement is executed and Okonkwo and his family have to move to his mother's ancestral place, Mbaino, for seven years. Now, seven years is more than enough time for one to lose touch with the on goings in the previous home. Thus, on coming back to Umuofia after seven years of absence, Okonkwo is at sea with himself. Enormous changes have taken place yet he is unable to reconcile himself with the changes that have occurred. His stubbornness and intransigence remain. He therefore tries to change the direction of things. He wants the society to revert to the old ways. He is also unhappy that the Umuofians have allowed the whites to come in and establish some kind of government, thus making the black people some kind of white people's subjects. In his rage, Okonkwo ends up killing a fellow African, a messenger whom he regards as a traitor, a servant of the whites. However, nobody is ready to espouse Okonkwo in his struggle to turn back the clock. He realizes that he is all alone in the struggle for anachronism. Everybody else desires to move forward. Many of the bad traditions have been discarded with only the good ones left intact. Many of the Umuofians have embraced Christianity. And the wheel of change seems unstoppable. The whirlwind of change is menacingly out to sweep out the obstinate. Okonkwo cannot reconcile his mind with the changes. He therefore chooses to end his life. Having all along endeavored to create an image of a cultural colossus for himself, with his myopia, intransigence and obstinacy, Okonkwo is eventually reduced to naught ± dying an abominable death just like his father, Unoka. The wheel of change has surely turned full circle for him.

What we see in the Plot of *Things Fall Apart* is that every event is explainable, accountable. Events rationally lead to one another until the very end. Nothing seems to fall from the moon. There is causality to every incident. That is the essence of plot in Literature.

Order, however, does not mean that a writer will employ an easy to follow sequential structure. In fact, Plot does not mean that simply because one event is necessitated by another, then one event will come immediately after another ± *ergo propter hoc* hence *ergo post hoc*. Indeed many experienced writers may present their stories in the form of flashbacks, taxing the reader's / audience's mind by frequently shifting to the past, then present, then back to the past. A novel like *In the Fog of the Seasons' End* by Alex La Guma cannot make sense devoid of the flashbacks. It is the flashbacks that veritably establish the plot. We can only understand where Elias Tekwane comes from in terms of his political inclination

and commitment to the fight for racial justice because of the flashbacks. The flashback inform us how, in his childhood, Elias Tekwane's family was uprooted from its fertile ancestral land and pushed to scrubby, stony, hilly, barren land where nothing could grow. Hence, Elias's family members had no choice but to depend solely on slaving for the white man. Through flashback, we are told of how when Elias Tekwane's father died in a mine accident alongside other white miners, Elias's widowed mother only received forty pounds as compensation whereas the widows of the deceased white miners received fifteen pounds per month for the rest of their lives. Elias Tekwane is therefore a person who has experienced the darkest ramifications of the discriminative apartheid system. We therefore understand his bitterness and why he joins the underground movement. We definitely comprehend why Elias Tekwane is very much ready to die for the liberation of black people in South Africa. Flashback in this case plays a very significant role in furnishing the plot with the necessary material that will lead to plausibility through apprehension of causality in all regards.

The play, *The Floods* by John Ruganda is another literary text whose plot cannot make sense without the information we get through the flashbacks. Just like in *In the Fog of the Seasons' End*, you will only understand the main characters (Bwogo and Nankya) fully through the flashbacks.

Remember

Plot does not refer to the mere sequence of events. Rather, Plot alludes to the chronological or causal sequence of events.

Activity

Illustrating from either John Ruganda's *The Floods* or Ngugi Wa Thiong'o's *A Grain of Wheat*, show how flashback is indispensable in the establishment of the Plot.

Characterization

In order to tell a story, a writer / narrator must have characters / actors even if they be animals as in the case of George Orwell's *Animal Farm*, or insects and other *invertebrata* as in the case of 'At Kinosaki' by the Japanese short story writer, Shiga Naoya.

Characterization refers to the actors in the 'drama' of a literary text; the participants in the volume; those imaginative creations of the author who interact with each other or 'with themselves' in the action of the text. The writer employs these participants as agents in his/ her communicative utterance. Characters in a literary text ought to appear so credible that they exist for the reader as real within the limits of the creative work.

Characterization is a very influential constituent of literary style, in fact, the very foundation of literary compositions. This is because, Literature is about imagined deeds, exploits and happenings or episodes with regard to certain characters, mainly, persons.

Characterization in Literature, just like other aspects of form, has all along been a deliberate enterprise, aimed at accomplishing specific objectives. Therefore, writers' preferences in terms of character-types should never be taken for granted. Rather, characterization in Literature should be viewed as an important vehicle through which the writer communicates his / her message. Aristotle (1934) recognizes that literary mimesis (imitation) always involves a rigorous selection of those objects which are deemed apt for imitation. Hence, an artist selects those facets of the subject which he / she wishes to treat in detail

and which suit his / her treatment of the chosen idea or matter. This is because, as Wilson Harris (1973) avers, everything in a literary work is intentionally geared at persuasion of the reader / audience. Characters in a literary text are also hinged more or less on the element of persuasion. An author's distinctive view of how people relate and how they ought to relate will be reflected in the representation of every character while other details such as status, dressing, manners, conversation, historical situations, and others, add to an author's view of the characters, who, as members of a society, are part of a broader pattern. Essentially then, characterization is the relationship of characters to content.

Because characterization is purposive and not accidental, the role of characters should enable the reader / audience to understand the subject-matter and themes better. Subsequently, characters in a literary text must never be mere statistics. Every character, however minor, must be seen to have a role in the overall thematic effect of a text so that when one reads Sembene Ousmane's *God's Bits of Wood* and encounters a gallery of women characters, this is explainable on the fact that each character is employed to exhibit some potentiality of the womenfolk. Together, then, the women characters demonstrate the latent abilities of the female human being who had all along been dismissed as a deficient, lesser person, who could not accomplish certain feats. On the other hand, some characters in Peter Abraham's *Mine Boy* appear to be mere statistics with no aesthetic value. Such characters include J.P. Williamson, that political enlightened person who only indulges in alcohol. What role does this character really play?

The element of plausibility of a character in a literary text cannot be overstated. We must be made to understand why the characters are the way they are. In Peter Abraham's *Mine Boy*, initially, we may dismiss the benevolent white man, Paddy O'shea as unbelievable. However, when we come to understand that he is a progeny of the Irish, that

group that suffered longest under various forms of colonial power ± the Danes, Norwegians and Anglo- Saxons ± then we begin to understand Paddy O¶shea as somebody who knows his history and who therefore apprehends how it feels to be subjugated and be subhumanized by fellow human beings. Paddy O¶shea¶s good nature is therefore not farfetched. However, in the same text, Xuma comes out as an incredible character. This is because his development is rushed. He comes to the village from the city and within a very short time he is so educated in the intricate politics of the urban centre that he becomes the educator, the ring leader in the political fight. The whole picture comes out as incredibly impossible.

There are three fundamental methods of characterization in Literature:

- (1) What does the author say about the character through narration and description?

This usually applies to prose fiction. For example in Rebeka Njau¶s *Ripples in the Pool*, Gikere¶s money-mindedness, which makes him easy prey to a moneyed woman, is presented through narration:

One morning, Selina left the house unobtrusively, and when she returned in the evening, she handed Gikere a small sealed envelope. He sat in front of a small table in the sitting room and opened it, his fingers trembling. Inside were clean, neatly folded bank notes, amounting to twenty thousand shillings. He looked at the notes, then at Selina, who was standing leaning against the door facing him, and swallowed several times before he could speak. Selina glared at him. Then her eyes went to the notes he was holding and back to his face again. Gikere gave her a kind of impersonal smile, then looked down immediately as though afraid to let her read what was going on in his mind. (p.69)

If the above is a mild indictment by the author of a man whose view of the world, and especially, marital relationships, is inverted, the following passage from *Hard Times* leaves no doubt what Dickens feels about the character named Bounderby:

Not being Mrs. Grundy, who was Mr. Bounderby? W hy, Mr. Bounderby was as near being Mr. Gradgrind¶s bosom friend, as a man perfectly devoid of sentiment can approach that spiritual relationship towards another man perfectly devoid of sentiment. So near was Mr. Bounderby ± or, if the reader should prefer it, so far off.

He was a rich man: banker, merchant, manufacturer and what not. A big, loud man, with a stare and metallic laugh. A man made out of a coarse material, which seemed to have been stretched to make so much of him. A man with a great puffed head and forehead, swelled veins in his temples, and such a strained skin to his face that

it seemed to hold his eyes open and lift his eyebrows up. A man with a pervading appearance on him of being inflated like a balloon, and ready to start. A man who could never sufficiently vaunt himself a self-made man. A man who was always proclaiming, through that brassy speaking-trumpet of a voice of his, his old ignorance and his old poverty. A man who was the bully of humility.

A year or two younger than his eminently practical friend, Mr. Bounderby looked older, his seven or eight and forty might have had the seven and eight added to it again, without surprising anybody. He had not much hair. One might have fancied he had talked it off; and that what was left, all standing up in disorder, was in that condition from being constantly blown about by his windy boastfulness.

From the description above, it is obvious where Dickens placed the haughty upper class of his days ± in the lowest rungs in the ladder of respect. Hence such a description of a character contributes immensely to content in that we garner the attitude of the writer while at the same time learning how the wealthy class viewed itself during the industrial revolution. We are told that the rich were the bullies of humility. Such a description no doubt paints a detestable picture of such a class to the reader. We as readers can never admire boastfulness.

- (2) Characters are also delineated through their actions towards others and what they say about others and themselves. Hence, whether in a novel the writer does not comment at all on the characters, the expectation of the writer is that the reader will be able to deduce the attributes of the character from his actions and talk. For example, Lucille in Janice Shinebourne's novel *The Last English Plantation* is presented as a brainwashed woman because of what she does and says. In spite of her lower class in the society, Lucille aspires for the highest white class and indeed sees her daughter, June, as a ladder to realization of her dreams. Lucille even impels her daughter to mimic Euro-centric accents in speaking English. At age twelve, June is cognizant of the fact that her own mother speaks English differently and she (June) is embarrassed of this fact. The portrayal of Lucille powerfully serves Janice Shinebourne well in bringing out the theme of Children's Rights. Shinebourne therefore lashes at despotic parents who may be too overbearing to the point of infringing on their children's rights. Lucille's alienated mind is further punctuated by her view of the lowest class ± the coolies. According to Lucille, Coolies are just good-for-nothing people; a human abashment that should not have been created in the first place:

they drink rum, they just eat and drink rum in their spare time, and beat their wives, and fight «Their wives cook from three

O'clock in the morning to late at night! « Coolie women have to carry all the burdens for the men, the burden of the sick, the old, the children, burying the dead, and get no thanks for it, only licks! And the women beat their daughters and treat them worse than the men treat them! Coolies pick up cow dung with their hands, bring up children with lies in their hair and feed up the lice with coconut oil. (p.128)

When a mother tells a daughter such words, she is evidently teaching her child to despise other people.

- (3) We also learn about characters through what others say about them or do to them. In ***Crick, Crack Monkey***, Merle Hodge lashes at irresponsible parents who have abdicated parental duties through the eyes of other characters ± how other characters view the bedlam such parents have created by allowing their progeny to grow up mannerless. Living with the Norman family, Tee considers the family head to be an escapist who has given up on properly training his children:

Uncle Norman struck me (Tee) as having at some previous date, retreated permanently before Auntie Beatrice's tireless initiative and talkativeness, or before the unbelievable propensity to rioting that engaged the rest of the household. Most of the time he was either absent or unnoticeable. When he was at work at home he spent a great deal of time outside doing something unspecified to the car. (p.120)

No matter the method of delineation, as we have seen, characterization will inevitably, inalienably contribute to the content in every respect.

Depending on how a character is presented, he or she can be deemed to be a round character or what we call a three-dimensional character (full, rich and complex) if all these aspects are reflected in his / her creation. On the other hand, if the writer seems to emphasize certain attributes at the expense of others, then such a character will come out as

a caricature; unbelievable. Major characters are expected to be three-dimensional whereas minor characters are often two-dimensional. However, some writers may purposely choose to make their central characters flat characters in order to underline particular attributes. Flat characters are easy to recognize owing to their one-sidedness.

Characters can also be said to be dynamic or static. A dynamic character goes through transition as the story unfolds. Three-dimensional characters are dynamic. For

example, in Marjorie Oludhe's novel *Coming to Birth*, at the beginning, Paulina is portrayed as a naïve, docile, traditional, illiterate African woman. However, with time, Paulina grows in all respects subsequent to: the experiences she undergoes in the hands of her husband Martin and the influence she gets from her informed, urbanized female friends. Hence, Paulina learns to be aggressive and financially independent. With financial empowerment, Paulina is able to chart a destiny for herself without having to rely on her beastly husband.

Static characters do not change or undergo insignificant, unnoticeable transition as the plot unfolds. Static characters are essentially flat. A good example is Munoo in Mulk Raj Anand's novel *Coolie*. Munoo remains the same passive, despondent lad in spite of the barbarous experiences he undergoes. A boy of his age in normal life would be transformed by such savagery.

Whatever type of character a writer uses, the characters must be seen to be consistent. Aristotle advises that even those characters that are purposely designed to be inconsistent must be portrayed as consistently inconsistent.

Activity

Select any literary work of your choice and qualify the existence of main and minor characters

Mode

There are many sub-genres of literary writing. The aim of a writer and indeed, the rhetorical situation in totality, will determine the type of writing an author will use. Apart from the three main genres (poetry, prose and drama), we also have many sub-genres within the genres. Mode as an aspect of form intertwines with the content of a literary work. Generic mode is the format that a writer chooses to use in his text. Generic mode is mostly determined by the kind

of message a writer wants to put across and subsequently, the conveniences of a particular genre. A play gives a reader a sense of immediacy in the enactment. A poem will capture the crucial emotion arising from an incident, thought or action. A novel will seek to give a clear elaboration of detail in order to convince. Many of the sub-categories such as tragedy, tragi-comedy, comedy and satirical writings percolate into all the main genres. The aim of a comedy is to elicit laughter in the audience / reader while at the same time help the audience / reader recognize certain truths. In watching or reading Nicolai Gogol's play *The Government Inspector*, we laugh at the foibles of the corrupt and confused government officials. However, in laughing, we realize that we are laughing at the weaknesses of people

just like ourselves. Thus, in laughing, we learn about human flaws and how we can avoid situations in which the characters find themselves.

Tragedy as a mode is aimed at exciting emotions of pity and fear in the audience while at the same time ridding the audience of burdensome emotions in a process called 'catharsis'. Tragedy will therefore portray a situation of suffering and irreparable loss. Disaster overtakes the hero(ine) in spite of his / her noble defiance of fate or reality. The possibilities of tragedy therefore exist in a setting in which man's powers are limited and in which heroism and virtue do not guarantee moral victories. As a result, the spectators, a congregation as much as an audience are purged of their emotions of terror and pity through vicarious participation in the drama where a man just like them suffers, not because of depravity but simply because of a human weakness. Tragedies therefore will be used by an author to teach on human weaknesses. Okonkwo and Ezeulu in *Things Fall Apart* and *Arrow of God*, respectively are employed to demonstrate what an awful thing intransigence could lead to. In *King Oedipus*, Oedipus's pride is a source of his fall. Therefore, as a mode, tragedy will be employed to reflect on hard realities of human life. Tragedy is not just what happens to the hero. The ordinary tragic action is what occurs through the hero. Thus, the tragic is embedded in the web of social relationships of which the hero is the focal point. Tragedies will convey of how life can be chaotic when the established social order is effaced.

Writers can therefore utilize various modes to communicate an assortment of ideas. Purpose will therefore determine the mode that a writer chooses.

Language

Language is a very key aspect of form; veritably the very lifeline of Literature ± now that language is the medium through which literary art is communicated. Indeed, the literariness of a text will derive from the creative linguistic manipulation inherent in a text. It is in this regard that non-fictional prose forms

can also be studied as Literature. Literary writers endeavour to produce new, exciting and stimulating ideas through imaginative use of language. The writer makes original use of the established possibilities of the language or transcends the boundaries, creating new, enlivening and gratifying communicative possibilities. In the imaginative manipulation, creative writers set out to communicate effectively by employing language that will elicit correct responses from their audiences or readers. Since content is meant to be expressed by the writer through sheer linguistic and paralinguistic devices, a literary writer must choose appropriate language to ensure that what he wants to put across to his audience is effectively done. This will bring unity between content and form and hence ensure meaning is clear because it is only through establishment of meaning in a work of art that gives the responses.

It is in this regard that in the novel *A Tale of Two Cities*, for example, Charles Dickens sets out to narrate the awful story of Doctor Manette, his daughter and others related to him. The doctor's story, embedded in the French revolution that saw people die

in cold blood, intentionally starts in a very enigmatic manner to capture the paradox that the real atmosphere at that time was ± punctuated by a mixture of hope and desperation, intrepidity and trepidation, harmony and confusion, cheer and tribulation:

It was the best of times, it was the worst of times, It was the age of wisdom, it was the age of foolishness, It was the epoch of relief, it was the epoch of Incredulity, It was the season of Light; it was the season of darkness, It was the spring of hope; It was the winter of despair, We had everything before us; we had nothing before us, We were all going direct to heaven, We were all going directly the other way. (p.12)

In the above excerpt Dickens carefully chooses his words to prepare the mind of the reader for the social jumble, blended with moments, mostly, infinitesimal or simply inconsiderable, of optimism and celebration, to be encountered in the text. That it was the best of times because people had finally realized that they had to salvage themselves by fighting Monarchism and Anarchism. But it was also the worst of times because people were not sure when the revolution would end and how much blood would be spilt in the whole process. The perplexing nature of the whole situation would not have been captured better except through such creative use of language. The repetition of the phrases 'It was...' and 'We had

...' perfectly capture the monotony of the mental and social muddle; the confusion that hang in the air everywhere ± in the leaves' whispers, in the birds' melodies, in the dull thuds of the people's steps, and everywhere else.

See how Ngugi Wa Thiong'o successfully introduces the theme of poverty in *Grain of Wheat* through sheer description of the state of Mugo's blanket:

The blanket was hard and worn out, its bristles pricked his face, his neck, in fact all the unclothed parts of his body. (p.3)

From the above description, a reader will easily vividly picture in his or her mind, the kind of blanket that Mugo owns. Through such description, Ngugi effectively brings to the fore the pauperism that was the black people's lot during the colonial times. Mugo is supposed to be the people's hero (even though in reality, a dastardly traitor), yet he can live in such material destitution. What about the rest of the people? One can only conclude that pennilessness and distress was the black people's surname. In that regard therefore, Ngugi's choice of words is what makes a crucial theme ± the deprivation and impoverization of the African following the invasion of the white man into Africa ± eminently clear and forceful. It would have been plain flat, actually, considerably impotent had Ngugi simply said: 'his blanket was torn and left most of his body parts exposed'. The power that the quotation from the novel carries would seriously be dissipated in the second version.

Also, in *A Grain of Wheat*, when King Joro starts praying, his is a language far apart from the ordinary because it is pregnant with metaphorical allusions, punctuated with frequent pauses, a language that is composed of compound sentences with repetition thrown in adequately; a language that draws references from the biblical events for justification of the moment:

God of Isaac and Jacob and Abraham, who also created Gikuyu and Mumbi, and gave us, your children, this land of Kenya, we, on this occasion ever to be remembered by all the nations of the earth as the day you delivered your children from Misri, do now ask you to let your tears stream down upon us, for your tears, Oh Lord, are eternal blessings. Blood has been spilt for this day. Each post in our huts is smeared not with blood from the ram, but blood from the veins and skins of our sons and daughters, who died that we may live. And everywhere in our villages, in the market place, in the shambas, nay, even in the air, we hear the widows and orphans cry, and we pass by, talking loudly to drown their meaning, for we can do nothing. Lord, we can do nothing. But the cry of Rachael in our midst cannot be drowned, can never be drowned. O God of Isaac and Abraham, the journey across the desert is long. We are without water, we are without food, and our enemies follow behind us, riding on chariots and horseback, to take us back to the Pharaoh. For they are loth to let your people go, are angered to the heart to see your people go. But with your help and guidance, Lord, we shall surely reach and walk on Canaan's shore. You who said that where two or three are gathered together, you will grant whatsoever they shall ask, we now beseech you with one voice to bless the work of our hands as we till the soil and defend our freedom. For it is written: Ask and it shall be given unto you; knock and it shall be opened; seek and ye shall find. All this we ask in the name of Jesus Christ our Lord, Amen. (p.189)

The prayer above is not only creative in language use but also has a lot of thematic significance in the novel. People had been waiting for the big day with suspense / apprehensive mood arising from the knowledge that Mugo was going to address them. The people had been waiting with both optimism and skepticism. Optimism because they were hopeful that they were going after all, at long last, to be self-governed. Doubts because it was uncertain yet difficult to know whether land would be returned to the Africans and whether the Indian Dukawallas would move and leave business in the hands of the black people, and so on. Suspense filled the air. People had been waiting with both expectation and dread; fear that blood would be spilt on this very day. So when the prayer is finally said with a lot of creative language, the people are 'stolen away' somehow to the spiritual world where the mood becomes prayerful and one of soul-searching. The prayer relaxes the people from the load of the previous days, and when they finally sing after the prayer, recreating history, they become truly relaxed and ready for the speeches that follow.

Effective use of figurative language is also seen in Francis Imbuga's play *Betrayal in the City*. For example, after the Askari boasts to Jere that the distinction between the two was very clear: that Jere was incarcerated whereas the Askari was unconfined, Jere asks a question that is metaphorically loaded:

³Has it ever occurred to you that the outside of this cell may well be the inside of another?' (p.21) Figuratively, Jere seems to imply that the citizens' liberty seems to have been grossly infringed in this particular society to an extent that whether you were gaoled or loose, you were still encumbered in a bigger jail where your birthrights were curtailed by shameless, coarse rulers. The smaller cell (real prison cell) would thus take care of the dauntless, vociferous critics of such tyrannical leaders whereas the bigger cell would still contain the timorous or sycophantic persons, damn them and ensure that they remain permanently politically innocuous. At the same time, Jere's utterance may imply that African leaders like Boss have rendered their countries a bedlam, a socio-politico-economic clatter to such an extent that if you are not suffocating the trauma that is jail life, you will be suffocating the corruption, poverty, anarchy, violation of human rights, and many other evils that pervade the social world owing to sheer political mismanagement of the country by egoistic and barbarous leaders. Thus, to bring out the enormity of the problem of leadership in African countries, Imbuga creatively uses a metaphorical statement which at first glance seems incongruous and meaningless and would even warrant an immediate dismissal to an incautious eye, to indict vainglorious leaders whose only mission is to turn themselves into political myths and ensure that they remain so by reducing their subjects into timid slaves or puppetry marionettes. Those who refuse to toe the line are labeled either deranged or dangerous or both. When Jere is perceived to be mentally sick due to his frankness on so-called sensitive political issues, he says: 'when the madness of an entire nation disturbs a solitary mind, it is not enough to say the man is mad'. (p.35) We cannot afford to take Jere lightly here. This is a creative construction by Imbuga to mean a whole world of things: that a man is not mad out of his own volition but because of the environment in which he lives. Juser is also said to be mad because of his many independent ideas. Everybody around him has now rebelled against him and they do not want to listen to him yet his only brother was murdered in cold blood in the city by a government too thin-skinned to criticism. No justice has been done yet. This 'madness' of injustices existent in all corners of this society actually made routine, is what has destabilized Juser's solitary mind. This is the message that the playwright wishes to communicate and he does it so effectively through appropriate choice of words.

A literary writer's language will reveal to us whether he / she is serious, earnest, indifferent or sarcastic about what he / she is writing about. For example the choice of words and images in Mbiti's poem 'New York Skyscrapers' in *Poems From East Africa* (edited by Cook and Rubadiri, p.95) reveals to the reader immediately that the poet wants us to get a rather disgusting picture of New York. The diction of the poem 'Vicious Circle' by Makando Mandia in *Anthology of East African Poetry* (edited by A.D. Amateshe) is effective in maintaining the semantic effects reached by the words used. For example, the flesh is referred to as 'tasty' in the first stanza. Later in the second stanza, the flesh is 'rotting'. This creative contrast is meant to create an impression that a lot of things may appear presentable, admirable or valuable at a casual look. However, such things may turn

out to be the exact opposite of what they appear to be. For instance, the carriers of Human Immunodeficiency Virus (HIV), the virus that causes the Acquired Immune Deficiency Syndrome (AIDS) may not openly show that they have it until the critical stages. One may not be able to judge from their appearance. It may therefore turn out that the person one thought was pure in as far as HIV is concerned, is the one that has it. Yet, the discovery might come too late to make any amends. Such imaginative use of language therefore is a judicious caution that we should check what lurks behind the veil before we indulge in commitments or acts that may plunge us into fatal problems.

Relaxation is an element in human relations that enables people to realize their relationship to their full. When tension creeps in, threatening to engulf the relationship, humanity would naturally devise ways of warding off the tension. Experienced writers express such aspects of real life convincingly in their art through sheer creative use of language. One such writer is Charles Dickens. For example, in *A Tale of Two Cities*, when both Miss Manette and Mr. Carton engage in a conversation, each carrying a heavy load of pain in his / her heart, Dickens uses language appropriately to illustrate the inherent tension:

Is it not ± forgive me; I have begun the question on my lips ± a pity to leave no better life? « Looking gently at him again, she was surprised and saddened to see that there were tears in his eyes. There were tears in his voice too «

Miss Manette asks a philosophical question, broken by a parenthesis, to try and ease the tension between her and Mr. Carton. Miss Manette has to endeavour and convince herself that her father, Doctor Manette will ever live a good life, a life without worries, a life without strife; a life that will warrant him free contact with the world. Mr. Carton, on the other hand, is burdened with the onus of rehabilitating himself from the 'malady' of alcoholism and come to terms with the harsh realities of life. Tension builds up and the two characters' pain and disquietude intensifies. Consequently, the need for composure ± seeking an 'agitation-killing' utterance from Miss Manette. The philosophical question is meant to shift the psychic focus of the individual characters from their respective predicament to a disposition that amalgamates the various plights into a collective / common dilemma that necessitates a concordant rumination and solution. Initially two problems, they conjoin into one so that the two characters see themselves as sailing in the same boat, the cliché notwithstanding. A very efficacious way of obliterating tension between individuals is by alerting the other to components of commonality in whatever regard.

Referring to the same quotation from *A Tale of Two Cities*, Dickens also uses language carefully to appeal to the reader's emotion. That a man has to speak with a voice that cries, makes the reader conjure a picture of a distraught man, full of pain, with a voice so remote that it seems to need to break some great yet invisible barrier, in order for it to come out coherently. Such a

disconsolate picture of grief that comes with adversity propels the reader easily into empathizing with the owner of the voice. In this way, the reader not only appreciates the predicament of the character but also identifies with the character.

When people in such a melancholic situation pause for a moment to swallow the bitter saliva that is their affliction and perhaps meditate upon their dejection, the silence that follows is usually ominous, dreadful. A good writer will employ language effectively to paint a clear picture of such gloom. Charles Dickens, for instance, demonstrates this by personifying the physical objects within the setting and showing that although inanimate objects do not share human suffering, they do acknowledge and empathize with the sufferers: 'The tables trembled in the silence that followed' (p.153). Even the repetition of the voiceless *apico-alveolas* stop sound /t/ creates a feeling of the consistency and permanence of the pain and trauma.

It can therefore be said that what is of paramount significance in literary language is the concreteness of texture of the language so that the language employed has the capability to evoke or recreate sensory perceptions that bring out the actual discernment intended.

Literary writers have also the freedom to ignore conventions of language generally observed by users of the language. When writers transgress such rules, the contravention is done purposely in order to enhance communication. We will see this clearly when we elaborately tackle deviation in Literature later on. However, we need to establish here that when writers go against linguistic norms, the transgression should be considered against the backdrop of the very meaning of the text itself. It is in this regard that Francis Imbuga employs ambiguity in *Betrayal in the City* to communicate his message. He alludes to a hotel as 'an eating-house'. This phrase is ambiguous and metaphorical at the same time. It is ambiguous because the compounded word may be subjected to two interpretations: (a) a place where people go to buy food and dine, and (b) metaphorically, a house that undertakes the act of eating. Whereas the second interpretation may sound outrightly foolish, it makes sense when analyzed against the backcloth of the on-goings in the text. The hotel business is presented as one of the varied businesses through which the upper class fleece the poor majority. The society presented is also one big eating-house where the occupants of the State House (the leaders) feed on (exploit, subhumanize and murder) the citizenry. Both meanings can therefore conveniently apply. Another case of ambiguity is where Doga says: 'A shaving ceremony is no child's play' (p.14). The words 'shaving ceremony' here can be given two interpretations. Firstly, they may be construed to denote a ceremony in which shaving is conducted traditionally as an outward expression of bereavement or as a mark to signal the end of mourning. Secondly, the two words may suggest a ceremony as an entity here that conducts the activity of shaving. Again, this may sound balderdash at a superficial level. However, this apparent nonsense may be linked to the meaning of the text, especially if we realize that on this day of shaving (traditional shaving ceremony), Doga and Nina are deprived of their other son,

Jusper. Jusper is whisked off to jail. It is also on this very day that Chagaga is 'shaved' ± killed by Jusper. Consequently, it is on the same 'shaving ceremony' day that Jusper is also 'shaved' when he is arrested for the murder of Chagaga.

By consciously allowing Mulili to break the rules of grammar, Imbuga draws our attention to the educational qualifications of some leaders. This way, Imbuga satirizes political systems that have little regard for academic merit, while at the same time saying that there can never be fairness in a system where the leaders got into their positions through unfair, corrupt and dubious means. At the same time, through such ungrammatical language, Imbuga invites us (audience / readers) to laugh while taking note of the serious issues highlighted such as nepotism. The deviant language therefore also has comic effect, thereby temporarily relieving us from the tension accruing from the momentous events of the text.

In Alice Walker's novel *The Color Purple*, the grammatical deviant language also has semantic weight. From the very language itself, one may be able to tell that the character Celie has been a victim of injustice ± denial of formal education. When one reads the novel, it becomes apparently clear that Celie's bad English is not really cultural (derived from her African-American orientation) as such but mainly a result of her semiliteracy. This point becomes clear when one compares her awful English with the polished language that her educated sister Nettie speaks. Nettie had the privilege of having some good education whereas Celie was a multiple victim of two men: her stepfather and husband.

As an element of form, thus, language is a very critical component. Literary language entails deliberate choice and use of particular expressions by a writer to convey his / her thoughts, feelings, attitudes and intentions. Through the deliberate patterning and arrangement of words, we are provoked to develop prudent and mature sensitivity and objectivity. A writer is free to select various aspects of language where he / she will be guided by his / her peculiar message and sensuality aimed at. Hence, the clarity and quality of a writer's thoughts / ideas can only be as clear and good as the nature and quality of his / her language.

A text's linguistic format is the sum total of all kinds of linguistic choices which according to Emmanuel Ngara (1982) are divisible into two subsets: (a) linguistic proper components and (b) para-linguistic affective devices such as symbolism, myth, allusion and allegory, among others. The latter (b) features are not analyzable in terms of normal linguistic description. Under linguistic-proper features, we isolate levels of syntax, sentence-type and association between form and meaning. Also, we consider phonology, whose outstanding aspects include: alliteration, consonance, assonance, onomatopoeia, rhyme and rhythm, among others. A good illustration of phonology as a powerful element of form can be discerned in the following two stanzas of Gerard Hopkins's poem 'The Wreck of Deutschland':

Stanza 13

Into the snow she sweeps, Hurling the
haven behind,
The Deutschland, on Sunday, and so the sky keeps, For the infinite
air is unkind,

And the sea flint-flake, black-backed into the regular blow Sitting
East northeast, in cursed quarter, the wind; Wiry and white-fiery
and whirlwind ± swivelled snow Spins to the widow-making
unchildling unfathering deeps

Stanza 14

She drove in the dark to leeward, She struck
± not a reef or a rock
But the combs of a smother of sand; night drew her Dead to
the Kentish knock;
And she beat the bank down with her bows and the
ride of her keel;
The breakers rolled on her beam with ruinous shock; And canvas
and compass, the whorl and the wheel
Idle for ever to waft her or wind her with, these she endured

In the first stanza you will notice a recurrence of the sound 's' which brings out the 'sweeping' movement of the ship ('snow', 'sweeps', 'Sunday', 'so', 'Sky', 'Keeps' etc). At the beginning there seems to be some kind of calmness in the sea. The use of the 's' sound together with the 'k' sound in the first three lines brings out such a picture of very little disturbance if any. But with the line 'For the infinite air is unkind', just as the assonance in the line suggests, there is some surging wave of moving air. With such a wave, the atmosphere is disturbed. The movement of the ship is subsequently affected too. Note that henceforth there is deliberate use of alliteration that illustrates disturbance (flint-flake, black-backed, wiry, white-fiery and whirlwind etc). The repeated 'l' sound suggests quick movement of the moving air (wind). The repeated 'e' sound coupled with the harsh 'n' sound in 'black-backed' and 'blow' (note also the harsh sound 'n' in 'flake' on the same line) suggest a ship that is being pushed from side to side by a tempestuous wind. The 'z' in the many words that follow gives the effect of a hurricane like wind. Hence, it is clear in the thirteenth stanza that things are no longer well in the sea. In the fourteenth stanza the buffeting of the ship intensifies. Note that there are more words bearing the harsh sounding 'n', 'e', 'g' and 'w' sound ('n' ± dark, struck, rock, combs, Kentish Knock, Keel, Breakers, shock, canvass, compass; 'e' ± beat, bank, bows, breakers, beam; 'g' ± drove, dark, leeward, sand, drew, dead, down and, ride, rolled, wind, endured; 'w' ± night, beat, waft). Note also how the generous employment of sound 'u' intensifies the harshness of the words therefore bringing out a ship in a turmoil. Note also that the calmlessness in the sea intensifies at the end with the words abundant with the sounds 'z' and 'l' (with, whorl, wheel waft, wind), patterned deliberately to give the effect of a no win situation. Apart from the consonant sound, assonances such as 'R' on the fourteenth stanza effectively bring out the effect of a ship in trouble ± rolling and sinking. The cumulative effect therefore of the deliberate sound patterning is a cinematic (in words that evoke a feelings and pictures) effect of a ship vanquished by a tempestuous sea.

Linguistic proper elements also entail lexical choices $\pm$ grammatical or deviant. These may entail use of particular diction, register, and dialect, among others. Since our onus here is to simply yet clearly illustrate how form contributes to meaning, having given substantial examples of how language manipulation may contribute to meaning, we shall not delve into elaborate details. This shall be left to the various lectures where we shall intensively discuss the components either under conformity or deviation.

Summary

In this lecture, we have endeavoured to establish that the relationship between form and content is one of an inseparable and reciprocal marriage where the sole offspring (meaning) can only 'die' if the parents cease to co-exist. We have also elaborately looked at aspects of form (structure, plot, characterization, mode and language) and how they contribute to meaning in literary works.

Activity

With ample illustrations from any literary text of your choice, discuss the assertion that 'matter is expressed in manner'.

Lecture four

ASPECTS OF CONTENT

Introduction

In the last lecture we focused mostly on aspects of form and how they contribute to meaning. It will be foolhardy and a waste of time to repeat the whole exercise from the perspective of content. Hence, in this Lecture we will restrict ourselves to defining the various components of content while only briefly showing how these aspects are realized in Literature.

Lecture Objectives

At the end of this Lecture you should be able to:

- (a) Describe 'content' in a literary sense
- (b) Identify aspects of content
- (c) Show their importance in apprehending literary art by showing how content affects meaning.

CONTENT

'Content' is a widely used term in literary criticism but one much debated in Linguistics and Stylistics. *Content* is normally perceived to be opposed, by implication, to terms such as 'form' or 'expression'.

Saussure contends that the levels of language consist of a *meaning* plane (Read ± content), the traditional concern of semantics and an *expression* plane which communicates content through the medium of form. The two levels cannot be divorced from each other. Thus, we can say that form is *semanticized* while content *formalized*. The truth cannot be overstated. However, certain literary critics purport to have endeavoured to study the content in a literary work independent of the manner of expression. The dualist approach based on a dichotomy between form and content assumes that the same content can be expressed in different forms. This assumption also lurks behind the notions of paraphrase, synonymy and translation. So a sentence like 'He makes untrue statements' means 'He lies' or 'They engaged in a bitter embroilment subsequent to their financial woes, as a consequence of which they divorced'

may mean ³Because of money problems, they quarreled, then parted ways'. Indeed, the two versions of the two sentences may be said to express the same message. However, a deeper scrutiny of the sentences will reveal that the meaning is not really quite the same in the alternative sentences. For example

³He lies' (the ambiguity notwithstanding), tersely means that he misrepresents facts. The implication here is that he is not to be trusted at all. In essence, he is not a good man. Period. On the other hand ³ He makes untrue statements' can be looked at from several angles. Firstly, there is the element of verbosity. Why this longer expression as opposed to a possible shorter form? In Literature, as we will see under ³Semantic Redundancy', a writer can communicate certain meanings only expressible through such verbosity. On the other hand, from the perspective of μ making¶ the statement may be seen an emphasis of the imagination / fictionality employed by the character ³He'. In this sense, the negativity clearly obvious in the first statement is not quite intelligible in the second version. The second pair of sentences can also be interpreted variably. The first sentence has a clear chronological sequence $\pm$ why they altercated and why they divorced. In the second example, there is a missing link $\pm$ did they part ways as a result of the commotion or as a result of the financial problems? Again, parting ways is not the same thing as divorcing. Parting ways may imply momentary separation. At the same time, from the phrase μ parting ways¶, we cannot tell whether they were married or were just friends. We cannot even ascertain that the two people belong to two different sexes, for that matter. The meaning of the two expressions is therefore not quite identical at a deeper level.

From the two examples we can say that whereas there are alternative ways of expressing a message, a writer will opt for a particular option because he thinks that it will communicate exactly what he wants to say. Therefore, language or whatever aspect of form is not only to communicate meaning, but also to create it. It is because of this truth that translations of poetic texts are always difficult. Indeed, alternative formalizations tend to become alternative conceptualizations.

Content being what is in a work of art, has four major components:

- (a) Thought
- (b) Attitude
- (c) Feelings
- (d) Intentions

Thought

Under μ thought¶ we have subject-matter and theme. The two terms confuse many scholars. People take them to mean the same thing. Some writers also employ the terms interchangeably as if they were exactly synonymous. Whereas the terms are doubtlessly greatly related, they are not essentially the same. To differentiate them, one can use alternative words for each. Hence subject-matter becomes the topic, while theme becomes the idea. Subject-matter may therefore be regarded as the wider idea whereas theme may be considered the specific idea. Two literary texts may, for instance, have the same subject

matter yet have totally different points about it. For example Chaplin's poem 'The next morning' and Rubadiri's 'Prostitute' (*Poems From East Africa* by Rubadiri and Cook, pgs, 32 and 139 respectively), have got the same subject-matter: a man's sober assessment of his relationship with a prostitute. However, the specific ideas / themes of the two poems are quite different. Whereas Jim Chaplin's poem suggests and indeed delves on the self-digust that would follow such an experience (where one was involved with a harlot), Rubadiri's poem on the other hand emphasizes the mistakenness of the speaker being attracted to the prostitute). Another pair of poems with an identical subject-matter but distinct themes is Laban Erapu's 'The Guilt of Giving' (p.42) and Richard Ntiro's 'The Pauper' (p.114). The common feature between Ngugi Wa Thiong'o's and Micere Mugo's co-authored play *Trials of Dedan Kimathi*, Kenneth Watene's *Dedan Kimathi* and Ian Henderson's non-literary *Hunting for Dedan Kimathi* is the subjectmatter: Dedan Kimathi. However, the different themes in the texts reflect the perspectives of the writers. Kenneth Watene's presentation of Kimathi originally (he has amended the text since) is implicitly no better than what we get from the colonial perception that is inherent in Ian Henderson's book. Kimathi is uncharitably presented to the point of appearing like a brute, a terrorist with no speck of virtue in him. Indeed, Ngugi's and Micere's text is said to be a reaction to the earlier misrepresentation of Kimathi. Ngugi and Micere sought to remedy the disgusting portrayal of a people's hero and thereby correct history.

Ngugi was Thiong'o's first three novels, namely: *The River Between*, *Weep Not, Child* and *A Grain of Wheat*, have a common subject-matter: Colonialism. In spite of this fact, the novels address different specific themes to do with colonialism. In the first novel, the writer looks at effects of colonialism such as: alienation of the black person as a result of the introduction of western education and culture, religious conflict, among others. In *Weep Not, Child*, Ngugi focuses on land alienation following the incursion of the white man. The concomitants of this uprootment are addressed. In *A Grain of Wheat*, Ngugi looks at the struggle for liberation against colonial subjugation. Betrayal is a major theme too in *A Grain of Wheat* where we see black people betraying each other during the struggle.

Having a clear understanding of the distinction between the subject-matter and theme, wider and specific ideas in the piece of work that one is reading, enhances better comprehension of a text since if one can clearly be able to pin-point the issue(s) at hand, only then may he / she be able to see what the writer is saying about it. The literary writer sets to talk about:

« something: it may be love, liberation, culture, religion or an imaginative idea. What he sets out to write about is the subjectmatter. He is saying something about the subject-matter; he is expressing his views about people, society and life in general. He is telling us what his attitude is to the subject-matter and in the process influences our own views on the questions he raises; or at least makes us think about. What he says about the subject-matter is the theme of the novel. In a novel there may be several themes, one being dominant and others subsidiary. The subject-matter, the theme, the views and attitudes expressed by the writer as well as the

meaning of the artifact or what we call its message ± all these constitute the content. (Emmanuel Ngara: 1982: 15)

When a writer sets clearly his subject-matter and theme, he will sit down and try to coin an appropriate style that will effectively communicate his point. Hence, the idea of form in communicating content is inalienable. Proper forms bring clarity in meaning.

Attitude

As an aspect of content, attitude refers to the writer's position regarding the on- goings in his / her fictional world. A writer's attitude will be garnered from the themes presented and how he presents them. Hence, Imbuga's attitude towards gender disparity and discrimination of women is clear in Aminata. The role given the protagonist, Aminata, clearly demonstrates that Imbuga recognizes the importance of women in society and appreciates their contribution to the world. Thus, those who feel that women should not be heard in the society such as Jumba, are uncharitably presented. Through the liberated pastor Ngoya, a cultural renegade in his period who had the temerity to go against tradition by treating his daughter as a human being as opposed to a sub-human creature as was the norm in his particular society, Imbuga lashes at patriarchal societies that demeaned women. Pastor Ngoya creates confidence in Aminata by educating her. It is this kind of confidence in women, Imbuga implies, that will enable women to reach their potential. Aminata is therefore able to do things that were considered masculine of preserves: starting a water project, paying fees for her good-for-nothing drunken brother's children and even buying a coffin for her departed father. Imbuga's attitude towards women here is unmistakable: that women have the same intellectual and therefore, economic potentialities that men have. That, sometimes, women may even do better than men in many regards.

Language and characterization are very crucial in deducing a writer's attitude (ref. Bounderby's description in Dickens' Hard Times, earlier cited).

Feelings

Feelings refer to the sentiments / emotions that a writer wishes to arouse in a reader. After reading a literary text, are you moved? Do you feel sad or depressed, amused or exhilarated, confused or disconcerted? A literary writer will aim at eliciting various shades of emotions: pity, awe, surprise, gloom, anger, ecstasy, satisfaction, and equanimity. Reading Rebeka Njau's The Sacred Seed, one is angered by the misdeeds of President Dixon Chinusi while drawing contentment from Tesa's mythical growth to a symbol of optimism in the novel. It is the same kind of feeling that one gets on reading Alex la Guma's In the Fog of the Seasons' End ± anger at the characterization of racist brutes who have the temerity to play God by reducing fellow human beings to the level of vermin simply because of the latter's darker skin pigmentation. The brutalization of Elias Tekwane in jail is the culmination of our indignation at the barbarism of the whites towards black persons.

However, there is jollity in the fact that in spite of enormity of the complexity and intricacies of the machinery under which the pugnacious apartheid regime operates, the so called inferior black people are still able to outwit it through establishment of an underground movement that helps train non-white people in military skills. We delight in the hope that black people will eventually get their rights through sustained violent agitation. The presentation of characters will therefore help foreground the writer's feelings. If a writer supports certain personality traits of a character, he will present the character as a successful torchbearer.

Feelings will also be deduced from the author's point of view and mode employed in the writing. The mood created in a text through manipulation of language will tell whether the writer is being satirical or otherwise, and consequently, what the author wants us to feel about the on-goings.

The tragic mode necessarily provokes feelings of pity, cheerlessness, alarm and disquietude. For example, in the story of King Oedipus in a play by Sophocles bearing the same title, the inevitability of fate is what accentuates our sorrow, sympathy, consternation and dismay. Oedipus is destined to kill his father and marry his mother, and he cannot seem to escape such an eventuality. That one can suffer because of no fault of his is the height of injustice. We therefore sympathize with Oedipus in his ordeals. The tragic mode affects the reader psychologically in this regard.

Language will also evoke all shades of feelings in a reader. A good example is Ayi kwei Armah's *The Beautiful Ones are not yet Born*. How better can one express the seriousness of corruption, the rottenness that it breeds in a society where it is so entrenched, except through such disgusting description as seen in this novel? Sample the following:

- (a) The man disappeared through the gigantic opening in the front of the building and turned up the broad cement stairs to the right. He moved absently to the left of the staircase and reached for the support of the banister, but immediately after contact his hand recoiled in an instinctive gesture of withdrawal. The touch of the banister on the balls of his fingertips had something uncomfortably organic about it. A weak bulb hung over the whole staircase suspended on some thin, invisible thread. By its light it was barely possible to see the banister, and the sight was like that of a very long piece of diseased skin « What had been going on there and was going on now would go on and on through all the years ahead was a species of war carried on in the silence of long ages, a struggle in which only the keen uncanny eyes and ears of lunatic seers could detect the deceiving, easy breathing of the strugglers.

The wood underneath would win and win till the end of time. Of that there was no doubt possible, only the pain of hope perennially doomed to disappointment. It was as clear. Of course it was the nature of the wood to rot with age. The polish, it was supposed, would catch the rot. But of course in the end it was the rot which

imprisoned everything in its effortless embrace. It did not really have to fight. Being was enough. In the natural cause of things it would always take the newness of the different kinds of polish and the vaunted cleansing power of the chemicals in them, and it would convert all the victorious filth, awaiting yet more polish again and again and again. And the wood was not alone.

Apart from the wood itself, there were, of course, people themselves, just so many hands and fingers bringing help to the wood in its course toward putrefaction. Left-hand fingers in their careless journey from a hasty anus sliding all the way up the banisters as their owners made the return trip from the lavatory downstairs to the offices above. Right-hand fingers still dripping with the after-piss and stale sweat from fat crotches. The calloused palms of messengers after they had blown their clogged noses reaching for a convenient place to leave the well-rubbed moisture. Afternoon hands not entirely licked clean of palm soup and remnants of kenkey. The wood would always win. (p. 11- 13)

(b) Under a dying lamp a child is disturbed by a long cough coming from somewhere deep in the center of the infant body. At the end of it his mother calmly puts her mouth to the wet congested nostrils and sucks them free. The mess she lets fall gently by the roadside and with her bare foot she rubs in softly in the earth. (p.35)

(c) Over the iron bridge the bus moves slowly. In gusts the heat rises from the market abandoned to the night and to the homeless, dust and perpetual mud covered over with crushed tomatoes and rotten vegetables, eddies from the open end of some fish head on a dump of refuse and curled-up scales with the hardening corpses of the afternoon's flies around. Another stretch of free sea line. More than half-way now, the world around the central rubbish heap is entered, and smells hit the senses like a strong wall, and even the eyes have something to register. It is so old it has become more than mere rubbish, that is why. It has fused with the earth underneath « Past the big public lavatory the stench claws inward to the throat. Sometimes it is understandable that people spit so much, when all around decaying things push inward and mix all the body's juices with the taste of rot. Sometimes it is understandable, the doomed attempt to purify the self by adding to the disease outside ± Hot smell of caked shit split by afternoon's baking sun, now touched by still evaporating dew. The nostrils, incredibly are joined in a way that is most horrifyingly direct to the throat itself and to the entrails right through to their end. Across the aisle on the seat opposite, an old man is sleeping and his mouth is open to the air rushing in the night with

how many particles of what? « Sounds of moist fish in open pans of dark perennial oil so close to the public lavatory. It is very easy to get used to what is terrible. A different thing: the public bath, made for a purification that is not so offensive. Here there is only the stale soapsuds merging in grainy rotten dirt from everybody's scum, a reminder of armpits full of yellowed hair dripping sweat down arms raised casually in places of public intimacy « (p.40/41)

Intentions

Intentions are the objectives of a piece of work. What does the author wish to accomplish by his / her work? Is it to give a clear explanation of how to do something or to give an impression of life in a certain way? Is the writer's purpose to explain the motives behind a person's actions or to ridicule something which is unworthy or undesirable in a person or society? Is the writer's aim to share with his / her readers certain very precious feelings. Is the writer's desire to cause us to admire or emulate something good or beautiful or is the writer's design to evoke pity for someone in unfortunate circumstances? Intentions can be as many as the stars in the sky but a writer will usually focus on a discernible number of goals.

To know an artist's intention, we have to scrutinize the plot and follow the flow of events. We have to look at and analyze the characters elaborately. We have to be able to peel the symbols, analyze the choice of words and interpret the significance of the mode and structure ± indeed, all aspects of form have to be examined critically if we are to fully appreciate and apprehend the meaning of the piece of writing and consequently, the artist's intentions. For example, the plot of Francis Imbuga's second novel, *Miracle of Remera*, is a clear pointer to what the writer thinks about the HIV /AIDS phenomenon. That the main character, Ezra Maiyo, is cured of the malady connotes Imbuga's thesis: that AIDS is not incurable as the world has been made to believe. That Maiyo's salvation emanates from traditional medication; experimentation with various herbs, upon which he stumbles onto one that reverses his condition, suggests that Imbuga does not see the solution to the scourge coming from Western medication, which we have been made to revere. Imbuga is asking Africans to re-evaluate their culture. Whereas we have been made to think of our traditional healing methods as savage and devilish, hence sinful, Imbuga is telling us that perhaps we have been bamboozled into myopia and self-hate yet what is good and may offer hope for the world lies in what we have been made to disregard.

Summary

In this lecture, we have focused on aspects of content: thought, attitude, feelings and intentions. We have not only looked at how these aspects of content are

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manifested in Literature, but have also seen how they contribute to clarity in comprehension of a literary work. We have also shown how these aspects of content are engendered and dramatized by aspects of form.

Activity

What is 'content' in Literary language? Illustrate your answer.

Lecture five

FOREGROUNDING IN LITERATURE

Introduction

As we saw in our previous lecture, both Rhetoricians and Literary writers endeavour to communicate through deliberate manipulation of language and structuring that appeals to the target audience and that evokes shades of emotions, attitudes and reactions that the author desires. In this lecture we focus on 'Foregrounding' – a term that is used to explain the numerous ways a writer or speaker may endeavour to make certain items in his writing or speech stand out. Foregrounding is a term that has received a plethora of definitions from various schools of thought. We will sample a number of these definitions and ultimately agree on what we think is the most appropriate definition.

Lecture Objectives

At the end of this Lecture you should be able to:

- (a) Define the term 'foregrounding' from a literary perspective
- (b) State the significance of foregrounding in Literature

Foregrounding

The concept of foregrounding is inalienable in Literature. The critical onus of a literary writer in his strivings to inform or entertain is that of attaining his goal through sheer manipulation of linguistic items and para-linguistic items. This means that a writer has to carefully select certain linguistic / paralinguistic items conducive to his objectives. In normal circumstances, those items that have an impact will stand out. Indeed, writers have to make certain items stand out if they are to achieve any impact at all. Veritably, a speech or writing that treads on the heels of the everyday language does not have as much impact as that which strives to be imaginative by creation of fresh expressions that stand out as unique, while at the same time contributing to better comprehension of the issues at hand. Having said that, we still need to define the term 'foregrounding'.

The term ³*foregrounding* is a coinage of the Prague Linguists. The pre-war school of Linguists borrowed the concept from Gestalt psychology and applied it to Linguistics. An attribute of Gestalt psychology entails observing things in terms of the totality. Hence, in Linguistics, the concept enabled an analyst to perceive a facet / quality not in seclusion but in terms of association with other components in the text. However, the Prague Linguists maintained that literary language or poetic language in particular, could only achieve foregrounding through contravening the established principles of language.

Jan Mukarovsky, a Russian originator of the term ³*foregrounding*, conceived of the concept as entailing intentional flagrant transgression of the rules of the standard language. To Mukarovsky, a literary writer would be unable to foreground unless he violated linguistic norms. Indeed, Mukarovsky asserted that it is the ability to violate the established principles of language, untrammelled, that creates literariness in language:

The violation of the norm of the standard, its systematic violation is what makes poetic utilization of language. Without this possibility there would be no poetry. (Freeman: 1970:42)

The Prague linguists therefore equated foregrounding with deviation. Many other scholars have of essence also defined the term with the idea of linguistic contravention in mind. For example Leech (Allen & Corder: 1974:22) describes the term as premeditated violation from the systems of the language code or from the acknowledged conventions of its use which sticks out or is foregrounded against the background of normal usage. Chapman (1974) too, considers deviation as the very foundation of foregrounding:

the word μ foregrounding is used to describe the kind of deviation which has the function of bringing some item into artistic emphasis so that it stands out from its surrounding.

Whereas we appreciate that deviation is a significant aspect of foregrounding, we cannot accept the definitions enumerated above that confine the term μ foregrounding to contravention of language norms. If μ foregrounding entails making a linguistic item stand out, does a writer necessarily need to deviate in order to accomplish such a feat? We disagree. Foregrounded items need not be deviant. It is in this respect that we embrace the definition of μ foregrounding that is espoused by Cluysenaar (1976) and Halliday (in Chatman: 1971). Through a practical analysis of poetry, both Cluysenaar and Halliday demonstrate that foregrounding could be conditioned on conforming to the language norms. Halliday therefore defines μ foregrounding as linguistic eminence that is motivated:

a general name for linguistic highlighting whereby some feature of the language of a text stands out in some way. (Chatman: 1971: 339)

The point of emphasis in the above definition is on the practice or possibility of making a linguistic item conspicuous - noteworthy. Now, we find the foregoing definition most apt since it underscores the pertinent quality of the term, which does not necessarily relegate the term to the parochial pigeonhole of deviation. The processes that can be employed to bring out the linguistic noteworthiness do not of essence have to be deviational. According to Halliday, three processes can be used to establish this prominence:

- (a) negative
- (b) positive
- (c) statistical

Halliday describes negative prominence as departure from the norms, hence equating negative prominence with deviation. Positive eminence is established when a writer attains linguistic conspicuousness through adhering to / establishment of a norm. For example, look at the following excerpt from Charles Dickens¶ *Hard Times*:

No little Gradgrind had ever seen a face in the moon; it was up in the moon before it could speak distinctly. No little Gradgrind had ever learnt the silly jingle, Twinkle, twinkle, little star; how I wonder what you are! No little Gradgrind had ever known wonder on the subject, each little Gradgrind having at five years old dissected the Great Bear like Professor Owen and driven Charles¶s Wain like a locomotive engine-driver. No little Gradgrind had ever associated a cow in a field with that famous cow with the crumpled horn who tossed the dog who worried the cat who killed the rat who ate the malt, or with that yet more famous cow who swallowed Tom Thumb: it had never heard of those celebrities and had only been introduced to a cow as a graminivorous ruminating quadruped with several stomachs. (p.54)

In the above extract, whereas there are a few cases of deviation which all derive from direct reference / quotation, Charles Dickens adheres to grammatical norms in every sense of the word. However, certain linguistic items stand out, yet it is not the deviant items. What is evidenced as conspicuous is the uniformity and regularity of the use of a syntactic pattern:³No little «it» It is indeed the recurrence of this syntactic structure that arrests our attention yet it is not deviant. It is indeed Dickens¶ insistence to purposely select a particular syntactic option notwithstanding that he could have used others and yet keep within the rules of language.

Now see the syntactic preference Salman Rushdie chooses to employ in the following complex sentence which could easily have been broken down into smaller grammatical structures:

« As the young Pakistani soldiers entered the marshy terrain of the Rann, a cold clammy perspiration broke out on their foreheads, they were unnerved by the greeny sea-bed quality of the light; they recounted stories which frightened them even more, legends of terrible things which happened in this amphibious zone, of demonic sea-beasts with glowing eyes, of fish women who lay with their fishy heads under water, breathing while their halves lay on the shore; they told about the great blubbery things which slithered around the border posts at night, and the floating-in-air spirits of drowned men with seaweed wreaths and sea shells in their navels. (*Midnight Children*, p. 325)

This complex sentence (loose paratactic sentence) has a deliberate structure:

³As they; «they «they «'. All structures beginning ³they «' explain what be considered the first clause / part ± ³As «the light «'. Even within the clauses, there can also be discerned a purposeful option. For example, there is the use of the pattern ³of demonic «', ³of fish women «', in the second clause. This long sentence is intentionally patterned to dramatize the mental situation of the soldiers at a critical moment. The sentence occurs at the climax of the story when the soldiers want to attack. The foregrounding of the linguistic items as explained above, where every focus melts down on ³they', not only vividly enacts the psychological disposition of ³they' but also instigates emotions of fear in the readers ± fear and sympathy for the young soldiers.

The two examples cited clearly demonstrate that a writer may maintain the established language conventions and still be able to make a linguistic item stand out.

Statistical prominence is established when a writer interrupts a pattern he / she has already established in a text. While some critics perceive this kind of interruption as deviation within the text, this cannot be considered deviation in the strictest sense of the word since statistical eminence does not hinge on transgressing linguistic norms. Rather, statistical prominence derives from the frequency of occurrence of certain components. The statistically conspicuous feature will be noted as the rare, infrequent item in the total. It is not established by transgression of rules. Rather, it is established by departure from a dominant pattern in a text. Let us try and pick out the statistical prominence in the following passage from Abioseh Nicol's ³Love's Own Tears':

The little black boy paused in awe outside as he listened to his grandmother dying inside the wooden frame-house with shutters now let down. It was hot. The heat simmered over the tin roofs of the African city and settled in a thin blue haze over the surrounding mountains. He bounced his ball slowly; he knew granny was dying ± that was an established fact ±

he had heard his mother saying so over the fence to the neighbours next door. He knew also that it was something ordinary, because although the old woman yelled at the top of her voice, no one paid exceptional attention apart from giving her a little water now and again, and sometimes patting her gently where she said it hurt most. On the other hand, he felt something uneventful was going to take place from the snatches of whispered conversation he had overheard; the steady but concerted buzz of activity; and the fact that no one paid much attention to his normal misdemeanours. Only once had he been shoo-ed out of the way. He had gone outside on some pretext and had asked his mother what was a bosom. She had paused. μGranny¶s dying¶, she said. μGranny¶s being taken into the bosom of her lord¶.

Looking at the example above, one thing becomes obvious ± that the passage is made up of fairly long sentences. The very first sentence comprises twenty-five words. The third sentence has twenty-two words. The fourth sentence, made up of several clauses and parenthetical elements has thirty words. If thirty looks long, that is just average in as far as this passage is concerned. Thus, the fifth and sixth sentences have forty-six and forty-two words respectively. This is how long the sentences in this passage can get. However, amid these lengthy sentences, a few sentences are very short and of necessity, foregrounded by their very brevity amidst lengthiness. For instance, the second sentence that is made of only three words ± ³It was hot' ± clearly sticks out. Similar short sentences are the ninth and tenth sentences - ³She had paused', ³Granny¶s dying, she said'. Such brevity, when the writer has mostly employed long compound sentences, inevitably calls our attention to the ³queer' short sentences. We are compelled to see the relationship between the brevity and the issue at hand. Looking at the μrare¶ sentences, one thing is clear ± statistical prominence enhances meaning in a text. The short sentences are loaded with meaning. ³It is hot' is not simply a three-worded sentence that summarizes the temperature inside the wooden-frame house. That it was hot despite the shutter being down, the writer is not actually focusing on the factual μclimate¶ in the house. Rather, through the monosyllabically worded crisp sentence, the author shifts from the real physical happenings to the psychology of the little boy. Having told us the circumstances obtaining on the old woman in the preceding sentence, the author now moves on to explore the little boy¶s psychology. ³It was hot' can only best summarize the boy¶s innermost feelings while watching his grandmother die. The boy does not really understand what is happening as revealed in the last couple of sentences where it has to be explained to him that the grandmother was ³being taken into the bosom of the Lord'. Hence, the boy may not comprehend a lot about the prevailing circumstances. However, his psychology gives him a premonition of the bad news to come. This premonition comes in the excess heat that his body generates. Notice that this heat is really artificial in that within a short time it ³settles in a thin blue haze over the surrounding mountains'. If it were heat generated by the scorching sun¶s impact on the ³tin roofs of the African city', would it really μdisappear¶ so

suddenly? The short sentence therefore effectively encapsulates the boy's psychology at a crucial stage. Indeed, such a short sentence, more so, made up of monosyllabic words, is employed in Literature to suggest a crisis or haste concomitant with emotions such as: panic, awe, wonder, anger and many others. It is in this respect that the other very short sentences also occur at a critical time. The boy is eager to know what the grandmother meant when she implored God to take her into His bosom. 'She had paused' is also a very suggestive short sentence that brings out the boy's child's mother's emotions at a crucial time. She could not just blurt out. She had to pause in order to explain to her naïve child. She had to pause to think about the magnitude of what the answer would mean to the child. Once again, then, the short sentence is loaded with psychological potentials. Having paused to weigh all options, the boy's mother chooses to explain to her child tersely: 'Granny's dying', she said'. She chooses to be blunt

at first. This seeming bluntness may be as a result of many factors, even cultural, and can therefore be debated at many levels. However, just like any human being would expect such bad news to be communicated subtly, we see that immediately after spurring out the blunt remark, the boy's mother goes further to alleviate the expected shock in the boy by explaining that 'Granny's being taken into the bosom of the Lord'. So now, to the boy, it is no longer a gory case of a beloved member of the family losing her life. Rather, the situation has now been mellowed, indeed, transformed from a situation of despondency and sadness, to that of serenity, death notwithstanding. After all, the member of the family is just leaving her family behind in order to be with her maker. With this kind of understanding, the boy achieves mental equanimity regardless of the misfortune of losing a grandmother.

Thus, literary writers may effectively employ statistical prominence as seen in the example discussed.

The Significance of Foregrounding

Creative artists set out through their artistic works to communicate and to do so effectively. In order to achieve this noble task, literary artists must be able to manipulate language resources uniquely yet efficaciously so as to impress upon their audience and provoke active responses from them through sheer creative use of language. Foregrounding in Literature is therefore premeditated and carefully considered so that when an audience reads or hears the foregrounded item in the text, he / she is reading or that is being performed, apart from arresting his / her attention due to its peculiar characteristics, the foregrounded feature also sets the audience pondering over the possible rationale of the artist in employing the feature at the precise position in the text. That foregrounding in Literature is prudent and purposed, then, foregrounding in Literature implies choice. The literary artist only selects certain linguistic items that will provide relevant information ± that is ± items that will ultimately powerfully contribute to the total picture / meaning. In Chatman: 1971, Halliday emphasizes the question of choice: that there must be a rationale for choosing a particular form of literary presentation. If the foregrounded items do not add value to the overall picture, then such foregrounding can be seen as a literary flaw since it will seem to lack motivation:

a feature that is brought into prominence will be foregrounded only if it relates to the meaning of the text as a whole. This relationship is a functional one: if a particular feature of the language contributes by its prominence, to the total meaning of the work, it does so by virtue of, and through the medium of its

own value in the language through the linguistic function from which its meaning is derived. Where that function is relevant to our interpretation of the work, the prominence will appear motivated. (p.339)

Since a foregrounded feature is a product of meticulous, deliberate selection, then it follows that the interpretation, by the audience, of the painstakingly adopted components, is what will ultimately lead to total comprehension of the text. The foregrounded item must therefore be interpretable such that through his / her own exertion and imagination, the audience can eventually recognize some association between the component and the text. It is through such recognition that finally the audience will be able to gain new insights into the texts.

The key issues when approaching foregrounding are basically three:

- (a) **Identifying** ± One ought to identify the foregrounded item.
- (b) **Describing** ± Secondly, the manifestations / texture of the foregrounded item must be described. What exactly is it? Is it a cumulative sentence, periodic sentence or antithesis?
- (c) **Rationalizing / motivation** - Finally, and yet most important, the foregrounded feature must be accounted for. That is, a reader or listener must be able to say why he / she thinks the author / narrator employed the foregrounded feature at the exact place. In a nutshell, an audience must be able to establish the relevance of the foregrounded item vis a vis the core issues obtaining.

Summary

We have said that foregrounding entails deliberate use of language imaginatively to enable an item, linguistic or otherwise, to stand out in a literary text. The eminence is considered against the background of not only norms of ordinary language, but also norms established by the writer himself in a text. Foregrounding

can therefore be attained by conforming to norms (grammatical or otherwise) or by deviating from these principles.

Features in a literary text are foregrounded for the purpose of surprising or impressing the reader so that he / she is set thinking about the relevance of the foregrounded element. In this way, the writer creates an active approach on the part of the reader.

Activity

What is foregrounding in Stylistics? Illustrate your answer.

Lecture six

DEVIATION AND LITERARY COMMUNICATION

Introduction

In our last lecture, we showed that foregrounding may be achieved through both conformity and deviation. In this lecture, we will define deviation as a literary term in its entirety. Henceforth, in the following several lectures, we will look at various forms of deviation and to what effect they are employed in literary works.

Lecture Objectives

At the end of this lecture you should be able to

- (a) Define deviation as a literary term
- (b) State the significance of deviation in Literary texts

Deviation

A survey of various definitions of the term 'deviation' indicates that the term is fundamentally a linguistic phenomenon, operating at the levels of grammar (which includes morphology, syntax and phonology) and semantics. For instance, Cluysenaar (1976: 31) defines deviation as:

« departure from expectations regarding different levels of language, semantic, lexical, grammatical and phonological, and different 'ranks' within grammar and phonology at the rank of sentence or phrase »

Now this is a purely linguistic definition of the term. It is the same case with Geoffrey Leech's definition of deviation ± violation of the commonly observed canons of the language. This description of the term deviation tallies with Enkvist's: 'an actual tinkering with the normal systems of rules' (Chatman: 1971: 55). **The Dictionary of Language and Linguistics** (Hartman and Stork: 1973) describes deviation as:

a collective term for any utterance which is not in keeping with the acceptable grammatical or semantic forms of the standard language.

The foregoing definitions of the term deviation all imply contravention of the rules of the language, resulting in an utterance being perceived as unorthodox, abnormal, anomalous, irregular or not typical. Whereas these definitions are acceptable in as far as they are taken to be the perception of the term deviation by Linguists, the fact that most of the scholars named (like Cluysenaar and Leech) have also contributed enormously to literary scholarship, then they cannot be excused from giving the term a context that does not transcend the Linguistic. By restricting the phenomenon to only linguistic explanations, one may be led to presuppose that deviation cannot be revealed in other ways. This is absolutely false.

Having said that, what would we consider to be the most acceptable definition of the term deviation? In *A Dictionary of Stylistics* by Katie Wales, deviation is aptly described as the divergence in frequency from a norm or divergence from the statistical average. This is a good definition which in a general sense implies a departure from certain expected or already established ways / patterns of doing things / writing / speaking. Todorov's definition also suffices here: 'infraction, transgression of a norm'. In both definitions, a norm can simply be regarded as the backcloth against which deviation can be measured. Thus, since norm can be varied, linguistic or otherwise, then these two definitions have the advantage of being able to accommodate non-linguistic deviance as well. By merely emphasizing on a norm, the definitions have led to the classification of literary deviation as:

- (a) Grammatical
- (b) Contextual and,
- (c) Statistical

Grammatical deviance

Grammatical deviance occurs when a writer transgresses established language codes. Linguists concur that language consists of patterns that are rule-related. Grammatical deviation therefore arises when the accepted norms of language structure are violated.

Contextual deviance

Contextual deviance occurs when language is employed correctly in terms of grammatical patterns, but inappropriately in terms of the situation at hand, or context. For example, when one uses formal language in a situation that is informal in all regards, then the language employed would be considered inappropriate in all respects, hence, contextually deviant. Generic deviance would also fall in this category such that usage of poetic language in prose narrative, for example, would be regarded as contextual deviation.

Statistical deviation

Statistical deviation roots in the frequency of occurrence of a particular usage / pattern, the disruption of which would be perceived as statistical deviance. Hence, statistical deviation constitutes a rarity: a writer establishes a consistent pattern so that any item that is distinguishable as the infrequent item in the total pattern, will be isolated as the deviant feature, statistically. For instance, should a writer use many short sentences successfully, then somewhere in the middle use a long compound sentence, then the long sentence can be regarded as the deviant item since it changes the pattern established in a text. Thus, statistical deviation constitutes departure from the dominant pattern in a text.

It has been argued that all texts, whatever their degree of deviance or conformity, establish their own norms. Stylisticians who espouse Levin's contentions have used this reasoning to distinguish between internal and external deviation. External transgression measures language used within a text against the background of the norms without the text. On the other hand, internal deviance alludes to features in a text that vary from the expected in the text itself. Leech (1969) calls such deviance *undefeated expectancy*. The implication here is that it is *normal* for deviant language to be *normal* and normal language to be deviant. An example here would suffice:

light leaves lurch a once world quickly from
rises army the gradual of unbeing fro On
stiffening greenly aim to ghosts go drift slippery
hands tease slim float twitten faces **only stand**
with me love; against this its until you are and
until I am dreams.

In the above excerpt, the *whole* language is commonly absurd, incongruous. That is, the syntactic order of the words is ungrammatical almost through out. In such a case where deviance becomes the norm, then the normal becomes deviant. Therefore, the underlined words are foregrounded by the *abnormality* of their *normality* in a text whose *normality* is the abnormal.

Deviation and Literature

Some scholars (See Stankiewics in Sebeok: 1964) contend that deviation is inevitable in Literature. Indeed, to scholars Jeniffer Schiffer Levine, deviation is what distinguishes the literary form from the non-literary; it is the very foundation of artistic value:

The central distinction of a literary language is that it is a consciously willed deviation from the ordinary language. (Ibid: p. 70)

Such definitions as the one above, are misleading since they create the impression that departing from norms is the paramount trait, nay, the only trait by which Literature can be appreciated and differentiated from non-literature. As Winfred Nowotny (1978: 92) aptly

remarks, the principal distinction between the language of Literature and the non-literary language is that the former is more highly structured than the latter. Nowotny implies that literary language stands out because of the patterns established ± these patterns could be grammatical or deviant. There is no implication of deviation in Nowotny's claims. In spite of that, it must be acknowledged that Literature does indeed consist of some language usage that is markedly at variance with what we call conventional or non-literary language. Literary language tends to encompass some components which when measured against the normal / customary appear to be irregular, aberrant, abnormal or unconventional. Such linguistic components are therefore deviant in the sense that no linguistic principles will be able to rationalize them.

If the fundamental role of language were to communicate, it would be rational to conclude that the objective of all literary writers, nay, all writers under the sun, is to communicate. Veritably, all writers use language as their medium of transmission of meaning. Despite this truth, literary writers are not just concerned with transmission of meaning (*What*). The issue is also *HOW* this meaning is conveyed ± the creative artistic dimension. Literary writers therefore devise ways of manipulating language in myriad ways in order to communicate as effectively as possible. This manipulation of language may be manifested in such a way that it tends to behave differently from the ordinary, conventional language. Such behaviour is realized when the writer crosses the grammatical borders to explore other communicative possibilities of the language achievable only through transgression. Such contravention is possible to a literary writer because of the immense freedom that the writer wields under what we call *Poetic License*.

Poetic License

The phrase 'poetic license' implies the freedom given to a literary writer to manipulate the vast resources of language in order to communicate effectively. Initially only conferred to poets, the liberties have now percolated into other genres, enabling writers even to flout the conventions of writing. In poetry, the term 'Poetic license' has been used for generations to refer to particular forms of deviance ± the kind of transgression that had become conventionalized due to re-use by generations of poets. The customary transgressions, namely: elision, ellipsis and transposition, were used by poets as elementary technical devices to fit metrical or rhythmical requirements. Presently, poetic license allows literary writers to deviate from anything that may be regarded normal in lingual or extra- lingual terms. Writers have capitalized on this freedom and employed it to greater creativity and originality.

The Significance of Deviation

When considering deviance in Literature, two main issues are of monstrous importance:

- (a) *motive* and
- (b) *response*

Motive

Since we have already reiterated that deviation in Literature is presupposedly done (and indeed it should be done) purposefully and never accidentally, for the sole aim of enhancing communication, then it follows that a reader must scrutinize the deviant components with a view to establishing what drove the writer to employ them at the particular place. The reader must therefore rationalize the inclusion of the deviant feature in terms of its communicative effect. A writer will employ a deviant feature intentionally to arrest the attention of the reader (i.e. the abnormality of the feature will necessitate its easy identification by the reader's eye). Again, because of its irregularity, the deviant element incites the reader into ruminating about its significance. In provoking the reader's attention, making him / her seek to establish the association between the component and the meaning of the text, the deviant item will ultimately have achieved the aesthetic effect of heightening the reader's awareness by enabling him / her to obtain deeper apprehension of the text in question. That notwithstanding, a reader's understanding of an element calls for an interpretation.

Response

Interpretation entails seeking to link a component in a literary text to the meaning. In such a search, the reader will endeavour to establish the motive and aim of the writer in employing the deviant feature within the entire context of the literary piece. So, what parameters does one consider in the whole enterprise of interpretation? Whereas literary scholars concur that deviant elements in a literary text must finally be interpretable, there is no formal logical yardstick that would lead to what can be termed a correct interpretation. Thus, interpretation of deviation in Literature is perceived to be purely subjective: based on a reader's own intuition, creativity, innovation and imagination. In terms of a response, therefore, deviation in Literature will depend purely on the sensibilities of the reader and his / her critical assessment. In spite of this, there has to be some kind of credibility in the interpretation so that textual evidence must be employed to rationalize the intuition or imagination. Hence, any interpretation which does not draw from the textual deposition can outrightly be dismissed as imposed. At the same time, it will be foolhardy to interpret an item in isolation. In isolation, of course, the interpreter may be justified to concoct all inanities about a feature. However, since interpretation consists in relating an item to the whole text so that the item is perceived not in terms of itself but in terms of other (con)texts, then the importance of a deviant feature is only realizable from the (con)text itself.

Apart from textual evidence, the veracity of an interpretation of a deviant feature will be judged against the responses of other readers / analysts of the same feature. This is what Cluysenaar calls 'inter-subjective validity'. Therefore, an interpretation will be considered credible and accurate if ultimately there exists consensus of interpretive judgement. According to Leech, this inter-subjective validity is attainable when every

reader / analyst strives to co-associate the objectivity of analyzation of linguistic items with the subjectivity of critical interpretation.

Summary

We have agreed in this lecture that deviation in Literatures alludes to infraction of a norm. The norm could be linguistic, contextual, statistical or otherwise. Such divergence from norms is devised by literary authors consciously and not adventitiously in order to heighten communication in a literary text. It is from the principles of transmission of meaning that deviation assumes its importance.

Whereas there are no clear-cut parameters against which a deviant feature may be interpreted so that interpretations of such features tend to be subjective, such subjectivity must be justifiable from the textual facts. At the same time, such subjectivity must be intra-subjective ± must be in consonance with other people's interpretation of the same feature.

Activity

In a nutshell, what is deviation in Literary language and why are deviant features important in Literary analysis?

Lecture seven

THE AESTHETICS OF GRAMMATICAL / SYNTACTIC DEVIATION

Introduction

Having defined what the term 'deviation' means in literary contexts in our last lecture, in this lecture we embark on demonstrating the manifold forms in which deviant items can be manifested. In this lecture, we will discuss grammatical and syntactic deviance. Our emphasis will be on the rationale of employing this form of deviation in Literature.

Lecture Objectives

At the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- (a) Define the words 'grammar' and 'syntax'
- (b) Identify forms of grammatical / syntactic deviation
- (c) Account for these forms of deviance

Syntax

Derived from a Greek word meaning 'together arrangement', the term **syntax** presupposes a set of conventions which govern the way words (and which words) can be combined to make meaningful utterances in a sentence. Syntax is therefore a branch of grammar that deals with word order and signaling of relations between constructions.

Of all elements imperative to making a linguistic construction / expression sensible, the most compelling is syntax, controlling the order in which impressions are appropriated and conveying the intellectual / mental relationships μ behind sequences of words.

Syntax not only determines clarity in literary content but also in literary structure $\pm$ it is a patterning tool especially in poetry where the constructive principle of μ **figures of grammar** and μ **figures of sound** is inalienable subsequent to the brevity of the genre, and the element of performance which necessitates that sound features must stand out. Indeed, syntax in Literature has the credit of creating rhythms and other patterns without which genres like poetry would be nothing more than lifeless rags. For literary writers therefore, even when they intend to transgress syntactic conventions, respect and consideration of rules of syntax has been synonymous with clear thought and expression.

Syntax is paramount to literary authors because it is capable of producing a variety of effects. As a user of language, a reader of a literary text is conditioned to attach meaning to syntactic relations without conscious effort. He / she does not grasp the gist of the utterance unless the meaning reaches him / her already marshaled in a set of relation that syntax imposes on the words the expression / utterance

contains. Hence, the genesis of the powerful effects which the reader naturally perceives but cannot explain to him /herself lies more in the manner than in the thought thrust forth.

Consequently, however little noticed by the reader, Syntax is the very heart of Literature. For instance, the management of alliteration, consonance, assonance or rhyme in poetry cannot be fully appreciated unless one can relate the syntactic flow and dexterous manipulation of sentential constructions to the meaning intended.

Many literary writers ignore and indeed, reject the rigid conventional word order, with its emphasis on clear, unequivocal relationships among the various components of the sentence, because they believe that such established patterns may not be able to powerfully produce certain effects intended by the author. Thus, Literary writers invent their own freer 'grammar' where word order may be manipulated anyhow as meaning gets clearer. Therefore, devices like ellipsis, inversion, cataphora, analocution, among others, were introduced and have been exploited fruitfully in Literature. Despite their obvious abnormality in terms of word order, such techniques are nonetheless interpretable and significantly furnish the overall aesthetic vitality of a literary text.

The central function of literary word order is to arrest the reader's / audience's attention by highlighting certain key meanings. The degree of aesthetic intensity is determined by the extent to which the foregrounding is successful, which is concomitantly attained by the employment of such other elements as the semantic, phonological, prosodic or rhetorical features.

Now we will look at forms of Syntactic deviance.

Ellipsis

Derived from a Greek word meaning 'leaving out', Ellipsis involves omission of a word or group of words which are grammatically and structurally (syntactically) necessary but non-imperative semantically. That is, whereas the words left out are significant in terms of word order, we do not really need them to decipher the meaning of an utterance. Indeed, we do obtain the substance of an utterance without these words, albeit sometimes not quite easily. Look at the following stanza from A.E. Housman's poem 'The Immortal Part':

Wanderers eastward, wanderers west Know
you why you cannot rest 'Tis that every
mother's son Travails with a skeleton

Several functional words have been omitted in the stanza above. For example, 'and' and 'ward' in the first line would suffice to make the grammatical construction of the first line: 'Wanderers eastward and wanderers westward'. Alternatively, the line could be written: 'Wanderers eastward and wanderers to the west'. Let us look at another example in the third stanza of Roger McGough's poem 'Hoarding':

Old lady sits by the firegrate Knitting
 and pudding with twine
 (she) dreams of brandy sauce (but) drinks
 methylated wine

The words in brackets would have been required to make the third and fourth lines grammatical. However, we are still able to comprehend the theme of the lines devoid of these words. From the two examples, you may have noticed that functional words which are omitted are essentially: conjunctions, auxiliary verbs, prepositions and determiners. Sometimes, writers even omit the subject in a sentence / line if it had already been mentioned in preceding sentences / lines.

Motivation for Ellipsis

Why would a literary writer engage in this kind of omission? Syntax as a strong sense of, is close and compact expression, and lack of diffuseness. Yet, in poetry economy of words necessitates Ellipsis. Poems are essentially arrangements of images and syntax. Where images reign supreme, syntax can be condensed significantly. Unlike prose, where the linguistic role of binding words together in logical arrangements is perceived as the key to derivation of meaning, hence the emphasis of grammatical patterns, in poetry the grammatical patterns do not necessarily prevail. Indeed, a poet may manage to create a suspenseful atmosphere by leaving sentences hanging while at the same time painting vivid images of what he would wish to capture without resorting to minute descriptions. The following lines from Eliot's poem 'The Wasteland' clearly demonstrate the kind of compactness achieved by use of Ellipsis:

Elizabeth and Leicester (were)
 Beating oars
 (when) The stern was formed, (it
 was) A gilded shell (of) Red and
 gold. (then)
 The brisk swell
 Rippled both shores
 (and the) Southwest wind Carried down
 stream The Peal of
 bells
 (from the) White towers

The words in brackets are an approximation (not necessarily the correct form) of how the verse would probably have read with some addition of structurally imperative components,

or if it were to be likened to a form of prose. Therefore, the economy of words at the level of Syntax makes the verse more compact and intense.

Apart from ensuring compactness and intensity through omission of semantically unnecessary words, literary writers also engage in ellipsis in order to create and maintain alliteration and a regular metrical pattern.

³Substitution' is another form of Ellipsis which involves replacing words that have already been uttered with words such as: $\mu do\|$, $\mu so\|$ and $\mu one\|$. This is a way of achieving cohesion and word economy in a literary text just as it would do in ordinary speech. For example:

³Charlotte seems a very pleasant young woman', said Bingley

³Oh dear, yes; but you must own she is very plain. Lady

Lucas herself has always said so and «'

The word ³so' replaces ³«she is very plain'. ³So' here serves to avoid repetition of an expression earlier uttered.

Inversion / Transposition

In transposition, the canonical word order is modified; the grammatical elements are shifted from their normal position, for a reason. Syntactically, subject-verb-object, in that order, occur in a sentence. Any alternation in position of these elements transforms the sentence into a μ malformed $\|$ one. Not so in Literature. Thus, inversion in literary texts is a means of organizing words so that instead of elements following each other in abstract conventional sheepishness, writers can allow any element to follow another deliberately in order to create particular meanings and tensions.

There are basically two common types of inversion:

- (a) Fronting
- (b) Aesthetic Inversion

Fronting

In ³fronting', a writer shifts grammatical components from their normal post-verbal position to the beginning of a phrase, clause or sentence. Fronting is usually done for purposes of highlighting or emphasizing the fronted item. For example:

Ten thousand saw I at a glance
Strange fits of passion have I known. (Wordsworth)

In the example above, both lines have been inverted. The correct version of the first line would be: 'I saw ten thousand at a glance'. The second line would read:

'I have known strange fits of passion'. Be that as it may, the writer decided to front 'ten thousand' and 'strange fits' specifically to emphasize them; changing them into the subjects of the expressions. In the first line, the writer wants you to think of 'ten thousand'. Then, he deliberately omits a word that would aid in clear understanding of what constitutes that big number. Thus, ten thousand what? While you think about the big number because of the fronting, you are left in suspense, wondering what exactly the author is talking about. As a reader, you crack your head in suspense, eager to know what makes up that number. The big number, thus, coming at the beginning to provoke you into noticing it and thinking about its significance, followed by an ellipted noun (a rare kind of Ellipsis), is the height of adept creation of a cliff-hanger at the level of a clause or sentence. In the second line, Wordsworth wants the reader to think of 'strange fits'. Again, one wonders: what kind of strange fits? Even after having been told that they are 'fits of passion', one wonders why 'strange'? And then, why 'fits'? What passions? Just like in the first line, transposition in the second line is loaded with and indeed grounded in heavy and captivating suspense.

Aesthetic Inversion

In aesthetic inversion, a writer may not necessarily seek to emphasize certain items brought forward. Rather, the writer engages in inversion, placing words in a telling position in a line in order to maintain the metrical or rhythmical pattern created. However, in the hands of experienced writers, such patterning and positioning would be in tandem with the relationships of the words in totality in their inverted order and thereby ultimately patterned towards a particular goal

± better communication / enhancement of meaning. An example of aesthetic inversion is in the following stanza from W.H. Auden's poem 'Look, Stranger, on this Island now':

Stand stable here
And silent be
That though the channels of the ear May wonder
like a river
The swaying sound of the sea

In the example above, you may have noticed the use of rhyming words: here ± ear, be ± sea. Indeed, the inversion in this example in many regards (though not totally) is geared at creating rhyme. For example, the inversion of 'silent' in the words 'And silent be' from the grammatical 'And be silent' does not add any value in whatever terms. Since there is no other µbe-ing¶ in this particular phrase and since one cannot merely 'be' (whatever that means), we can infer in whatever version that the point of emphasis is the need for silence.

However, the fourth line constitutes fronting so that emphasis is on the river-like wandering that the sounds of the swaying sea may simulate.

Note

Apart from the two types of transposition discussed above, writers may also engage in other types of syntactic alternation for particular effect. The third most common type of inversion involves moving an item to the very end of an utterance. See examples below.

In the following example from Lubega's poem 'Evening', the persona emphasizes the verbs in both lines (Note that in the second line the verb is the very last word):

Drunkards like sick dogs retch homewards « «
and soldiers like ants file

Also, consider the following line from Donne John's poem 'The Bait':

Come live with me, and be my love And we
will some new pleasures prove

In line two the position of the verb and object has been modified, creating a Japanese language kind of grammatical pattern ± SOV (Subject-Object-Verb), instead of the English system of SVO ± Subject-Verb-Object:

We	Will	Some new pleasures	Prove
(<i>Subject</i>)	(<i>Auxiliary verb</i>)	(<i>Object</i>)	(<i>main verb</i>)

Grammatically, the sentence above would be: 'We will prove some new pleasures'. The intentional action of changing the various structural positions of the sentential elements being as we have already said, to convey important information in a particular way, in the above sentence it is not only the object that gains emphasis but the main verb (prove) too. Truly, structurally placing a verb at the end of a sentence creates curiosity in the specific verb. The verb prove carries with it the main information ± the desire, determination or inclination towards evidencing, manifesting the favours, enjoyment of love discoverable only in living together. Consequently, the verb prove, concurrently with the

object, effectively contribute to the theme of seduction which is evidently the basis of this particular love poem. The persona really wishes to improve emotional luxuries and fulfillments that emanate from such relationships, as a way of winning the addressee / partner sensually. Therefore, the transposition in this example nurtures in the poem an imploring tone ± a potent poetic tool for appealing to a person emotionally. Aesthetically, the poet creates alliteration through the same inversion ± 'some new pleasures prove'.

Apart from syntactic devices discussed, a writer may also choose to simply ignore the rules of grammar in other ways. For example, a writer may employ one-worded sentences which in the truest grammatical sense of the term *sentence* do not qualify to be sentences. A writer may also choose to ignore main verbs, even main subjects or punctuation marks; deliberately suspend the principles of grammar in order to capture the exact emotions of a character or circumstances which in real life defy grammar and do not occur in a systematic pattern. An example from Samuel Beckett's novel Malone Dies will illustrate this:

This tangle of grey bodies in they. Silent, dim, perhaps clinging to one another, their heads buried in heir cloaks, they lie, together in a heap, in the night. They are far out in the bay. Lemuel has slipped his oars, the oars trail in the water. The night is strewn with absurd.

absurd lights, the stars, the beacons, the buoys, the lights of earth and in the hills the faint fires of the blazing gorse. Macmann, my last, my possessions, I remember, he is there too, perhaps he sleeps. Lemuel.

Lemuel is in charge, he raises his hatchet on which the blood will never dry, but not to hit anyone, he will not hit anyone, he will not hit anyone, anymore, he will not touch anyone any more either with it, or with it, or with it, or with or or with it or with his hammer or with his stick or with his fist

or in thought in dream I mean never he will never or
with his pencil with his stick or
light light I mean never there
he will never never anything.

The above excerpt is a curious syntactic structure to be found in a novel. Definitely, the syntactic organization disturbs, upsets our routinized normal view of grammatical patterning. And indeed it is this disturbance that the writer aimed at in order to motivate the reader to think about the significance of this unconventionality while at the same time being realistic about the normal spontaneous syntax of psyche. This syntax is affected by many things: mood, mental disposition, attitude and social circumstances, among many other factors.

Hence, in the illustration above, we see numerous instances of perplexing, mixed syntactic patterning involving greater clausal complexity, even obscurity, resulting from manifold embedments and variations from normal subject-predicate constructions.

While the structure of the illustration may appear a curious syntactic mess, a keen reading will notice that the syntactic construction effectively produces an effect more readily associable with the atmosphere or mood of the composition. A sorrowful, grim atmosphere caused by the demise of Malone, necessitates the loosening of logical locutions subsequent to the shock and grief on the part of the persona. Thus, the drunkard's kind of speech realistically brings out the mental disposition of the persona following the death of Malone. The repercussions of such experiences as death and other forms of trauma on the human psyche can only be credibly demonstrated through illogical, loose structures. The tension in the atmosphere and the confusion that has engulfed the persona is vividly expressed by the lack of coherence in the syntactic constructions, the omission of punctuation marks, redundancy and the disarranged locutions. Hence, Beckett twists the syntactic order to conform to the fluidity of human feelings. Such twisting is a syntactic option only granted to the literary writer to increase the emotional verisimilitude of one's art while at the same time reinforcing the aesthetic value of such a work. Therefore, in Literature, instead of playing its usual linguistic role of binding words together in a logical arrangement, Syntax can be used profitably to establish plausibility of various sentiments in the characters in the text while at the same time appealing to various shades of emotions in the reader. For instance, we can almost see Lemuel drifting into eternal sleep and are brought into empathizing and sharing the loss undergone by the persona.

Cataphora

In a grammatical structure, we normally name the noun and then subsequently refer to the noun using pronouns. This grammatical structure of referring back to the noun is what we call 'Anaphora' or backward reference. However, Literary writers may decide to begin with a pronoun even before naming the noun. The noun is named later on. The technical term for this forward referencing in Literature is 'Cataphora'. Cataphora is grammatically deviant and may be used by literary writers for a variety of effects, the most common being, to create suspense. It is also a way of befriending the reader, the assumption being that both the writer and the reader already know the subject and are merely sharing the knowledge. A good example is in Chinua Achebe's Arrow of God:

This was the third nightfall since he started looking for the signs of the new moon. He knew it would come today but he always began his watch three days early because he must not take a risk. In this season of the year, his task was not too difficult; he did not have to peer and search the sky as he might do when rains come. Then, the new moon sometimes hid itself for days behind rain clouds so that when it finally came out it was already half grown. And while it played its game, the chief priest sat up every evening waiting. (p.1)

In the above excerpt, Achebe begins the story in his novel *Arrow of God* by merely referring to a character as μHe . This creates curiosity in the reader to crave to know whom the pronoun μhe stands for. It is much later in the paragraph that Achebe makes it clear that he is talking about some Chief Priest. The suspense created in the reader on reading the above excerpt is in tandem with the contextual suspense at the particular point: the Chief Priest is also in a suspenseful mood, waiting for the moon.

Let us look at another example from Alex La Guma's novel *In the Fog of the Seasons* *End*. This novel begins this way:

They arrested him late one night and took him to a Volkswagen, one of several cars which had been used in the raid« Two detectives went in the car with him, and the other beside him in the back, while the rest of the posse searched the house.

In the example above, La Guma seeks to appeal to our emotions right from the start. There is no better way to elicit emotions of anger and sympathy for some respective characters right from the start than through cataphoric reference.

'They arrested him late one night' is a phrase that raises suspicions about 'they'. Why did 'they' arrest 'him'? Besides, who are 'they'? Are 'they' good people? Who is 'him'? Is he a bad person or just an innocent man being persecuted? These are the kinds of questions that come to mind. Besides, unlike the example from Achebe where the pronoun is finally named within the same paragraph, Alex La Guma's novel is an intricate work where the cataphoric reference is employed in an entire seven-paged prologue. The prisoner is never named in

the entire prologue. The effect achieved is that of intense suspense. We are anxious to know who the prisoner is and why he is being tortured. At the same time, we empathize with the prisoner owing to the bestiality perpetrated against him, his supposed crime notwithstanding. At the same time, we loathe the detectives for the merciless brutalization of an individual who is apparently but a political prisoner.

The use of cataphoric reference in La Guma's novel also serves connotative purposes. The ordeal of the prisoner is but a microcosm of what the black people in the South African republic reflected went through. Thus, in essence, what La Guma is saying through the cataphoric reference is that any African name, not just Elias Tekwane's, would aptly replace the pronoun 'He'. This is because torture was the air that majority of the black people breathed under white domination.

Summary

Since style is a precondition of art, we have seen that syntactic deviance is employed intentionally for various effects. Such effects include: achieving compactness and intensity in a literary text, maintaining a metric pattern, changing points of emphasis and to clearly capture the atmosphere of a situation in terms of how the atmosphere impacts on the psychology of a person. This impact is realizable in the syntactic constructions emanating from the affected or uninfected psyche.

Activity

With illustrations, show how and why a writer would indulge in Syntactic deviance.

Lecture Eight

PHONOLOGICAL DEVIANCE

Introduction

Every language has its own set of speech sounds, its own ways of connecting these sounds with other sounds into bigger units such as syllables and morphemes. Every language also has its own canons for moderating sounds as they occur in speech. In this lecture, we will look at how writers transgress the rules of sound patterning and alteration in their writings. We will endeavour to show that such transgression is purposeful, for certain aesthetic reasons.

Lecture Objectives

At the end of this Lecture you should be able to:

- (a) Identify forms of phonological deviance.
- (b) Account for such deviance in Literature.

Phonology

To understand the term 'phonology', one needs to understand the term 'phonetics'. Succinctly, Phonetics is the study of speech sounds. Phonology, then, is the sub-category of applied phonetics labeled 'Linguistic Phonetics'. Phonology focuses on the study of the sound patterns of a language. Phonology recognizes that a language has a particular / standard number of phonemes (speech sounds). Phonological analysis also recognizes that phonemes can occur only in certain places in particular languages, so that while the nasal m^{h} may begin some African Bantu or Nilotic languages, it cannot start an English word, no matter the dialect. The sequence commonly found in English of many consonantal sound coming immediately after consonants such as $\text{m}^{\text{h}}\text{r}^{\text{h}}$, $\text{m}^{\text{h}}\text{t}^{\text{h}}$, $\text{m}^{\text{h}}\text{d}^{\text{h}}$, $\text{m}^{\text{h}}\text{b}^{\text{h}}$, $\text{m}^{\text{h}}\text{s}^{\text{h}}$ and other would not start original Bantu words. Hence, Phonology appreciates that speech sounds occur only within the limits of a language system so that certain sounds may or may not combine with others in a particular language. The rules that determine sounds that may be combined with others in a language are called ***phonotactic rules***. A literary writer is expected to abide by the ***phonotactic rules*** of the medium (language) he / she has chosen to use to convey his / her literary ideas. However, Literary writers do not always follow these laws. Writers may choose to ignore these canons.

Phonological Deviation

Elision

A term derived from Latin, 'Elision' entails omission of syllables or letters from a word, therefore, affecting the phonological presentation of the word. Look at the following example:

Tis true, $\text{m}^{\text{h}}\text{t}^{\text{h}}$ is day, what through it be? O
wilt thou therefore rise from me? Why

should we rise, because μ tis light Did
 we lie down because μ twas night?
 (³Break of the day' ± John Donne (1612))

You will notice that the very first word of the stanza constitutes phonological deviation. While a combination of μ it and μ is is normally contracted to μ itV, the poet has decided to leave out the first letter μ L and then combine the μ W with μ is. The μ K in the word μ this on the same line has also been omitted, changing the pronunciation of the word to μ tis. A similar omission occurs in the third and fourth lines: μ tis light, μ twas night. From the example, it is apparently clear that the poet purposely omitted the vital phonemes in order to create alliteration. Note that all the words where an omission has occurred begin with the consonant μ W, even though in their correct forms, some ought to have the vowel μ L before the μ W (μ it is, μ it was).

Writers may choose to omit syllables in words for two main reasons:

- (i) Establishing and maintaining a metric pattern in poetry.
- (ii) Establishing and maintaining a rhyme scheme

There are three forms of Elision:

- (a) Aphesis
- (b) Syncope
- (c) Apocope

Aphesis

This is elision that entails omission of the initial letter or syllable of a word. For example:

- (i) (i)twas
- (ii) (be)twixt
- (iii) (e)scape
- (iv) (a)gainst
- (v) (aero)plane

Syncope

This refers to the kind of elision that entails omission of a medial letter or syllable in a word:

- (i) O'er (over)
- (ii) E'en (even)
- (iii) E'er (ever)
- (iv) Ne'er (never)
- (v) Heav'n (heaven)

- (vi) Ma^ham (madam)
- (vii) Tow^hrd (toward)

Apocope

Apocope refers to the form of elision that involves omitting the conclusive letter or syllable in a word:

- (i) O^h (of)
- (ii) Oft (often)
- (iii) Ol^h (old)
- (iv) An^h (and)

Word Combination

When one makes a phonological analysis of any language, it will be observed that words naturally combine in a manner that makes speaking comfortable. This is only normal now that speech was designed so that humanity may communicate with each other. It would be foolish if such a process were tortuous and painful owing to the distress occasioned by a woefully nightmarish syntactic structure. If that were the case, many of us would opt for sign language rather than persecute our tongues and in the process, afflict our minds too owing to the frustrations attendant to the calamitous process of speaking. For example, it is rare to find many words beginning with the same vowel or consonant following each other in ordinary spontaneous communication. However, we may deliberately engage in such verbal gymnastics as alliteration in our conscious conversation for reasons such as humour or simply to impress. That notwithstanding, very few people are endowed with the ability to employ such sound gymnastics effectively without prior, thorough preparation. Literary writers, however, have all the time to prepare their writings. They may therefore employ such sound manipulation beautifully. Whereas the syntactic structure in such patterning may be grammatically correct, such structuring may be considered deviant in the sense that it behaves different from natural speech patterns. Such patterning is seen in tongue-twisters.

Tongue-twisters / puns

Aimed at testing the eloquence of a speaker, tongue-twisters were intentionally crafted in the African traditional set-up. The abnormal syntactic order in tongue-twisters is not only effective in testing the fluency of a speaker, it also helps in ameliorating the speech abilities of the speaker. Look at the following examples and test yourself. Read them as fast as possible.

- (a) Akaawa akaawa kaawa kaawa akaawa kawa? (Luganda) (The girl who gave kaawa bitter coffee, where is she from?)

- (b) Kantai can tie and untie a tie. If Kantai can tie and untie a tie, why cant I tie and untie a tie just like Kantai can tie and untie a tie?
- (c) She says she sells sea shells at the sea shore but the shells she sells are not sea shells.
- (d) Pili alimpiku Peku na pikipiki katika pilkapilka za Olimpiki (Kiswahili)
- (e) Lori libiringikalo-biringikalo ndilo aendeshalo. (Kiswahili)
- (f) Two tree toads tied together tried to trot to town.

The common feature in the tongue-twisters and puns cited above is the use of similar consonantal or vowel sounds in successive words, which make quick articulation of the expressions rather difficult.

A critical look at forms of orature such as proverbs and riddles will also reveal a premeditated unnatural phonological pattern ± a pattern that not only enhances rhythm but also memorability:

- (a) Haba na haba hujaza kibaba (kiswahili) (Little by little fills the measure)
- (b) Haraka haraka haina baraka (kiswahili) (Hurry hurry has no blessing)
- (c) Kyaa kimwe kinyuaa ndaa (Kikamba) (One finger cannot kill a louse)
- (d) Vutele vumanyi mwami dave (luhya) (Slipperiness knows no king)

In the first example, the consonant μK has been repeated. The vowel sound μD has also been repeated. In combination, rhythm is enhanced. This is a reasoned combination to not only enhance rhythm but also to make the proverb interesting to the ear and easy to remember. The same applies to the other proverbs cited.

Apart from tongue-twisters, proverbs and riddles, Literary artists, especially poets, also purposely employ alliteration, consonance, assonance and rhyme both for aesthetic as well as thematic effects as seen in Hopkin's poem

³The Wreck of Deutschland' earlier cited. Indeed, through manipulation of sound

features, writers may fruitfully give the effect of: a train moving, birds flying, a river flowing, a building crumbling, soldiers marching and many other effects.

Remember

Most of the phonological pdeviance¶ cited here alludes to techniques that are pdeviant¶ only in as far as they are carefully reasoned and go against the ordinary /natural simple phonological combination which allows either easy or convenient articulation of utterances. However, such combinations may be grammatically correct.

Activity

- (a) Poetry can use the language of everyday speech, but it imposes its own patterns and rhythms. Show how the combination of everyday speech and poetic convention in W.H. Auden¶s 'The More Loving One' contributes to the total effect of the poem (see poem below)
- (b) Show how the phonological and visual patterns of G.M. Hopkins¶s 'Pied Beauty' (see poem below) contribute to its meaning.

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The More Loving One

Looking up at the stars, I know quite well

MWALIMU GREG.

That, for all they care, I can go to hell,
But on earth indifference is the least We
have to dread from man or beast.

How should we like it were stars to burn W ith a
passion for us we could not return? If equal
affection cannot be, Let the
more loving one be me.

Admirers as I think I am Of stars
that do not give a damn I cannot,
now I see them, say I missed one
terribly all day.

W ere all stars to disappear or die, I should
learn to look at the empty sky And feel its
total dark sublime,
Though this might take me a little time.

1957 W.H. Auden

Pied Beauty

Glory be to God for dappled things ±
For skies or couple-colour as brindled cow;
For rose-moles all in stipple upon trout that swim;
Fresh-firecoal chestnut-falls; finches¶ wings;
Landscape plotted and pieced-fold, fallow, and plough; And all trades,
their gear and tackle and trim.

All things counter, original, spare, strange;
Whatever is fickled, freckled (who knows how?) W ith
swift, slow; sweet, sour; a dazzle, dim;
He fathers-forth whose beauty is past change: Praise

him.

Gerard Manley Hopkins

Lecture Nine

TRANSGRESSING LEXICAL NORMS: the literary Import

Introduction

In the last lecture we looked at how writers engage in acrobatics of sounds of words for various reasons and effect. In this lecture, we will look at how and why writers deviate from rules appertaining to vocabulary and word choice.

Lecture Objectives

At the end of the lecture you should be able to:

- (a) Identify forms of lexical deviance.
- (b) Justify their use in literary writings.

Lexical deviation

The term *lexis* alludes to the word-stock of a language: the available vocabulary in the language. Lexical deviation therefore means transgressing principles governing the word-stock by coming up with non-existent words, using obsolete word forms, borrowing from other languages or employing words considered inappropriate for a particular context. Lexical deviance therefore comes out as: unheard of, unusual, unexpected or unpredicted. However, just like other forms of deviance, lexical divergence is intended for clarity and forcefulness.

There are many forms of lexical deviance. Now we will look at the most common types.

Neologism

Writers may decide to take the liberty at their disposal to come up with new words ± words that, never before, belonged to the pool of the language in question. The technical term for coining of words in literary studies is

‘Neologism’. Such neologised words are deliberately coined either subsequent to the realization that there exists no word in the lexis of the language to express a new phenomenon or for other reasons such as: irony, satire or sheer literary ornamentation. The invention of the words depends on the context and purpose of the writer. Sometimes, the words are eventually incorporated into a language. However, many a times these words are short-lived or may not exist outside the literary text. Writers can coin words through ‘affixation’ or ‘compounding’ / blending.

(a) Affixation

In coining words, writers may opt to add prefixes or suffixes that grammatically would not be affixed to certain words. For example:

For Satan in helldom and God
in paradise
(Jared Angira’s ‘Soft Corals’)

Angira adds the suffix ‘dom’ to the word ‘hell’ instead of simply saying ‘hell’. In this regard, Angira is saying that ‘hell’, just like the heavenly ‘kingdom’ of Jehovah, is a dominion, an empire, sovereignty, with Lucifer as the grand monarch. In elevating hell, that gehenna, that abyss, to a domain at par with heaven only that it functions directly opposite of the latter, Angira wants us to infer the magnitude of consciously opting to belong to Satan’s kingdom.

In Grandsaigne’s Anthology of Short Stories, Taban Lo Liyong christens one of his stories ‘Lexicographicide’. Well, no such a word exists in the English lexicon. It is merely Lo Liyong’s formulation in the fashion of such words as ‘homicide’, and ‘suicide’; words that all seem to refer to some form of killing (think also of ‘infanticide’, ‘parricide’, etc). Taban Lo Liyong therefore comes up with a new word

³Lexicographicide' to denote the art of systematically μ murdering words by changing their meaning.

In Austin Bukenya's *The People's Bachelor*, the author borrows Kiswahili prefix ³ki' and affixes it to an English word ³settler' to come up with a lingual half-breed word ³ki-settler'. If ³ki' as a prefix in Kiswahili suggests contempt as in ³kijumba chake' or ³ki-bibi chake', then the lexical μ mullato' coinage brings out the disdain of the speaker towards the ³settler'. It will be remembered that ³settler' as a term in the East African colonial context alluded to white people who on invading Africa, uprooted the natives from their ancestral, fertile lands and settled there. The Africans were pushed to unproductive, arid land. To a person who understands Kiswahili, the prefix ³ki' therefore powerfully brings out black people's bitterness and derision towards the white settlers.

Other examples of invention of new words through affixation include: ³Negritude' by Leopold Sedar Senghor $\pm$ to express the quality of being black; ³Whitude' by Austin Bukenya (in a poem going by the same title) $\pm$ to express the quality of being white. In scoffing at Negritudist Movements, Wole Soyinka comes up with a new word ³tigritude', arguing that people of African descent did not have to go around yodeling their throats husky about their so-called uniqueness as a human genre. If there is anything exceptional in the black person, Wole Soyinka argues that let it just be SEEN. If black is beauty, then so be it; it will be seen. We don't have to shout on top of mountains about it $\pm$ ³A tiger does not proclaim its tigritude; it pounces'. In all the three examples above (μ negritude', μ whitude' and μ tigritude'), the suffix μ tude' is combined with words that would not combine grammatically with such a suffix.

Compounding

In μ compounding, a writer may blend or join two or more independent words to form one word. Look at the following example from Jonathan Kariara:

μ Your Cigarette burnt the Savannah grass Colour
melts at your stave Orangewhiteblueredandall

(*Introduction to East African Poetry*, p.118)

The underlined μ word is essentially an amalgam of six words $\pm$ orange, white, blue, red, and, all. The persona is therefore being sarcastic and satirical at the same time in reference to μ you in the poem. To the

persona, even a rainbow would look like one colour to the character 'you'. To demonstrate this oneness or short-sightedness, the writer conglomerates the six words. In another regard, the agglutination of words is a scathing indictment of the character 'you' by the persona. The persona is saying that the character 'you' cannot differentiate between virtue and vice in the same way he sees all colours as one.

Activity

Read Jared Angira's Soft Corals, p.10 and consider the following lines:

The Lion vomiting wine of the palm
 Wine for the goatshepherd boy
 Torn to pieces by the Lion

Question:

What do you think Angira is saying through compounding the three underlined words?

Other examples of compounding include 'childishicited' by David Rubadiri (in Poems from East Africa ed. Cook and Rubadiri) and 'widowmaking' by Hopkins.

Sometimes, writers may neologize through affixation and compounding at the same time. For example: "it is unputdownable collection" with reference to Australian poems that thematize love and how it influences human psychology, is an intricate compounding that summarizes the complexities that underlie human emotional thoughts with regard to sexual intimacies (love) – that they are „unputdownable“ – they cannot be objectified or expressed in tangible terms. In this kind of example, the „un“ and „able“ in the „word“ „unputdownable“ are affixes – the former a prefix and the latter, a suffix – whereas the two words „put“ and „down“ conjoined, constitute compounding.

Foreign Words

When speakers choose a medium of communication, it is expected that they will consistently use that mode of communication. Thus, when one chooses to use English or Kiswahili or whatever other language to speak, the audience will have assumed or concluded at the beginning of the speech that the speaker has consciously selected the particular language as opposed to others as a result of various circumstances obtaining such as context, audience and purpose, in essence, the rhetorical situation, and will harmoniously employ the same medium through out. In this case, our speaker is competent in more than one language but has chosen one to communicate. In the same regard, when literary writers choose to write in a particular language, it is expected that they will conform to the vocabulary appertaining to that language. However, Literary writers rampantly use words that belong to a language different from the main medium of communication. If the main medium of delivery is English, many a times writers introduce words that belong to another language all together. For instance, use of Kiswahili, Gikuyu or Luo words in a text written majorly in English would constitute lexical deviation since it entails borrowing from another lexicon. So why would a writer use words from another language? This can be done for many reasons. However, the four main reasons are as follows:

(i) lack of a corresponding equivalence

One major reason for incorporating words from a medium different from the one the writer has chosen to use is when a writer has to reflect on a culture that has no equivalence in the tradition of the owners of the medium of delivery. This is why Chinua Achebe in both *Things Fall Apart* and *Arrow of God* extravagantly employs Igbo words such as: ³chi', ³egwugwu', ³agbala', ³Ogbanje' and others. Such words have no equivalence in the English language. They refer to purely contextual traditional concepts with reference to ³gods' or ³spirits' as in the first three or a mystical child (³Ogbanje'). In fact, such concepts as ³personal god' (³Chi) do not exist at all in the Western mode of thinking. Hence, translating them would render them thematically insipid or nonsensical. Achebe therefore decided to retain the words in their original language (Igbo). The same rationale applies to the use of Acoli words in Okot P' Bitek's *Song of Lawino and Song of Ocol*:

It means the moko dance « During the Ager period «

Chew the shoots of Lapena and Olim « Let the people drink kwete beer and Waragi «

The words underlined have no equivalence in English. Translating them may either mean using many words to describe them elaborately in order for their essence to be captured clearly, or only giving a meaning near the real meaning of these traditional ceremonies, epochs, vegetation and liquor.

(ii) To Give Clue of Setting

Foreign words can also be employed intentionally to give a reader a clue of the social or historical setting (or both) of a text. For example, the use of Kiswahili words in Ngugi Wa Thiong'o's and Micere Mugo's *Trials of Dedan Kimathi* places the book in its historical context ± Colonial epoch in which Africans strive for not only independence but also identity, having been deformed by Colonial powers socially, politically, culturally and economically. The use of Kiswahili especially in the songs (e.g: 'Tutanyakuwa mashamba yetu, Tupigania Uhuru wetu') is really one way in which Kenyans during the struggle for independence asserted their oneness in spite of the diverse ethnic groups. Even presently, Kiswahili is used profitably in giving us a sense of cultural identity. In Margaret Ogola's novel *The River and the Source*, persistent use of dholuo lexicons such as: 'jodongo' (elders), 'kon'go' (alcoholic brew) and 'nak' (removal of six lower teeth), among others, places the cultural context (Luo) of the text easily.

(iii) Giving a text a Local Flavour

In situating a literary text historically, socially, politically and culturally, the use of foreign words also give a text local flavour so that if it is an African situation reflected through the medium of the English language, the incorporation of words that belong to African languages gives the text a feeling of being truly African'.

(iv) Marking off characters and Portraying Alienation

Write may also decide to incorporate words from other languages other than the medium of delivery in order to differentiate characters or even demonstrate alienation on the part of some characters. In Ebrahim Hussein's play *Mashetani*, Juma and Kitaru's utterances are characterized by code-mixing (incorporating both English and Kiswahili). The language of these two young men indeed marks them off as educationally superior to other characters. And indeed, they are University students. Their kind of language does not just mark them off but also serves purposes of realism: reflecting the real talk of University students in African Anglophone countries. On the other hand, in the same text, mixing of English and Kiswahili is presented as a manifestation of alienation on the part of the superiorized bragging neo-bourgeoisie class such as Kitaru's mother who desires to be treated just like the Colonial Governors' wives. Kitaru's mother's use of sprinklings of English words in spite of her low educational level is satirical ± to lash at the brainwashed Africans who took the reigns of power from the colonialists. Instead of changing the society to an equitable one, they revelled in aping their former Colonizer's ways of doing things and relished being treated similarly by their fellow Africans.

Archaicism

³Archaicism refers to the use of old forms of words / obsolete words which do not belong to the modern period. The use by a modern writer of words such as: 'thou', 'thy', 'thee' and many more old forms, constitutes lexical deviation since a writer is expected to use the language of his times. A modern writer may employ such language for various reasons. The first reason is for purposes of authenticity. This is why in *A Grain of Wheat*, Ngugi Wa Thiong'o uses such language. Citing from the Bible, Ngugi has to be authentic:

Thou fool, that which thou sowest is not quickened, except it die. And that which thou sowest, thou sowest not that body that shall be, but bare grain, it may chance of wheat, or of some other grain.

The illustration above that appears on page 1 of the novel is a direct quotation from 1st Corinthians 15:36. Ngugi borrows from the Bible to authenticate the struggle for independence on the part of Africans and to underline the need for personal sacrifice if freedom is to be achieved.

Archaicism can also be employed for purposes of sarcasm as in Bwogo's 'The dumb speaketh' in John Ruganda's play *The Floods*. Bwogo uses the archaism in reference to Nankya who had all along been trying to give him the 'silent treatment', ignoring the former. Nankya is eventually tricked into talking. In this regard, Bwogo is alluding to the Biblical miraculous healings by Jesus Christ where the dumb were enabled to speak, the lame were enabled to walk and the blind were enabled to see. However, Bwogo uses the Biblical allusion for sarcastic ends.

In *Hard Times*, Charles Dickens employs archaicism satirically in regard to the intransigent characters:

When from thy boiling stone thou shalt fill each jar brim full
by-and-by, dost thou think that thou wilt outright kill the
robber fancy ± lurking within ± or sometimes only warn him
to destroy him. (p. 10)

Remember

Archaicism is only a case of employing outdated language. Thus, the use of such words as: 'thou', 'thee', 'thy' and the like in Shakespearean works does not constitute archaicism since that was the language of Shakespearean days.

Taboo Words / Obscenities

It is a rule (though unwritten) in Literature that a writer worth his / her salt should observe linguistic etiquette and steer clear of profanities. Indeed good writing demands that writers avoid offensive language. Aristotle viewed this as one of the main principles of not only literary expression but also sober communication. Veritably, just as we expect speakers to avoid using explicit language in ordinary conversation and to substitute indecently overt language in all regards with polite figurative expressions, we expect literary writers to behave in the same fashion. However, some literary writers choose to ignore the rule about language etiquette and deliberately incorporate vulgarities in their art in order to communicate effectively and plausibly. For instance, in *A Grain of Wheat*, Ngugi W a Thiong'o uses taboo words to attain 'a balance between modesty and realism' (Emmanuel Mbogo, *ibid*):

Gilthead said, ³I was not always like that, I swear by my mother's aged cunt, or that of an old woman',

Also, Lt. Coined says to his fellow Africans while talking of Dr. Lynd:
 'Man, I'll break her in, I'll swim in that hole'.

Ngugi uses foul language in the above excerpts in order to be realistic. This is because, the two characters speaking are victims of a violent environment and have therefore been hardened. They have been conditioned into throwing caution to the wind. This is revealed in their speeches. Further still, the profanities, especially in the second utterance, bring out the gravity of the animosity between the white and black people. The vulgarities employed by Koinandu underscore the bitterness that black people had towards the white colonialists.

In Meja Mwangi's urban novels, the author brings out the moral rottenness of the poor urban dwellers through such language. The frustrations of the poverty-stricken slum dwellers are seen in their carefree language in *Cockroach Dance*: 'pee in your pants', 'bitch, tight arse, pendulum', 'stinking shit'. Such obscenities are common utterances among the disconcerted, unhappy destitutes. Meja Mwangi doubtlessly uses his urban novels to give a gory view of the real life of the dejected have-nots in Urban areas. Owing to the difficult conditions they face every day, the poor people have become hardened. What more could authentically illustrate the beggary setting and psychological make-up of such frustrated and hardened characters than the language? Look at the following example:

³You' Dusman choked on rage, ³You, what wont they do to you? Hell. You landed yourself into real rut, cheepy vermin. First they will piss on you, then shit on you and mix you up. They will twist your head till your nose is in your rear end and you can smell your own dung. They will come for you in a big way!' (*Cockroach Dance*, pg, 364)

Big Words

The grammatical rule / rationale about choice of words is that a writer / speaker will select words that communicate. Communication can only be profitably achieved if a writer / speaker endeavours to be as simple as possible through utilization of ordinary clearcut, concrete words. However, literary writers may not always use language merely as an artistic tool for self-expression. At the level of words, writers may select deep, complicated, entangled or pompous language for purposes of equivocality to avoid being pinned down by some thin-skinned government or to satirize haughty or confused characters. In that regard, pomposity serves to create humour while at the same time

illuminating the braggadocio inherent or clatter-brain revealed in the use of bombastic expressions. This is what we see, for instance, in Wole Soyinka's play Kongi's Harvest:

Fifth: Naturally. I am a professional theoretician.
I must be paid for my services.

Also:

Nor proverbs nor verse, only ideograms in algebraic
quantums. If the square of xqy (2bc) equals QA into the
square root of X, then the progressive forces must prevail
over the reactionary in the span of .32 of a single generation.

Summary

In this lecture we have looked at how writers go against grammatical rules and principles of common sense and etiquette relating to vocabulary of a language, words or words formatives. We have seen that the lexical level too is an open system where writers have a certain degree of freedom to use words carefully to express certain ideas. Many of the words we use have shades of meanings impelled by how we use them and which other words we collocate them. It is at the lexical level that most creative writers use language with a lot of originality through positive or negative prominence, exploiting and manipulating linguistic items in unique ways. Neologism, archaisms, foreign language, taboo words and big words are exploited to achieve special meanings obtainable only through the use of these deviant elements

Activity

- (a) Account for lexical deviance in the following poem.
- (b) Comment on any other outstanding stylistic devices employed

Lord, should I trust Ye?

Thou shalt have none other gods before me W hile Polytheists
prosper and the faithful fail Thou shalt
not make thee any graven image
While the makers make monumental monies, become myths New
denomination for domination and reputation, no deputation.

Thou shalt not bow down thyself unto them nor serve them W hile
bowers bloom, servers survive Unbowers gloom, servers suffer.

Thou shalt not take the name of the Lord in vain
W hile vain-takers victorious, vanquish the veritable.

Six days thou shalt labour and rest on the seventh
W hile seven day workers rule the earth Six day
workers scrap the earth
All day God-talkers, scum of the earth.

Honour thy father and mother that thy days may be prolonged As disobeyers
and who keep mum and dad at bay
Are healthier, wealthier, appropriate ponderous pay Good life,
May to May, early grave, No way!

Thou shalt not kill
Patricide, matricide, infanticide, homicide, on the rise
Perpetrators and posterity in Paradise Palaces and
parliaments.

Thou shalt not commit adultery
As adulterous the wondrous, fornication is monstrous
Devoted to conjugal trustworthiness, you are doomed to loneliness
Debauchery is fashion, would you rather alienation?
Decadence is salvation, effervescent emotion Age is
but a number, Paedophilization is sober Rape, rape,
escape, aren't we just clothed ape? Then
bastardization and scott-free inattention
And child criminalization and dungeon reformation
And the unadulterous damnation, childlessness or artificial insemination.

Thou shalt not steal

As the thief becomes the Chief Robberman, noble
man.

Thou shalt not bear false witness
W hen fake affirmation flings into wealthiness.

Thou shalt not covet
W hen coveters are the getters Oh Lord,

Should I trust Ye?

Mugubi Magalo

Lecture ten

FLOUTING SEMANTIC PRECEPTS: the Literary rationale

Introduction

In the last lecture we discussed the forms of deviant vocabulary use and wordformation that writers may skillfully employ and pattern to relay various meanings and for emotive effects. In this lecture, we look at the rationale for violating laws related to meaning in literary works.

Lecture Objectives

At the end of this Lecture you should be able to:

- (a) Define the terms 'semantic redundancy' and 'semantic absurdity'.
- (b) Distinguish the related features of semantic redundancy.
- (c) Account for the use of semantic deviation in Literature.

Semantic Deviation

In our third lecture we said that *semantics* is the level of language that deals with meaning. Semantic deviation therefore entails widening and stretching the possibilities of language in terms of meaning. The grammatical rule about relaying meaning is that it should be clear, rationally intelligible, consistent, conclusive, incontrovertible, succinct and non-repetitious. However, literary writers may choose to be paradoxical, inconsistent, nonsensical, or preposterous, indefinite, vague, superfluous or wordy.

We will now look at forms of semantic deviance and reasons for their employment.

(a) Semantic Redundancy / Excessive usage of words / Wordiness

Good grammar emphasizes on conciseness and terseness in communication. Brevity and precision in communication are indeed regarded as hallmarks of a methodical and orderly psyche. Such organization keeps the readers or listeners perpetually alert and interested. A laconic presentation / utterance calls for a brisk mind since there are excessive words employed to clarify the idea further. One has to digest the substance of a curt utterance there and then. On the other hand, wordiness may irritate or fatigue the reader / listener especially if the expression can be said briefly and still be understood lucidly. Indeed, unnecessary repetition would be regarded as slovenly and an emblem of clumsiness, carelessness or sheer ineptness. However, in Literature, when a writer employs redundancy deliberately rather than adventitiously, such wordiness if investigated carefully and reflected upon, would not give the feeling of 'needless-extras'. 'Super-abundance' in Literature can serve many functions such as: to emphasize a point, to create various tonal shades or to beautify the work.

Let us now see how these functions are possible by looking at various forms of semantic redundancy.

(i) Tautology

From a Greek word meaning 'same speech', tautology is the collocation of words of the same category. At the surface, the words appear repetitive and uninformative. However, at a literary / connotative level, such words serve various aesthetic effects. Let us look at some examples:

³Me I said to myself, Taban cool it baby«
(Taban Lo Liyong, *Another Nigger Dead*, p. 57)

In the example above, Lo Liyong refers to himself thrice in the same expression: Me, I, Myself. Whereas at the surface value the expression may sound ridiculously wordy, at the literary level the determination of the persona (Taban) and the insistence on selffreedom are captured in the repetition.

Now think about the sagacity in the tautology Jared Angira employs in the poem ³Concord':

Over the sane sanity, W hich
happens to be elusive.

W hat do you think Angira means by ³sane sanity'? Can one be sane and insane at the same time? W hen one thinks deeply about this tautology, one garners the profound implication that sometimes the sane engage in maniacal, delirious acts that can only ³rationaly' belong to the irrational. W hen one thinks of members of parliament scrambling to receive small token (almost shamelessly little) gifts from interested parties in order to vote in a particular pattern on various key bills, yet such parliamentarians are extravagantly paid by citizens in order to articulate the latter's concerns, then one sees the ³dementia' of egoism and greed in these ³sane' members of the August house. W hen one thinks of the ³craziness' of a government that endorses sixty million dollars to be spent on rewriting a country's constitution then suddenly wakes up one morning to bastardize and trash the re-written draft that emanated from the citizens' views and in the process disregard not only the perspective of its people but also the huge amount of money used, then one begins to understand the tautology. Indeed insane sanity pervades us: mothers who procure abortion in order to ³maintain' their youth; men whose pride is in siring without caring about the products of their lecherous adventures; men who regard multiple sex partners and innumerable sex escapades a fad in spite of the decimating AIDS scourge; citizens who maim and kill each other merely because the mother speaks a different tongue or has a darker or lighter skin pigmentation; where leaders grab millions of acres of land from their electorate only to leave the land idle and then brazenly brag of their ³hard-earned' wealth; the list is inexhaustible. Surely, where will we find sane sanity amidst this madness? Sane sanity is veritably elusive in the present topsy-

turvy world where morality and fellow-feeling are becoming lexical items only to be found in the dead pages of books.

Tautology may also be employed in Literature for purposes of creating humour. This is what we see in Francis Imbuga's play *Aminata*:

Agege: Porcupine? Now that is double twice and « koroga koroga together all.

Agege is an idiotic character in the play yet the author's mouthpiece. Whereas we laugh at the tautology necessitated by his poor command of English, when we ruminate over his utterance, we are able to discern some wittiness. However, in the above example, tautology serves to create humour and laughter.

(ii) *Pleonasm*

Whereas tautology constitutes collocation of synonymous words, Pleonasm would entail expressing the same thing in many repetitive words. Tautology could therefore essentially be labeled Concise pleonasm.

An example of Pleonasm in Chinua Achebe's novel *No Longer at Ease* is in the following utterance:

'You hear?' Matthew asked. 'I have seen it with my own two eyes'

See also how Charles Dickens seemingly overstates the same point in *A Tale of Two Cities*:

«a very faint voice responded to the salutation, as if it were at a distance» The faintness of the voice was pitiable and dreadful « It was like the last feeble echo of a sound made long and long ago. So entirely had it lost the life and resonance of the human voice,

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that it affected the sense like a once beautiful colour faded away into a poor weak stain. So sunken and suppressed it was, that it was like a voice underground. So expressive it was, of a hopeless and lost creature, that a famished traveler, wearied out by lonely wandering in a wilderness, would have remembered home and friends in such a tone before lying down to die « (p. 47)

MWALIMU GREG.

In the above excerpt, from the outset, it is clear that Dickens is talking about a dimness of voice. It is also very clear from the first part of the passage that the voice is very dim: ³«as if it were at a distance’. However, Dickens goes on further to describe the dimness of the voice in a manner that at a surface level does not seem to add any value: ³feeble echo of a sound made long and long ago’, ³like a once beautiful colour faded away into a poor weak stain’, ³sunken and suppressed’, ³« was like a voice underground’, expressive ³of a hopeless, famished traveler, wearied«’. All these descriptions while only emphasizing the dimness of the voice, do not seem to say anything more. You will also note clear pleonastic expressions within the same clause or sentence such as: ³long and long ago’ (why repeat ³long’?),

³colour faded away into a poor weak stain’ (definitely if a colour fades, the resultant effects can only be a faint or listless shade), ³sunken and suppressed’ (a voice that is sunken is obviously suppressed). So what is Dickens saying through such a plethora of pleonasms? When one thinks about the passage critically, one will notice that the pleonasms elevate the faint voice to the pedestal of a human being so that the voice ceases to be just a voice but a living thing. Fundamentally then, what Dickens is saying is that the disposition of a voice, human or otherwise may be able to tell a story ± may be able to say a lot about a person. A person’s voice may tell whether the person is happy or sad, serious or jocular, peaceful or distressed, optimistic or despondent, contented or otherwise. In a nutshell, a sincere voice may be a reflection of the very being of a human. When we think about this, indeed, there is a lot of truth in what Dickens is saying.

(iii) *Periphrasis / Circumlocution*

³Periphrasis’ or ³Circumlocution’ is the literary expression that refers to the use of a longer expression in place of a possible shorter and explicit form of expression. Periphrasis therefore is the roundabout / indirect way of saying something. Periphrasis can be done for Euphemistic reasons or sheer sarcasm as in the following examples:

- (1) « My brother who dances so vigorously « Is a nobody he has no wife; He has brought home a woman whose womb has been sucked by a leopard.

(Okot P’ Bitek, *Song of Lawino*)

- (2) Jumba: I think it is the mosquito disease
Amata: bathe there, sleep there « and even go to the bush right there.

(F. Imbuga, *Aminata*)

- (3) He dug a little and feeling the desire to pass water « Two young women dressed for church passed near, saw a big man playing with his thing and giggled.

(Wa Thiong'o, N, *A Grain of Wheat*)

In the last two examples above, the speakers / personae employ circumlocution to achieve politeness / linguistic decorum by avoiding to mention taboo words. In the first excerpt, the speaker is being sarcastic at the same time in employing the periphrastic phrase 'he has brought home a woman whose womb has been sucked by a leopard' instead of: 'He has brought home a barren woman'. The use of many words here serves to emphasize the seriousness of human infertility in African societies (Acholi, in this case). Childbearing was and indeed is still highly esteemed in Africa. A woman or man who cannot bring forth children is still regarded as cursed person, a misfit.

In the second excerpt, 'mosquito disease' in lieu of 'malaria' illustrates the ignorance / educational level of the speaker. At the same time, such an expression may be a direct translation of an indigenous expression for / perception of Malaria. '«and even go to the bush right there' in the same

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excerpt is euphemism for relieving one's bowels at the particular place (my euphemistic explanation notwithstanding). In the third example again, 'to pass water' is euphemism for urinating or going for a short call whereas 'his thing' refers to a man's reproductive organ (Oh, how periphrasis can be inevitable in other regards). Consider the following lines from Jonathan Kariara's poem 'A Leopard lives on a Muu tree':

My medicine bags torn
My sword has rusted in the scabbard
The upright post at the gate has fallen.

The euphemistic description of the male reproductive organs not only makes the poem non-offensive to read but also allows the reader to be critical in deciphering the meaning.

(b) Semantic absurdity

The word 'absurd' means: illogical, irrational, dull-sounding, nonsensical; in a nutshell, saying or doing something in a manner that can only be termed incongruous and unreasonable. In Literary works, writers may employ expressions that border on the nonsensical at the literal level. However, at a deeper level such expressions are loaded with huge semantic relevance. Indeed, the core concerns of a literary text may revolve around the absurdity. Semantically absurd statements or expressions are usually either contradictory or ambiguous ± contradictory in the sense that opposite or antithetical words are collocated or a writer presents a situation where a word may present more than one valid meaning.

There are three main types of semantic absurdity: Oxymoron, Paradox and Ambiguity.

(i) *Oxymoron*

Also referred to as a concise paradox, an oxymoron is an epigrammatic expression that entails collocation of incompatible words - elements that belong to opposite semantic categories.

Expressions such as 'laborious

idleness', 'sweet pain', 'bitter honey', 'clever fool', 'brave coward' or 'democratic tyranny', are oxymoronic. Oxymorons therefore entail contradictions in terms. The title of Said Ahmed Mohammed's Kiswahili novel *Asali Chungu* is at one level oxymoronic. The concise paradox arises, as the two words that make up the title seem to contradict each other. Veritably, honey is considered one of nature's sweetest matters on earth. That Said Ahmed Mohammed should say otherwise about it creates a semantic oddity. Hence, the two words constitute a semantic deviation because, collocated, they violate sectional restriction rules. It is not conceivable that honey can be collocated with

'bitter'. However, on reading the novel, the 'preposterous' title makes a lot of sense. 'Bitter Honey' is seen as the result of the pleasurable life the wealthy are enjoying. Affluence and power have apparently turned the rich men into blind self-indulging, immoral dinosaurs who only worry about their self-aggrandizement while unmindful of the plight of the lowly. It is when such depraved rich people begin to pay for their iniquity that what had all along been perceived to be a 'honey-full', felicitous and luxuriant life turns awry, giving way to humiliation and guilt, that the 'bitterness' of the 'honey' (sweet life) begins to be seen.

In *Nobody Knows My Name*, James Baldwin talks of

'Criminally frivolous'. On the surface, this expression is an absurdity. A crime is something serious because we are talking of some depravity, some infringement, some sinfulness. On the other hand, something frivolous is unimportant, worthless, insignificant, vain or puerile. The combination of 'Crime' and 'frivolous' is therefore apparently anomalous. However, James Baldwin's point is that the argument by some white people that the black person is intellectually inferior to the white man is the kind of argument one may call a 'serious joke'. It is a joke in that this kind of argument is futile and petty. However, when the magnitude of the repercussions such 'shallow' reasoning can instigate can be disastrous, then such a futile argument may be deemed grave. Indeed, it is such a claim by some white racists, of supposed congenital mental inferiority of the black person that was used as a warrant by white people all over the world to subhumanize the black race and reduce black people to mere chattels. When such a trifling argument engenders momentous effects such as subjugation of one

group of people by another, enslaving of one people by another people and total discrimination of one breed of persons by another, then the foolish claim, with all its worthlessness, becomes something worth very serious attention.

Activity

In the tragedy of *Romeo and Juliet*, we witness a verbal ejaculation of a plethora of oxymorons. What do you think is the significance of these oxymorons in relation to the issues at hand?

Romeo: Alas that love, whose view is muffled still, Should without eyes, see pathways to his will:
Where shall we dine? O me what fray was here? Yet tell me not, for I have heard it all:
Here's much to do with hate, but more with love:
Why then O brawling love, O loving hate, O anything of nothing first created: O heavy lightness, serious vanity,
Mis-shapen chaos of well-seeming forms, Feathers of Lead, bright smoke, cold fire, sick health,
Still-waking sleep that is not what it is. This love feel I, that feel no love in this, Dost thou not laugh?

(ii) Paradox

A statement is said to be a paradox if it is seemingly self-contradictory and opposed to common sense and yet perhaps true in fact. It is not until the reader or listener thinks deeply about the utterance that he / she is able to perceive the profound meaning inherent in the contradiction. Think of the truism in the following paradoxes:

- (1) Religion tries to satisfy man while its essential purpose is to make him dissatisfied.
- (2) Water, water everywhere, but not a drop to drink.
- (3) The fool doth think he is wise, but the wise man knows himself to be a fool.

(iii) Ambiguity

An ambiguous statement / word allows for more than one possible interpretations. Many a times, literary writers may purposely employ equivocal words in contexts that permit multiple meanings. This

kind of situation goes against the grammatical rule of accuracy / exactness, unmistakable straightforwardness in communication. Be that as it may, literary writers may flout the rule either in order to avoid being pinned down by some political authorities thin-skinned to any form of criticism or to engage the reader's mind in trying to figure out what the writer exactly meant.

In Ngugi Wa Thiong'o's *A Grain of Wheat*, it is said that on the eve of independence 'the man' passed at the market and people cheered and sang his praises. There is double meaning here. We can interpret the man to be Jomo Kenyatta or Mugo.

In Jonathan Kariara's story 'Coming of Power', the title could signify either the establishment of a colonial regime or the installation of electricity at Kigwa-ini. Indeed the title accommodates the two interpretations.

Said Ahmed Mohammed's *Asali Chungu* can also be said to be ambiguous at another level. If the Kiswahili word 'Chungu' idiomatically means *plenty* (as in 'asali imejaa chungu' ± there is plenty of honey; 'kulikuwa na chungu ya wasanii' ± there were many artists) and *bitter* on another level, then the text can be given more than one meaning. Indeed, both interpretations relate quite well to the story in the novel. Plenty of honey is epitomized by the pleasurable life that characters such as Zuberi, Biti Daudi and Bushiri enjoy. However, we have also seen that this happy life can lead to wickedness, which ultimately turns the honey bitter.

Summary

In this lecture we have discussed semantic deviation as an aspect of stylistic realization. We have looked at features of semantic redundancy and semantic absurdity. We also endeavoured to account for the use of such deviation in Literature.

Activity

Interpret the philosophical implications of the paradoxes in the following poems by William Shakespeare and Jared Angira.

When most I wink, Then do mine eyes best See

W hen most I wink, then do mine eyes best see For
all the day they view things unrespected But when I
sleep, in dreams they look on thee And darkly bright
are bright in dark directed Then thou, whose
shadow doth make bright How would thy shadow's
form happy show

To the clear day with thy much clearer light W hen
to unseeing eyes thy shade shines so! How would, I
say, mine eyes be blessed made By looking on thee
in the living day.

W hen in dead night thy fair imperfect shade Through heavy
sleep on sightless eyes doth stay!

And days are nights to see till I see thee,
And nights bright days when dream do show thee to me. (W

illiam Shakespeare)

No Coffin, No Grave - Jared Angira

He was buried without a coffin without
a grave
the scavengers performed the post-mortem in
the open mortuary without sterilized knives
in front of the night club

Stuttering rifles staged the
gun salute of the day that
was a state burial the car
knelt
the red plate wept, wrapped itself into its master's blood his
diary revealed to the sea the rain anchored there at last isn't
our flag red, black and white? so he wrapped himself well

who could signal yellow
when we had to leave politics to the experts and
brood on book
brood on hunger and
schoolgirls
grumble under the black pot sleep under
torn mosquito net and let lice lick our
intestines the lord of the bar, money speaks
madam woman magnet, money speaks
madam we only cover the stinking darkness
of the caves of our mouths and ask our
father who is in hell to judge the quick and
the good

well, his diary, submarine of the Third World War showed he
wished
to be buried in a gold-laden coffin

like a VIP
under the jacaranda tree beside his palace a
shelter for his grave and much beer for the
funeral party

anyway, one noisy pupil suggested we bring tractors
and plough

Lecture eleven

OTHER FORMS OF DEVIANCE

Introduction

In the last four lectures we systematically dealt with how and why literary writers engage in four main forms of deviation: grammatical / syntactic, phonological, lexical and semantic. These are not the only areas where a literary writer may flout certain rules. In this lecture we will explore other areas where deviant literary manipulation is tenable.

Lecture Objectives

At the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- (a) Identify forms of title deviance and account for them.
- (b) Identify and justify aspects of structural deviance.

Title Deviation

Whereas linguists direct that a good title should be adequately expressive of the content of a text, many literary writers go against the cannon. Titles such as 'The Cockroach Dance' (Meja Mwangi), 'Shrine of Tears' (Francis Imbuga), 'Petals of Blood' (Ngugi Wa Thiong'o), 'Ripples in the Pool' (Rebeka Njau), 'I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings' (Maya Angelou), 'The Bluest Eye' (Toni Morrison), 'Crick Crack, Monkey' (Merle Hodge) or 'Invisible Man' (Ralph Ellison), are a case in point. If the µgrammatical rule was to be followed then most of Ngugi wa Thiong'o's early works would have words such as 'colonial', 'struggle', 'rivalry', 'land alienation' in the title. Think of a title like 'A Grain of Wheat' changed to an all-telling title 'The true Hero'. Indeed, the amended version of the title lacks

the curiosity created by the symbolic title 'A Grain of Wheat'. What if 'The River Between' was to be changed to 'Waiyaki' or 'Makuyu and Kameno'? The complexity of the novel which subsists on the dexterous weaving of paralinguistic features and themes that relate not only to the antagonistic ridges but also beyond the sociological and historical position of the 'Sleeping Lions' would apparently be lost. Again, the curiosity created by a title that focuses on topography rather than people would be heavily dissipated in the amended title.

Literary titles are therefore an aesthetic choice. Literary writers create titles that not only encapsulate the primary concerns of a text, but also that are powerful enough to enthrall and subdue the reader, creating suspense to an extent that the reader feels obliged to read the text in order to liberate his mind. Indeed, literary writers select enigmatic titles that necessitate the reader to unriddle them if he / she has to understand the content of the text. Reading a literary text therefore becomes an endeavour to unravel the mysterious title.

Literary titles are therefore a psychological choice. Human beings are fascinated and overpowered by the absurd, the cryptic. No one wants to be confined into some mental bondage. Puzzling titles therefore provide a challenge to the reader to liberate his / her psyche. Many a times, a literary writer would structure the content of his / her bizarre title in a manner that necessitates reading the whole work in order to perceive the connection between the title and the content. Hence, by the time the subdued reader comes to see the association between the title and meaning, unburden his / her confined mind, he / she has read the whole text smoothly, pleasantly and effortlessly. Literary titles are therefore a good strategy for ensuring that a text is read fully. A perplexing title, while whetting a reader's appetite, only makes sense at or towards the very end of a literary text.

Activity

Make a list of Literary titles that you have come across in your reading, which you regard as deviant. Try to account for such titles.

Structural / Generic deviance

Various genres of Literature have their own rules of operation. A novel subsists on continuous prose made up of sentences, paragraphs and chapters. A play ought to subsist on dialogue, divided into acts and scenes. A poem ought to be written in stanzas. However, Literary writers may deviate from the principles governing a particular genre. They may even borrow precepts of one genre and flagrantly use them on another. There are several ways in which writers can deviate structurally:

Literary writers may choose to deviate from the expected external structure. In print therefore, the appearance of a text visually violates the expected. This form of deviation is also intentionally done to contribute to the aesthetic quality of a text. For example, Jared Angira deliberately arranges his poem ³The Street' in an incongruous manner to depict the confusion, disorganization and disparities that characterize the urban centres:

scratch
scratch tiny
nails blocked
nostrils The
example above
constitutes
graphological
deviance since
the poem is not
structured in
stanzas (of
equal or
unequal
duration), as we
would expect.
What we
see are
unconventional
pictorial,

uneven,
unrelated
structures that
cannot even
constitute
poetic lines,
presented as
poetic,
unrhythmic
lines. (b)

***Amalgamation
/ Incorporation***

Literary writers may choose to borrow aspects of one genre and incorporate into a genre that originally lacks such features. For instance, a novelist may decide to be poetic or incorporate aspects of poetry in the novel. Likewise, a poet may decide to use aspects of drama or prose in poetry. In the novel *The Voice*, Gabriel Okara sometimes chooses to deviate from normal prosaic language to poetic language. Look at the following example:

Faces, a mass of faces glistening with sweat in the moonlight stood, talking, arguing. Grim faces like the dark mysterious forest afire with flies. Then a shadow blocked his view, then silence. And a voice clear and cool like a glass of water from the standing shadow salted forth.

The example above reads like a poetic stanza rather than an excerpt from a novel. Note the abundant use of sound features (consonance, alliteration, assonance and repetition) in: sweat, stood, moonlight, forest, afire, flies, clear, cool, standing, shadow, salted. Note also that there is no single grammatical sentence in the whole excerpt. Many words have also been ellipsed, making the passage read like a poem. Also, note the lavish use of imagery (similes and metaphors) akin to poetry.

In a Kiswahili novel *Asali Chungu* by Said Ahmed Mohammed, instead of the author presenting the story in the expected narrative form, in some places he adopts the format of stage direction in a scene in a drama:

Chumbani kwa Bw. D.C. Akarabu za saa ya ukutani
zaonyesha saa nne na vichopo. Nje bao refu linalotambaa na
ukuta limesaki mabibi wa kila aina.

Bi Pili Stahamala zimekwisha. Anachacharika baoni, tayari kumvunjia mbarika bwana D.C. Ubavuni pake; Bi ± Kikongwe aliyebugia chumvi ya kutosha, kajikunyata, anasubiri zamu yake. Katikati ya bao, jana-jike lenye jirim la kiboko linatia gati wenzake huku linapuma.

Translation

In the D.C.'s office. The hands of the clock on the wall show it is a few minutes past ten. Outside, on a bench set against a wall, are seated several women of every type and kind.

Madam Pili shows great impatience. She is restless and eager to tell off the D.C. Seated folded up on her side is a very old woman, waiting patiently for her turn. At the middle of the bench is seated a massive woman with a hippoish countenance chattering with her fellow women while breathing heavily.

(c) *Partitioning*

The rule about plays is that they ought to be divided into acts and scenes. Novels have chapters. Literary writers do not always obey this rule. Thus, instead of acts and scenes in *The Floods*, Ruganda decides to have *μwaves*. This is a purposed transgression that suits the island setting of the play. Indeed, we see political waves maiming (physically or psychologically) scores of people. We see waves of disillusionment and despair growing every other day as waves of dictatorship and indifference pervade, giving rise to tides that eventually sweep off the atrocious regime. There is a dynamic forward movement provided by the three waves, climaxing in a coup de tat.

Ngugi Wa Thiong'o and Micere Mugo also decide to use *μmovements* instead of Acts and Scenes in the play *Trials of Dedan Kimathi*. The use of *μmovements* here in lieu of the normal Acts and Scenes also tallies with the political themes attendant to the freedom struggle movement highlighted in the text. W ahome Mutahi's use of days of the week instead of chapters in the novel *Jail bugs*, is also a good example of deviant sectioning. Mutahi's choice also goes hand in hand with the diary-in-dialogue kind of presentation. Using days of the week as a point of focus, Mutahi is able to effectively, systematically show not only the time lapse but also the context of the novel in terms of the experiences of the prisoners: filthy food, lousy blankets, cloggy toilets, water shortages, escape from prison, among others.

(d) *Plot Arrangement*

A µgrammatical¶ plot begins at the very start, moves on to the middle and then ends (it doesn¶t just stop). A literary plot does not always move systematically. A literary writer may manipulate the plot in various ways for aesthetic effect. The writer may begin with the end or the middle. A literary plot may even end with the beginning. A case in point is Alex La Guma¶s *In the Fog of the seasons¶ end*. This novel begins with the very end. In the prologue we meet a prisoner being tortured. Neither do we know who the prisoner is nor whom his persecutors are. This is because, as readers, we have not been introduced to these characters. It is when we read the rest of the novel that we meet the character Elias Tekwane, in freedom, and subsequently, his engagement in activities that precipitated his incarceration and torture. This inversion of plot creates suspense as we would wish to know who the unnamed prisoner in the prologue is and what he did to deserve the (mis)treatment he gets from the detectives.

Ngugi also employs such an arrangement in his novel *Petals of Blood*. The novel begins with the arrest of Karega, Abdalla and Munira. Henceforth, through flashback, we are taken to the very beginning of events that led to the arrest. Curiosity in the reader is heightened by this strategy since he / she would crave to know why the trio has been arrested and would not stop reading until that curiosity is gratified.

Summary

In this lecture we have looked at other forms of deviation that cannot be classified under the major forms of deviance earlier discussed. We have seen how literary writers defy grammatical or literary conventions in terms of: titles, graphological presentation (in print), generic structures and µrational¶ plot arrangement.

Activity

- (a) Make a list of any literary texts which deviate in any of the following ways:
- (i) graphologically
 - (ii) In terms of generic conventions
 - (iii) In terms of plot arrangement
- (b) Account for the deviance in terms of thematic or aesthetic significance.

Lecture Twelve

CONFORMITY: syntactic

Introduction

In the last six lectures, we looked at various forms of deviance intentionally employed by literary writers in order to enhance the understanding of their text(s). In discussing foregrounding, we also noted that one could make an item stand out by conforming to the norms of language. What this means is that one does not necessarily have to deviate to foreground a linguistic item. In this lecture we will look at how this positive prominence may be achieved. Whereas in lecture seven we elaborately looked at aspects of prominence (negative) achieved syntactically, in this lecture we will concentrate on syntactic foregrounding achieved through conformity (positively).

Lecture Objectives

At the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- (a) define the word *conformity* in the literary sense.
- (b) identify aspects of syntactic conformity.
- (c) explain the literary import of such positive prominence.

Conformity

³'Conformity' in Literature succinctly alludes to adherence to rules of language and generic patterning in all regards.

Syntactic Parallelism

In lecture seven we noted that syntax is a branch of grammar that deals with word order. Therefore, at the syntactic level, there are sets of conventions which govern how and which words (can) combine to form meaningful utterances. That the subject of a sentence ordinarily comes before the predicate, for example, is a feature of English syntax. Words, phrases and clauses are all syntactic elements.

Positively, syntactically, writers majorly foreground through employment of parallel structures. Parallel elements ordinarily appear in lists or series, in compound structures, comparisons and in contrasted elements. Many parallel elements are linked by a co-ordinating conjunction such as *and* or *but* or by correlatives such as: *neither*, *nor*, *whether*, *or*. That notwithstanding, parallel structures can also be determined by the very similarity or contrast inherent in the syntactic construction. That is, parallelism is a syntactic device which is conditioned on the principle of equivalence. There is likeness (similarity) structurally as well as dissimilarity in terms of semantic function. This will be clear once we have looked at various patterns of syntactic conformity.

(a) The Loose Paratactic Sentence / structure

In order to suggest confusion, desperation, pain, loneliness and other forms of turmoil or jumble, whether physical or psychological, literary writers may choose to grammatically conjoin decentralized syntactic structures. These structures are decentralized and loose in the sense that they cannot exist on their own devoid of a main constituent. The structures are indeed loosely attached to each other. Thus, a loose paratactic or cumulative sentence entails loose syntactic structures where the main clause comes at the very beginning and is followed by subordinate clauses. These subordinate clauses are also referred to as 'trailing clauses / constituents'. Examples here would suffice:

- (i) He looked about ± at the benches ± at the table supported by crestles ± at his basket of tools ± at the stove where the furrity had boiled ± at the empty basins ± at some shed grains of wheat ± at the corks which dotted the grassy floor.
- (ii) Soldiers invaded the working class quarter of the city, breaking down the doors of houses, sticking bayonets in mattresses filled with grass and cotton, slashing open shacks of foofoo, beating with their rifle butts anyone who didn't answer the questions quickly enough, or quite simply cutting down anyone who dared protest at the violation of his home. (Dongala, E.B, 'The Man')
- (iii) Yes, she thought, Agatha deserved to be pitied; this girl who danced and raved down from salvation, from dawn to dusk every Saturday, who distributed free leaflets (she had once even sneaked upto Chris when Beatrice stepped out of the room and gave him one) yes, this Agatha who was so free with leaflets dripping with the saving blood of Jesus and yet had no single drop of charity in her own anaemic blood. (Achebe, C: Anthills of the Savannah, p.183)
- (iv) Such masters were not at that time easily found; Princes that had been, and Kings that were to be, were not yet of the teacher's class, and no ruined nobility had dropped out of Tellson's ledgers, to turn cooks and carpenters. (Dickens, C: A Tale of Two Cities)
- (v) We are all prostitutes, for in a world of grab and take, in a world built on the structure of inequality and

injustice, in a world where some can eat while others can only toil, some can send their children to schools, others cannot, in a world where a Prince, Monarch, a businessman can sit on billions while people starve or hit heads against church walls for divine deliverance from hunger; yes, in a world where a man who has never set foot on this land can sit in a New York or London office and determine what I shall eat «in such a world we are all prostitutes. (Ngugi wa Thiong'o: *Petals of blood*, p. 240)

In the first sentence, the main clause is the very first one: 'He looked about'. That three-worded clause constitutes a sentence and can stand on its own. It suggests a vexed mind; wandering owing to discomposure. The mental agitation goes further to imply some kind of trouble. The clauses that trail this main clause only give additional information as to what 'he' looked at. However, in totality, the structure suggests some kind of mental torment subsequent to some irritation or annoyance. The structures are loosely attached to the main one using hyphens. It is notable that without the first clause, the trailing constituents will be rendered meaningless structures. In the example from Dongala, the main issue is that 'soldiers invaded the working class quarter of the city'. However such a structure raises certain questions: why?, what happened after? Also, the word 'invade' tells it all. It does not suggest soldiers coming to defend the people or fortify the city against some attack. Rather, invasion intimates and indeed denotes some form of incursion, raid, onslaught, aggression; some kind of attack. The trailing constituents therefore serve to answer questions as to why the city was besieged and what followed thereafter. Also, the loose structures here serve to illustrate the chaos and suffering that followed the invasion: breaking into houses, plundering people's property, maiming and killing innocent people for merely protesting the desecration of their dwellings.

In the example from Achebe's *Anthills of the Savannah*, the main clause is: 'Yes, she thought, Agatha deserved to be pitied'. The rest are loosely attached to this clause. Here again, the loose paratactic structure performs a specific aesthetic function ± highlighting the inconsistency and absurdity of Agatha's character. A character who preaches water and drinks lots of wine, so to speak, is not an enigma but a walking embarrassment. Such a character, who is literally a house divided among itself and is not at home with herself, does not require condemnation but compassion and tenderness, if she is to understand herself.

The last example from Charles Dickens accentuates the unique talents of the teacher. Implicit in the emphasis of the unprecedented qualities in the main clause is the indispensability of the teacher, hence near despondency devoid of the teacher. Indeed, whereas rarity is greatly prized and revered, it may lead to hopelessness when nothing can be done to retain or maintain it. Therefore, the loose structure here also serves aesthetic functions: it suggests the helplessness of the people of this society without the teacher.

In terms of syntactic parallelism, you may have observed that some of the structures (like in the very first sentence) are repeated and similar in many regards. Most important, in all the sentences, the trailing constituents are parallel (similar) in the structural sense of the word. Firstly, they are dependent on the main clause. Secondly, they all merely give additional information about the main clause.

The last example is a curious structure, a near *μ*syntactic mongrel[¶] that borders on sentential cross-breeding. With the repeated clause ³'We are all prostitutes' at the beginning, the sentence comes out as a loose paratactic sentence; where all that follows serves to explain the main clause. However, with the repeated clause only at the end, the sentence can very well serve as a periodic sentence (we will look at the periodic sentence in the next section). As a loose paratactic sentence, the decentralized structures serve to bring out the annoyance of the speaker clearly. At the same time, aesthetically, the trailing constituents illustrate the alienation of the modern man from fellow man, the lack of humanism among men and the dehumanizing effects of a capitalistic system ± in a nutshell ± indignation at the ignominious indifference of the haves towards the have-not and the discrimination and subjugation of men by men.

(b) *The Periodic Sentence*

Read the following sentences and try to establish the grammatical behaviour:

- (i) When he was fifteen, six feet tall, // and trampling round at school dances with the girls from the *μ*sister[¶] school in the same town; // when he had learnt how to tease and flirt and fondle quite intimately these girls who were the daughters of prosperous farmers like his father; // when he had even met one who, at a wedding he had attended with his parents on a nearby farm, had let him do with her in a locked store room what people did when they made love // - when he was as far from his childhood as all this, // he still brought home from a shop in town a red plastic belt and gilt hoop earrings for the black girl Thebedi. (Nardine Gordimer, ³'Country Lovers', *Looking For a Rain God*, p.67)
- (ii) In the hardest working part of Coketown; // in the inner fortifications of that ugly citadel, where nature was as strongly bricked out as killing airs and gases were bricked in; // at the heart of the Labyrinth of narrow courts upon courts, and close streets upon streets, which had come into existence piecemeal, every piece in a violent hurry for some one man[¶]'s purpose and the whole an unnatural family shouldering, and trampling and pressing one another to death; // in the last nook of this great exhausted

receiver, where the chimney, for want of air to make a draught, were built in an immense variety of stunted and crooked shapes, as though every house put out a sign of the unkind people who might be expected to be born with it; among the multitude of Coketown, generically called 'the hands' ± a race would have found more flavour with some people if providence had seen fit to make them only hands, or like the lower creatures of the show only hands and stomachs// - lived a certain Stephen Blackpool, forty years of age. (Dickens, C: *Hard Times*, p.63)

- (iii) When we are harsh and hurl abuses, when we refuse to forgive, when we blunt people's hopes, when we tear reputations down, yes, when we do and say all these things that make a human being feel a little less wanted, a little less effective, a little less happy to that degree, we have begun to kill God's spirit in our fellow man. (Mulwa, D: *Redemption*, p.69)

The main clause in the three long sentences comes at the very end. The sentences begin with subordinate clauses followed by the main clause. Since the subordinate clauses create a feeling of expectation, they are also referred to as anticipatory constituents.

In the first sentence, there are a total of five clauses. The first five all anticipate the main clause: 'when he was as far from his childhood as all this; he still brought home from a shop in town a red plastic belt and gilt hoop earrings for the black girl Thebedi'.

In the second example by Dickens, the core of the sentence or what Dickens really wanted to put across is the existence of a 'hand' named Stephen Blackpool. The anticipatory clauses give us a description of the city in which Blackpool lives. Thus, before we are introduced to the character Blackpool, we have a picture of where he lives and the circumstances prevailing. It is clear that the circumstances are not enviable. There are a total of six clauses here beginning: 'In the hardest working part', 'In the inner fortifications'.

That the anticipatory clauses in a periodic sentence anticipate a main clause (also known as the 'punch line'); they create suspense at the sentence level. Heightening expectation in the reader, the anticipatory clauses finally lead to the gratification of the expectation in the punch line. The reader falls onto the main clause with satisfaction. The build-up inherent in a periodic sentence that climaxes in a 'punch line' also creates a dynamic forward movement. Psychologically, such a structure moves the reader's emotions up and down as he / she anticipates the main clause. Such a structure moves effortlessly in terms of its reading making the reading interesting. The reader will not stop reading until his / her curiosity is gratified.

The periodic structure is widely used in Para literature such as film. Popular soap operas such as: 'The Bold and the Beautiful', 'Santa Barbara', 'The Rich also Cry', 'Lady of the Rose', 'Camilla', 'La Muher de Lorenzo', 'Days of our Lives', among others, employ such a structure where all episodes begin pointing towards some happening. At the end of the programme, one's expectations may be gratified. However, the scriptwriter ensures that he / she introduces something else that will continue maintaining the sense of expectation. The resolution of this 'something else' will be suspended to ensure that the viewer watches the next programme. As the sense of expectancy is sustained *ad infinitum*, the viewer is unconsciously 'enslaved' to the programme.

In novels, the novelist may choose only to resolve a conflict at the end of a chapter while introducing another conflict whose resolution he suspends, making chapters end at a point where the reader is left hanging in anticipation. Such a technique is called a 'Cliff-hanger'.

The periodic structure or end-focus is also employed in poetry. Henry Barlow poem 'The Village Well' is a good example. The persona does not tell you what happened by the well until the very end ± that the one he first loved died by the well.

The periodic structure derives from an old rhetorical principle ± that the most important thing ought to be said at the end. Thus, one rule about the periodic sentence is that since it taxes one's memory while creating suspense, the punch line must justify the waiting. And indeed, looking at the three examples, the punch line justifies the waiting. Look at Nardine Gordimer's sentence. Reference is made to a man's childhood escapades, but the punch line comes in handy to show that the affection this man had for the black girl Thebedi, in his childhood, was no mere child-like infatuation. He still harbours feelings for the girl in his adulthood. In the sentence by Dickens, whereas we have been told the circumstances under which the 'hands' lived, the punch line serves not only to introduce Stephen Blackpool but also to heighten our curiosity about this character. In the last example from David Mulwa, the main clause comes as a bombshell: that when human beings are unjust to each other, they kill God's spirit in fellow men. What can be worse than 'murdering' God's spirit in a fellow man?

N/B

A grammatical periodic sentence does not necessarily have to be long. For example, 'Suffering from Kidney Failure, John's father died' is a simple and short periodic sentence. Indeed, the length of a periodic sentence determines the degree of anticipation.

(c) *Antithesis*

Antithesis is a form of parallelism which entails the juxtaposition of contrasting ideas. The piling up of the positive and negative meanings of words or expressions produces a form of balanced opposition. Let us now look at practical examples:

- (i) You taught school, I attended school You initiated people; I was an initiate
You were a minor clerk; I was a member of the Assembly You were a minor actor; I was a spectator
You were hissed off the stage, I joined in the hissing Your policies supported our enemy, mine, our country

(Desmothenes, ³On the Crown')

- (ii) «I don't know for how many years. They lived together sharing everything, their joy and sadness. They got in well, they crossed swords, they reconciled; they sulked at one another, they agreed with one another, they suspected each other, they withdrew their suspicions. And days passed by until today when they are still living together.

(S.A. Mohammed: Asali Chungu, p.43, translated from Kiswahili)

- (iii) Time and space seemed to lose their meaning and their abruptness; the minutes slid into hours, and the meadows and fallows sloped away into middle distance, softly and imperceptibly. Wild weeds of the hedgerow struggled into the flower-garden and wall flowers and garden bushes made counterattacks into farmyards and lane. Sleepy looking hens and solemn preoccupied ducks were equally at home in yard, orchard or roadway; nothing seemed to belong definitely anywhere; even the gates were not necessarily to be found on the hinges. And over the whole scene brooded the sense of peace that had almost a quality of magic in it; in the twilight you knew that it could never have been anything but twilight. (Wash, W: 1985, p.166)

In the first example, you will observe that there is a considered pattern where arranged with an obvious caesura, the stanza has one half contrasting what is in the second half: You taught school ± I attended school. This pattern is prudently maintained throughout, making the

clauses stand out as structural equivalents. This pattern clearly brings out the difference between the two characters alluded to in the poem.

In the second example, the life of the two unnamed characters is made vivid through the unusual compiling of actions in the positive and in the negative. Such compilation has a notable foregrounding effect.

In the last example, aspects of nature are juxtaposed firstly to bring out the confusion that reigned before finally some tranquility was attained.

The General Significance of Parallelism

Parallel structures can be used to:

- (i) express matching ideas
- (ii) reinforce grammatically equal elements
- (iii) contribute to ease in reading while at the same time enhancing interestingness of a literary text
- (iv) reinforce memorability of a text. Indeed, parallel structures make literary texts easy to remember
- (v) provide clarity and rhythm

Summary of sub-section

In this sub-section we have endeavoured to show that contrary to what some critics claim, a literary writer does not always have to deviate to make a literary work powerful. We have seen that at the level of word-order, a writer may conform to grammatical rules and still bring out his / her ideas forcefully. The loose paratactic sentence is such a structure that clearly sheds light on the state of the mind of the character being portrayed. We have seen how the periodic sentence involves the reader psychologically. We have also seen how piling of opposites side-by-side helps not only clarify a writer's point, but also emphasizes the same.

Activity

Giving examples of syntactic variation (at the level of Conformity), discuss the significance of such stylistic realization in literary works.

REPETITION

Although in a restricted sense the rules of grammar advise against repetition (so that repeating oneself can on one level be considered deviant), repeating grammatical structures can also be considered part of conformity.

Hence, although the literary writer is using the same words intentionally, the words are grammatically employed. Repetition in Literature can achieve various effects ranging from: creation of suspense, emphasizing a point, for satirical reasons, for purposes of being ironic, and many more. Let us now sample a few examples and evaluate the advantages of using repetition:

(i) **I beg You** ± Laban Erapu

I beg you,
If you feel something like love for me
Not to let me know it now
When I feel nothing so certain for you ± W
ait until you've conquered my pride By
pretending not to care for me.

I beg you,
If you think your eyes will give you away
Not to give me that longing look

When you know it will force the moment
± Wait until our hearts have settled Then
put your head on my shoulder.

I beg you
Not to let us surrender to passion, Until
our liking has grown to love Let's stop
and look back
Let's draw apart and sigh

(ii) From *Song of Lawino* ± Okot P. Bitek

The white man's stoves Are for
boiling cabbages
And for baking the light spongy thing They call
bread

They are for warming up Tinned
beef, tinned fish Tinned frogs,
tinned snakes Tinned peas,
tinned beans Big broad beans
Tasteless like Cooco!

(iii) *Death of An Eland* ± Henry Barlow

Those eyes
Those liquid green eyes
Tearless yet crying
Terrified and silent
Imploring for mercy
Those eyes haunt me

We stood and looked at her Emaciated with
hunger and pain
Lying on her side with the festering leg
Dripping with pus held in the air
Trying in vain to heave itself up with her other leg

Those eyes!
The terrified liquid eyes
Fervently transmitted pleas for mercy And the
body shook with terror and pain The
emaciated legs kicked feebly Trying to get
her up
W here she had tripped and fallen
There were ticks on her belly Some
were fat and bluish green
And there were numerous small brown ones The
eyes begged! Those haunting eyes

The hunter said in a matter of fact way It is
kinder to shoot her And raised his gun
There was a kick and a feeble neigh The
body relaxed; the neck fell back The
eyes looked at me
Still pleading
As if the hunter had not been merciful And I
stood there Feeling foolish

I noticed the ticks Still
sucking
I walked away With
liquid eyes
And followed the hunter.

In example (i), the deliberate repetition of the line 'I beg you' at the beginning of every stanza enhances the mood of the poem: a pleading mood in which the persona, a patient young man, is begging for restraint. The repetition underscores the need for the two friends to understand each other, strengthen their love before allowing passion to come in.

In example (ii), there is an aspect of both emphasis and satire. While emphasizing that Westerners depend on entirely tinned (and refrigerated) food, stored for long periods such that it loses its taste, the persona is also making a statement about an alien culture which she considers laughable: a culture where people are lazy to cook fresh food. The choice of items 'tinned' is also intended to enhance the satire: that Westerners are so bizarre that they do not discriminate when it comes to what they eat ± that they are capable of feeding on anything under the sun.

In the last example, the repetition of the phrase 'Those eyes' creates some kind of lamentation for the dying eland, achieving a sympathetic tone, evoking pity in the reader for the dying horse.

You will also note that the repetitions in all the three examples create a kind of rhythm. In the first example, the repetition of the line 'I beg you' in each stanza make each stanza stand out as a rhythmic unit. However, rhythm is a subject for another lecture. Our onus in this lecture was to establish that foregrounding can also be achieved through repetition and that repetition in Literature has all kinds of advantages.

Activity

Now account for the repetition in the following poem.

They killed themselves

She told him: 'To Hell!
He hearkened the bell
She jumped into the rivals lap

He jumped into a ceaseless nap
Chasing dreams, chasing hopes
Who wants to be rickshawed W hen
she can be Benzed? Who wants
glum W here there is plum? Who
wants cheap nylon W here there's
chiffon? And he killed himself.

He told her: 'To Hell! ' And went
for another belle
How could she bulge without permission? Who
wants to be her permanent station? Who wants
yelps to impair his eardrums, Distract concentration,
Scrawls and scratches at preciousness Pulls and
prods at wealthiness,
Soil and soak of treasure
W hile pruning his plenteousness? Who wants
to be daddy
W hen t'would rather be buddy?
He escaped the napkin But became
a bumpkin She took 'To Hell' in
tears Afraid of jeers.

He killed himself
Ate the uneatable cassava W hen
there was so much grass, So much
mud, so much leaf, So much wood,
so much word to eat
He didn't want the help hoarded at the Chief, Why should
he plead, pay for relief?
Could as well nourish on grief
Cereals, cereals, no beef
Why should he seduce for wheat?
And he munched the cassava And
down, down the cliff He went
stiff.

She killed herself She
swallowed her own heart
Couldn't survive the pressure
Twenty-one on one in darkness, after work God's
gift for man played gift to men, Two months
atonement, acquitted
And God's gift for man plays gift to men And

God's gift for man goes to God And two
months atonement still the mode And she
kills herself.

He killed himself
He ran too much
Couldn't run slow, keep with peers Why crave
to be first
When you could be second, third or fourth, Even
last?
Age must be respected
The first have to be first
Those who follow mustn't go past Keep
to your position.
He killed himself.
He sprinted to his death Sprinting for
his life.

She killed herself Over- talked
her lungs She ran out
of air talking, Talking of
embezzlement When the
funds kept mum
Talking of nepotism As
if she wasn't a mum
Talking of bribery
As if ignorant of our wage sum Babbling about
bloodshed
Don't we eat beef, torment the cowshed? And
she ate herself with bullet Then roasted
herself like fillet Then flung her meat into the
Tsavo
And they laughed singing Bravo!
They'd intercepted the salvo And
we believe ± She killed herself.

They killed themselves They
loved the fuss.
Crammed into the overloaded bus,
The old cheered at the over-speeding lad Regarding high
speed a fad.
And he really drove like mad
Driving like a game of card He

forgot about now Thinking
only of the ³wow! '
Then he saw the on-coming trailer
And he wished he were a sailor
It was too late, He met his fate.
They crushed into an ugly mass And there
wasn't e'en an ugly nurse
Not even a quack preacher to read a verse Not
any crocodile wailer, such a curse! They killed
themselves.

They killed themselves
Refused to die when they should have died Their
world ended Their Jesus returned
But they refused to go to heaven
They desired their earthly haven
Another life with their prophets.
³Take all your riches to God
And you shall be blessed hereafter'. They
sold e'en their souls, Peddled to their
preachers
But they refused to die when they should have died. Then they
wanted their wealth, their souls,
They wanted life and wife like their pastors And so
they had to die of knife
And they died when they should have died,
Ripped their bellies open, Strangled their own
necks
Bombed themselves Buried themselves
at night
While their pseudo-priests sang:
³Till we meet at Jesus' feet«' Praying
for another life, Another
congregation of goons, Praying for
another loot,
³Till we eat at another fete'

Mugubi Magalo

Summary

In this lecture we have looked at aspects of conformity. We have seen that writers can achieve variety at the sentence level through creation of complex sentence types while at the same time conforming to grammatical norms. We have

also seen how syntactic parallelism is achieved at various levels and the effect to which it may be geared at. Lastly, we have seen the many advantages that repetition as a feature of conformity may have.

Lecture Thirteen THE

SUPRASEGMENTALS

Introduction

This is our thirteenth Lecture in this unit. When studying sound features in literary works, we tend to focus on sound features as realized in the segments presented in a text, or symbols that have phonic potential. However, not all attributes of the *μorality* attendant to a linguistic symbol are reflected plainly in the symbol. Certain phonological features, very crucial in apprehension of literary works, cannot be marked graphologically but we appreciate them when we hear them. These are the features we refer to as 'Suprasegmentals'. They are also commonly known as 'Prosodic features'. In this lecture, we will examine the literary significance of such sound features which are not marked in print.

At the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- (a) define, describe and identify the various Suprasegmentals
- (b) Explain their use / effect in Literature

The Suprasegmental Level

The word *μSupra* means *μabove*. 'Suprasegmental' therefore means

³above the phoneme'. Thus, Suprasegmental features operate at a plane higher than phonemes (segments). Instead of being marked graphologically as units of sound, suprasegmentals are only heard. They are deciphered mostly in terms of loudness and speed. That is, suprasegmentals are construed through variance in loudness in an utterance or through the speed of articulation of an utterance. For example, irony or sarcasm in a phrase like: ³Oh yes he is intelligent' may not be deciphered in a literary text unless there is further elaboration which makes the irony or sarcasm clear. However, spoken, a mocking tone would bring out the sarcasm in the phrase. No further elaboration would be required. Also, the speed at which a literary work is articulated verbally would suggest various shades of emotions such as: agitation, annoyance, melancholy, adoration, passion, gratification and many others. An agitated character will speak faster than one expressing fondness or sorrow.

In phonic analysis, after deciding which phonemes were spoken, we usually just examine phonemes for changes such as voicing, nasalization, aspiration or any other characteristics of the segment of the utterance that is being analyzed. Once that is done, the analysis is considered complete. However, at the level of sound, an analysis is required that takes account of dynamic sound units larger than the sound itself. This is in recognition of the fact that sound units, while decipherable into phonemes, are very dynamic and may be manipulated variously for different reasons. For instance, a speaker may change point(s) of emphasis in a word or a sentence for purposes of making some meaning clear. Because they affect the meaning of an utterance, suprasegmentals also affect meaning(s) of literary texts. While this truism is

clearly obvious in performed texts such as poetic recitations, songs and drama, Suprasegmentals also influence meaning in written texts. This is because a good writer writes as if he / she is talking to the reader. Consequently, a good reader ought to intone the written words as if they are being articulated aloud. This way, he will be able to gain a deeper understanding of the writer's intentions. Charles Dickens, for example, was known to prudently use alliteration, assonance, consonance, rhyme and even metre in his novels. One has to intone such texts correctly to comprehend them fully. Apart from influencing the meaning of the text, suprasegmentals will evidently impact on the aesthetic disposition or beauty of a literary text. Stress and metre would create some melodiousness in poetry. Stress may also create similar musicality in drama and prose. While creating symmetry or tuneness textually, the variation in loudness in texts may be used to not only produce but also enhance a variety of themes: conflict, change, peace, amity and many others.

Now let us look at types of suprasegmentals:

Stress / Accent

Used interchangeably in this course, ³stress' or ³accent' refers to the emphasis or loudness with which a syllable, word, phrase or sentence is produced. In stress, we give certain syllables, words, phrases or sentences more prominence than others. This prominence is inferred in the way we control loudness, giving selected components more emphasis than others. A stressed item will be slightly louder and slightly longer than an

unstressed one. Consequently, a stressed / accented item calls for more expenditure of energy than an unstressed one ± a stressed element involves a forceful push from the chest wall and subsequently a more energetic force of exhalation. A certain sound or some sounds in a spoken word or utterance will be heard to be more conspicuous than others. Even where a word has more than one prominent sounds ± save for a few disyllabic words where both syllables are stressed ± one of the protruding sounds will stand out more than the other(s).

There are three kinds of stress:

(1) *Syllabic Stress*

Syllabic stress refers to the emphasis of a syllable in a word. Thus, there is a contour, a peak, at the word level so that a syllable stands out when a word is intoned. For example:

(a) *Perfect*

(b) *Funny*

(c) *Excellent*

(d) *Education*

In the first two words, the first syllable is longer and louder than the second syllable. In the third example, the first two syllables are longer and louder than the next syllable.

Syllabic stress may be predictable in some languages. This is the case in Bantu languages of Africa. In most of these languages (if not all), syllabic stress is on the second last or penultimate syllable in a word. Let us look at some examples from Kenyan Bantu languages:

(a) Person

Mtu - Kiswahili

Mudu ± Kikuyu

Omonto ± Kisii

Omundu ± Luhya

(b) Love

U**p**endo ± Kiswahili
Lu**k**undo ± Taita
Obu**k**heri ± Luhyia

(c) A male person

Mwan**a**mume ± Kiswahili
Mu**l**ume ± Giriama Mur**u**me
± Kimeru

From the examples above, it can be observed that it is the second last in the words from the seven different ethnic groups named that is stressed. Shifting stress onto a different syllable only distorts the meaning of the word. Imagine reading the following Kiswahili sentence with the stress pattern changed as indicated:

Bwana Athuman**i** alikuja kwetu jana akatuletea za**w**adi nyingi sana.

Placing an accent on the syllables indicated only results in a clownish kind of pronunciation that may only elicit laughter when employed in a comedy but pity if not disgust if used by an adult in real life.

Syllabic Stress in the English Language

Whereas syllabic stress is very predictable in phonetic languages, it is not predictable in English. Hence, coming up with a concrete formula of pronunciation in English is almost impossible. However, reliable syllabic patterns may sometimes be observed when one examines the English language critically:

(i) Disyllabic words and words of Anglo-Saxon Origin

In such words, one normally accents the first syllable. Thus:

ma**r**ry
mi**g**hty
he**i**nous
gr**u**dge

no**r**mal
fla**i**r
pu**r**e
sa**c**red

drone
love

kindred
welfare

Even when affixes are added to such words, the stress pattern remains more or less the same:

Marry ± marriage ± marriageable ± unmarried

Grudge ± begrudge ± begrudgingly

Love ± lovely ± loving ± loveless ± unloving

Pure ± purity ± impure ± purified

Sacred ±unsacred

Even when such a word acquires secondary stress through affixation, the root syllable is still stressed. When the primary stress shifts to another syllable, as in ³abnormality' or ³purified', the root syllable still maintains some secondary stress. However, one may choose to shift the stress purposely to emphasize an issue. For instance, one may choose to stress the prefix ³un' in ³unsacred' in order to stress the negation. The same case can be applied in: ³irregular', ³unmarried' and ³impure'.

Note

In most prefixed words, the stressed elements will be more than one so that not only is the prefix accented but also the strong sound in the original word. (see .vii. for more clarification)

- (ii) Abstract nouns ending in ±ion, in the English language usually behave like Bantu words. Hence, one accents the second last syllable:

discrimination

reputation

gratification

administration

abomination

motivation

machination

pacification

salvation

revolution

- (iii) All words ending in $\pm$ ty, the accent is generally placed on the third last syllable:

celerity

captivity

anxiety

sincerity

antiquity

veracity

divinity

variety

firmity

charity

enmity

curiosity

security

community

intensity

felicity

serenity

regularity

- (iv) Words ending in $\pm$ cial, -tial or $\pm$ dual, one stresses the third last syllable:

superficial

partial

facial

official

financial

provincial

gradual	essential residual	habitual
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- (v) In words /adjectives ending with $\pm ic$, the stress is on the second last (penultimate) syllable:

anaemic	caballistic
asoteric	cathartic
fanatic	eclectic
intrinsic	alcoholic
barbaric	forensic

- (vi) In multisyllabic words ending in $\pm ing$, also, one stresses the second last syllable:

singing	dancing
excruciating	perplexing
carping	domineering
farming	passing
verifying	importuning

- (vii) In most words formed by appendaging a prefix to an ordinary term or in compound words, there are usually two accented syllables: (a) the prefix will customarily be stressed and (b) an element in the main / original / root word:

non-payment	malformed
prejudge	over-rated
disobey	misinform
interdisciplinary	half-heartedly
Arch-deacon	ex-wife
anti-progress	irresponsible
impatient	unskilled

illegal

invisible

- (viii) In some homonymic words, stress is determined by meaning intended such that the same word may function as a noun, verb or adjective. For example:

Noun**increase****exercise****implement****compliment****insult****conduct****produce****moderate (adj)****manifest (noun or adj.)****record****Verb****increase****exercise****implement****compliment****insult****conduct****produce****moderate****manifest****record****Note**

The syllabic stress rules suggested here are just guides, neither exhaustive nor conclusive. You need to read more on English phonology from texts on Phonetics (English).

(2) Word stress

In every language, when words are uttered, some words are pronounced with a greater degree of stress than the neighbouring words in a sentence. Such words are said to be pronounced with an accent or a strong stress. Unaccented words are said to be unstressed. The rule in the English language is that only semantically imperative or tersely communicative words in a sentence would be stressed: nouns, verbs, adjectives and adverbs. Pronouns, articles, conjunctions, prepositions and auxiliary verbs, which have to be appendaged to the communicative words to make sense and have no capacity for enlightenment just on their own, are usually not stressed.

(3) Phrase or Sentence Stress

In normal talk, we regularly choose to emphasize some words or sentences in order to make our meaning clear. It follows therefore that phrase or sentence stress is tied to meaning in the sense that we select the items to stress depending on the message we want to convey. Such selective stress is very important in communication to the extent that if we were only to talk μ normally with the expected grammatical syllabic stress, we may not only sound suppressive and reserved but also ambiguous, vague or totally obscure. Human speech is not just about grammatical material transmission. Human speech also incorporates emotion and mood so that from the selective prominence of some words, one may tell a speaker's agitation, disquiet, joy sadness, fear; in a nutshell, a speaker's mental disposition. Human speech also incorporates beliefs, convictions and passions. This will be discerned from the stress

pattern at the phrase or sentence level. Indeed, communication that only encompasses grammatical stress would be μ structurally humdrum, tiresome and thematically foggy and unintelligible.

Pitch

In word, phrase and sentence stress, we have said that such words, phrases and sentences are emphasized more than others by controlling how loudly we produce them.

This means that we pronounce the words, phrases and sentences at a higher pitch than others. 'Pitch' refers to this loudness occasioned by the frequency of the vibration of our vocal chords. Pitch is the indispensable apparatus of preference for emphasis at syllabic, word or sentence level. Consequently, pitch is the fundamental element of phonetic stress in English.

Intonation

Closely related to Pitch is 'intonation'. Intonation refers to the pitch variations within an utterance. An utterance in this regard alludes to an assemblage of speech or pronouncements which ought to be enunciated or expressed continuously within one breath. Such an assemblage of words is also referred to as a 'tone-unit'.

Tempo

In speech, we can also emphasize our message by controlling the speed with which we articulate our words. Tempo in Literature refers to the quickness with which we make our utterances or enunciate literary matter. Tempo can therefore be used effectively to suggest tardiness, inaction, briskness, urgency, urge and others. In this regard, therefore, tempo in performance would effectively connote or convey: annoyance, worry, tranquility, reconciliation, subjugation, adoration, tenderness and many other themes. Pause also contributes to the speed of a speech such that pausing deliberately (not respiratory pausing) at some point in a speech would give certain words more prominence than others. At times, such deliberate pauses may suggest confusion, nervousness, anxiety or forgetfulness.

Summary

In this lecture we have looked at **Suprasegmentals** or **Prosodic** features. We have seen that **Suprasegmental** features allude to communicative activities which accompany language but which are not themselves part of language. We have seen that these activities are crucial in Literary works in terms of creating or changing points of emphasis and in terms of suggesting a whole range of themes.

Activity

What are **suprasegmentals** and why are they important in Literary studies?
Illustrate from Literary works of your choice.

MWALIMU GREG.

Lecture Fourteen

RHYTHM IN LITERATURE

Introduction

In the last lecture we looked at the significance of prosodic features in Literature. The cumulative effect of such Suprasegmentals is in the creation of rhythm. This should not be misconstrued to mean that rhythm in Literature is an exclusive territory of the Suprasegments. In this lecture, we will look at the major components that contribute to Rhythm in Literature. We will see how rhythm is achieved in the major literary genres.

Lecture Objectives

At the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- (a) define the word rhythm from a purely literary perspective
- (b) identify the literary devices that contribute to the rhythmicity of literary texts
- (c) account for rhythmic effects in Literature

Rhythm

Webster's Third International Dictionary defines ³Rhythm as:

An ordered recurrent alternation of strong and weak elements in the flow of sound and silence in speech including grouping of weaker elements around stronger elements, the distribution and relative disposition of Rhythm of strong and weak elements

and the general qualitative relations of these elements and their combination. It is also the regular recurrence of similar features in a literary text.

Raymond Chapman defines rhythm as 'the distinctive but variable pattern in the spoken utterance of a language; the deliberative use of regular and recurrent'.

Hugh Holman conceives of rhythm as:

The passage of regular or approximately equivalent time interval between definite events or the recurrence of specific sounds or kinds of or the recurrence of stressed and unstressed syllables.

Looking at the foregoing definitions of the term 'Rhythm', one thing is clear – the element of regularity. Indeed, this tallies with the origin of the term. Rhythm is derived from a Greek word *ῥυθμός* which means 'to flow with regularity'. However, the definitions looked at, or most definitions generally (see *Dictionary of Stylistics*, Frank et.al, *Music of Poetry*, Olembo, W. and others) harp on the regularity of linguistic components. It is also possible to create rhythmic effects through employment of extra-linguistic components. For instance, the shape of something can be said to have some kind of rhythm. Likewise, in Literature one can discern some physical rhythm of a text even before reading it. This rhythmicity will be enhanced by the arrangement of the components of the text. For example, Richard Wright divides his novel *Native Son* into three sections: Fear, Flight, Fate. Psychologically, this partitioning creates some rhythm even before one has read the text. One can imagine the *fear* in a character which makes him flee or make certain blunders in life as a result of which he has to take *flight*, whereupon, his *fate* is finally decided. Such a structure will psychologically strike one as being rhythmical. Think of a poem in print with stanzas that have the same number of lines, of equal duration. Again, such a structure, physically, will strike you as having some rhythm. Rhythm is therefore also achievable at the extra-linguistic level.

Rhythm in Literature is a reflection of rhythm in Life. Various aspects of nature will strike you as being rhythmical. Think of the way seasons give way to each other. For instance, in the Western world, Winter – Spring – Summer – Fall follow each other faithfully. A case where winter suddenly appears in the middle of summer, with severe sub-zero temperatures, snow and all, may not shock some people out of their wits but will definitely cause confusion and disquiet among many people. Locally, we expect December to February to be hot if not dry as well. March to May

is normally wet though not so cold. June and July and part of August are rather chilly. September to November though a little wet are usually moderately hot. This is the pattern we have come to know so that we can even plan: when to prepare our farms, what to wear, what activities, indoors or outdoors, to engage in, and so forth. Think also of your heart beat, it has a regular tempo. The way we talk $\pm$ I have never met somebody who speaks very fast and very slow, very loud and soft, all at the same time, except in comical dramatic enactments. Everyone has a talking pattern which makes it easy to pick out the person even if he is talking from another room. The way we walk is also rhythmical such that you can easily pick out a person from afar just from the rhythm of his / her walk.

As a reflection of such a rhythmical life therefore, Literature cannot avoid being rhythmical. Indeed, to assert that Literature can be conceivable without rhythm is to proclaim that honey is conceivable without sweetness or that life is conceivable without life. This is because rhythm is enmeshed in Literature in such a way that the two cannot be separated. Rhythm is part of the artistry or design of Literature just as it is part of the design of life. It is the sweetness of honey that its consumers cherish. Squeeze the sweetness out of honey (if at all this is possible) and it ceases to be honey. In the same way, rhythm makes Literature what it is besides making Literature very sweet to enjoy. So we may assert that it is only the degree of rhythmicality in works of art that may vary. One work may be more rhythmical than the other as different literary artists strive to create varied aesthetic effects.

Now let us see how Rhythm is achieved in various literary genres.

Rhythm in Poetry

It is correctly argued that of all literary genres, poems are more rhythmical. Indeed, as a genre that relies more on various sound effects owing to its brevity and compactness, poems are more rhythmical than the novel.

In poetry, firstly, the graphological structure will strike you as having some rhythm. The poet usually organizes his poems into stanzas of equal duration in all regards. Each stanza comes out as a rhythmic unit. Secondly, the dynamic flow of ideas from one stanza to another, creates rhythm.

Metre, virtually an exclusive property of poetry, when employed, contributes immensely to the rhythmicality of a poem. In metre, as we saw in our first year

Introduction to Literary Genres course, there is an interplay or alternation of weak and strong syllables, creating a mathematical beat that makes the poem very pleasurable to listen to.

In Kiswahili mashairi, the original metric structure consisted of two halves in a stanza $\pm$ one half on the left and the other one on the right, with a caesura. Each half was composed of eight syllables. For example:

Dunia kweli mwendani, mithili kama mizigo
Kiwa peke maishani, mizaniye si kidogo Hutoibeba
baini, yalemea kama gogo Tabaki hakuna kogo,
dawamu kuwajazia

(Salim Ali Kodi)

The whole stanza above consists of eight syllables in each half; making the stanza very rhythmical.

During the Shakespearean age and during the Renaissance generally, poetry without some deliberate metrical pattern was unthinkable, and if any, underrated and perceived as vulgar (poetically, that is). The writers of such poems were looked down upon and dismissed as second-rate artists. Whereas current poets, both in Kiswahili and English poetry, have immensely deviated from the traditional pattern and rarely employ metrical structures, rhythm in modern poetry is achievable in other ways (some of which have already been mentioned).

Repetition is also widely used in poetry to create rhythmic effects. Repetition in a poem may take the form of a repeated word, phrase, or even a whole stanza. In all regards, repetition creates some musicality in a literary text:

Atieno washes dishes Atieno
plucks the chicken, Atieno
gets up early
Beds her sacks down in the kitchen Atieno
eight years old Atieno yo

Since she is my sister's child,
Atieno needs no pay
While she works my wife can sit
Sewing every sunny day
With her earnings I support
Atieno yo.

In the example above, 'Atieno' is repeated several times. This serves to remind us that this poem is not only about Atieno but also of the injustices perpetrated against the child by her own relative. The repetition of the girl child's name serves to evoke (in the audience) feelings of revulsion and antipathy towards the uncle for his wickedness towards a helpless child. On the other hand, the repetition helps to appeal to the audience's emotions of

compassion and sympathy for a subhumanized person. Consequently, apart from creating rhythmic effects, repetition may serve to achieve various aesthetic / thematic effects.

The use of onomatopoeia, assonance, consonance, alliteration, rhyme and other sound devices in poetry, may also enhance the rhythm of a poem:

Stanza 1

From the West
Clouds come hurrying
Turning
Sharply
Here and there
Like a plague of locusts
Whirling
Tossing up things on its tail
Like a mad man chasing nothing.

Stanza 2

Clothes wave like tattered flags Flying off
To expose dangling breasts As
jagged blinding flashes Rumble,
tremble, and crack Amidst the smell
of fired smoke
And the pelting march of the storm.

(David Rubadiri, ³An African Thunderstorm')

In the example above, onomatopoeic words such as µwhirling¶, µrumble¶, µtremble¶, µcrack¶ and µflash¶, when read aloud effectively, in cahoots with use of alliteration (in µcloud-come¶, µtossing-tail¶; consonance in µjagged-blinding¶, µrumble-tremble¶) and use of assonance, fruitfully give one the feeling of a storm, owing to the rhythm inherent. Note also that the rhythm of a storm is enhanced in the first stanza through the sheer suspension of grammar: there is no single punctuation mark save for the full stop at the end. The lack of punctuation marks serves to show the speed of the movement of the whirlwind heralding a storm. The very short lines µTurning¶, µSharply¶, µHere and there¶ give a breathless, rushed effect suitable for a sudden storm. Onomatopoeic words µwhirling¶, µwhistling¶, µrumbling¶, µtrembling¶ and others either imitate the sound of the wind or thunder before the storm. Veritably, therefore, rhythmic effects in Literature do and ought to enhance meaning.

Rhythm in Drama

In drama, rhythm is achieved scene-by-scene, act-by-act. In traditional drama, the division was a mechanically designed rhythmical structure:

- (1) **Introduction** ± The first part called the *introduction* would introduce the conflict.
- (2) **The Exposition** - Coming immediately after the introduction, the exposition would be an exposure of the conflict in all regards.
- (3) **Climax** - Here there would be rising action all the way to the peak of the conflict.
- (4) **Falling Action** ± having reached its zenith, action in a play has no further space on top. The only way now seems downwards. Falling action therefore marks the descent.
- (5) **Denouement** - Falling action leads to a resolution of the conflict(s). Denouement therefore would entail a resolution.

Such a structure essentially constitutes a dynamic forward movement towards a resolution. It is therefore intrinsically very rhythmical.

This is the kind of structure we see in John Ruganda's *The Floods*. Having artfully decided to use waves in place of Acts in order to suit his island setting, Ruganda's first wave is brief and effectively acts as an introduction to the conflicts in the play. The second wave is longer, exuberant, profuse and dynamic in its thematic coverage. The lengthy wave involves the exposure of the atrocities perpetrated to the people by the regime in power. The third wave, which is the longest, is the culmination of everything up to the resolution. This third wave is the absolute divulgement of the abominations inherent in that society and climaxes in a coup de tat. The rhythm in such a structure therefore highly contributes to the meaning of the work. Ruganda wants us to imagine the waves of the floods drowning people. The third wave is the strongest, a tsunami of sorts that swallows up even the perpetrators of evil, who used to think they were not only indispensable but also superhuman.

Imbuga's *Burning of Rags* begins with an introduction of characters: Matilda; the apparition of Denis' wife, Yona; Denis' son, Agala; the father of Denis, and others. The play opens with the ghost of Matilda attempting to circumcise Yona. This is an abomination in that land ± a woman cannot circumcise a man. The spirit of Matilda torments Denis' father, Agala. Matilda was the first wife of Denis. She committed suicide after some disagreement.

In the second scene of Act I, the conflict is introduced to the reader through Denis's letter that he cannot find time to come and attend his son's circumcision ceremony and that he would rather take his son to hospital. Agala refuses to have his grandson circumcised in a hospital. As the play moves into scene five of Act I, the conflict rises towards the climax. Yona is to be initiated traditionally after all. However, his father Denis does not have a house at home to accommodate the initiated son. Also, Denis does not want to stay for the whole ritual yet certain rites such as the burning of Yona's rags cannot be performed in the absence of the initiate's father. An argument ensues between Agala and Denis.

In Act II, Denis returns to the city and refuses to attend the final ceremony. The boy has to be taken to the city for the ritual to be performed there. But disaster ensues. Denis remains uninterested. The events lead to Agala's sudden death. In the last pages of scene II, Act II, there is falling action towards denouement. The death of Agala marks a turning point in the life of Denis. Denis examines himself and seeks to rectify his flaws. Denis apologizes to regain his relationship with Hilda, a woman whom he had refused to recognize as a wife. This is a sign of his retraction to the traditions of his people. Denis resolves to embrace the culture of his people.

In a nutshell, Imbuga's ***Burning of Rags*** powerfully demonstrates the rhythmical interaction between the introduction, exposition, climax and resolution.

In drama, rhythm is also maintained through the rhetoric of dialogue. Dialogue can be varied to depict the tempo of the play according to the situation obtaining within a character or between characters. Short and fast paced dialogues are usually employed in moments of panic, tension, and excitement or in moments of anguish. Slow-moving dialogues will be employed to suggest boredom, to bring out themes of love, loneliness, gratification, tenderness, benevolence, loyalty and the like. Panic, tension or excitement are manifested in quick tempo and therefore fasten the pace of the play. This is best illustrated in the final episode of John Ruganda's ***The Burdens***. As the book comes to a close, the long utterances that were there as mother and son interacted cordially diminish into three or one-worded utterances. The stunted or compacted talk is occasioned by the agony and mental affliction that Tinka undergoes after murdering her husband:

Kaija: What is that long red scratch, mother? Tinka:
Where?

Kaija: (Showing her) There

Tinka: Oh, this? It's a nail scratch. Finish your breakfast. We
are going.

Kaija: Going?

Nyakake: Going?

Tinka: Telling him what? (p.77)

In dramatic dialogue, rhythm is also attained through variation in loudness. For example, characters at one point whisper, at other times they yell at each other. The variation often turns out to be rhythmical.

Rhythm in Prose Fiction

Rhythm is manifested in prose fiction in various ways: sentence structure, tonicity, cataphora, cliff-hangers, alternation of dialogue and narration, and through the structural organization of the work. In lecture twelve, we looked at two main types of sentences: the loose paratactic sentence and the periodic sentence. Both sentences are rhythmical because of the syntactic similarity inherent in the trailing or anticipatory clauses. The periodic sentence quoted from Charles Dickens's *Hard Times*, for instance, is very rhythmical. Rhythm is heightened by the series of anticipatory clauses leading to a main one. Note how the dependent clauses begin in a peculiar fashion, either 'At the' or 'In the'. Such a structure in all clauses, makes the reader anticipate a conclusion. In this way, a kind of inner rhythm is created such that there is a build up to a climax, which is the conclusion. When Dickens starts his sentence 'In the hardest working part of Coketown' but only goes on to describe the locality without telling the reader what exactly happened there (since the reader's feeling is that Dickens is not just describing the place but wants to talk of some occurrence or notable incident), this creates a longing for an answer. But the answer comes only at the very end 'lived a certain Stephen Blackpool, forty years of age'. Before we reach the conclusion, Dickens has moved us up and down emotionally as we crave to know what really happened at that part of Coketown. This suspense-full up and down psychological manipulation of the reader creates an inner rhythm in not only prose but also any other genre of Literature. We had earlier mentioned that the periodic structure is also employed in a poem like 'The Village Well' by Henry Barlow. All the stanzas begin with either 'By this well' or 'In this well'. However, in all the stanzas save for the last one, Barlow does not tell us what we expect him to tell us. He is merely reminiscently narrating what used to happen by the well, yet we concretely feel that there is something else he wants to tell us. However, Barlow keeps that important information until the last two lines. And the information comes like a bombshell 'worth having waited for' 'For she is dead. The one I first loved by this well'. Here, Barlow powerfully captures our emotions and moves them up and down. In this case, there is a dynamic forward movement towards an answer.

In novels, the dynamic forward movement, which is essentially very rhythmical, can also be achieved chapter by chapter. A writer takes his readers to a very high point where the reader's expectation of something is immensely heightened. Just as the reader expects something major to happen, the author ends the chapter. Meanwhile, the anticipation on the part of the reader had not been fulfilled and so the reader automatically, even unconsciously, curiously moves on to the next chapter, hoping that his expectations will be satiated. The writer may do two things in this succeeding chapter: either satisfy the reader's expectations while introducing another conflict which will not be resolved in the same chapter, or maintain the suspense by leaving a conflict unresolved and keeping the reader hanging

emotionally. The point at which the reader anticipates something to occur but is left hanging as the chapter ends is referred to as a *Cliffhanger*. Such a technique makes the reader read on and on since he is captivated and left to hang at crucial points. Consequently, he has no option but to read on and on. The emotional up and down movement created by such *cliffhangers* creates an inner rhythm.

In a cataphoric reference in the novel *In the Fog of the Seasons*¶ *end*, Alex la Guma introduces a prisoner in the prologue. The unnamed prisoner is being tortured by some policemen. However, before we get to know who the prisoner is, why he is being persecuted, and what his eventual destiny is, La Guma has already shifted the scene to Beukes and Beatie Adams in the Municipal park. We only get to know much later about Elias Tekwane (the

prisoner in the prologue), his life history, what eventuated his arrest and how he is manhandled to death without disclosing any vital information about the underground movement, which he championed. Also, after Beukes is shot in the arm, we wonder what next? We expect him to give up the struggle and return to Frances, his wife; but this does not happen. Instead, he goes ahead to Henny April and makes certain that the four volunteers are transported north for military training. Here, there is also inner rhythm created by the profuse suspense inherent in the strategic structural arrangement of the novel.

In the episodic novel *Coolie*, Mulk Raj Anand also employs a structure that creates suspense all through and, accordingly, captivates the reader¶s attention to the very last word. Although systematically narrated, unlike *In the Fog of the Seasons*¶ *End* where the writer chooses to transpose the structural order in order to achieve the same effect, *Coolie* moves in a manner that keeps the reader always asking: what next?, will things be any better? First, Anand tells us of the fourteen-year-old Munoo and his predicament in the rural area of India, Kangra Hills. Despite losing his parents owing to socio-economic injustices perpetrated upon his family by some unfeeling landlord, Munoo¶s life is idyllic and the boy is somehow happy in the custody of his uncle and aunt. However, features of capitalistic exploitation have also permeated the rural areas of India and Munoo has to leave school while still in middle primary school in order to make a living as a servant of a middle class Indian family in Sham Nagar. However, the boy¶s hopes for a better life in the urban centre are shattered when he is showered with bestiality by his employer¶s wife, who has no regard for his kind. The boy is underfed, is nagged, beaten, and all kinds of insults hurled upon his innocent head. The boy is made to sleep in the kitchen and is thoroughly overworked. For all the trouble, the boy is worth only three rupees as monthly pay, which is all taken by his uncle. When Munoo complains to his uncle about the mistreatment he undergoes in his employer¶s house, the uncle, a self-seeker who is only after getting favours from Munoo¶s employer, flogs him for complaining. In view of the cruelty Munoo experiences in Babu Nathoo Ram¶s homestead, we do not expect the boy to go back to the same house when he leaves to go and complain to his uncle. But Munoo goes back. It is only later when he finds it impossible to bear any further molestation that the boy flees, with no concrete agenda. Drifting without any tangible plan of action, the boy finds himself in a Pickle and Jam factory in Daulatpur. Things get better here under a benevolent employer, Prabha. However, Prabha has a partner, Ganpat, a malevolent person who only delights in unleashing his

frustrations and caste spite on the blameless factory workers. Later, the factory is bankrupted by the villainous Ganpat and Munoo has to slave in the vegetable and grain markets. All the time, as the boy drifts from place to place in search of a better life, we keep hoping that things will get better for him. Instead, life under Bibiji, the rancorous wife of Nathoo Ram, repeats itself when he finds himself in the hands of diabolic employers. Whereas the boy veritably enjoys momentary favour with some philanthropic employers such as Prabha or the generally good-natured but eccentric Mrs. Mainwaring, in most cases things only get worse. When at last he is in the hands of the unear-philanthropic but psychologically jumbled Anglo-Indian Mainwaring, where he is treated more like a human being in spite of the sexual insinuations, we expect Munoo, at long last, to lead at a favourable life. Yet, subsequent to the energysapping rickshaw-pulling job, the boy begins to cough blood and dies from Tuberculosis.

There is rhythm in the structure enumerated above, which captivates the reader's emotions to the very end of the story.

Intonation, tempo and punctuation marks, in the reading of syntactic structures in prose, also contribute enormously to the rhythm of literary prose:

She was gone by and by and the day went after her, and the lights sprang up again, and the express whirled in full sight of the fairy palace over the arches near ± little felt amid the jarring of the machinery and scarcely heard above its crash and rattle. (Dickens, C. *Hard Times*, p.79)

In the example above, there is rhythm brought about by the use of commas and hyphen. The rhythm is also achieved through the repeated use of conjunctions. Proper intonation and tempo would also enhance the rhythm of such a sentence and any other sentence since a good reader reads as if he is talking. Intonation in prose is indicated by the stress pattern. According to Geoffrey leech and Michael Short:

Written prose contains an implicit unspoken intonation indicated by punctuation marks. When the length of the unit follows a regular pattern the text progresses with some dynamic movement. (Leech & Short, *Style in Fiction*)

Hence, short sentences grouped together, as the ones usually found in plays, would create a definite rhythm. In the same respect, use of short or long sentences together or a regular inter-change of the two types, would also constitute some rhythm. Indeed, any sentence, however uttered, constitutes some rhythm. This is because Literature derives and is

composed of words that are used in normal discourse. Therefore, no matter how they are phonologically manipulated, words must be produced in a manner that would make them convey some sense. The tendency towards rhythm is therefore strong such that the moment one starts to read a work of art, there is an inner voice which automatically rhythmizes as completely as possible the matter supplied.

To be able to understand a writer like Charles Dickens; a writer who wrote with a listening audience in mind, a writer who on completing a novel would endeavour to read it orally publicly, one needs to take note of the significance of all prosodic and phonological features. Such features veritably abound in Dickens's novels. Look at the following example where Dickens uses alliteration in prose:

A clattering of clogs upon the pavement; a rapid ringing of bells; and all the melancholy mad elephant. (*Hard Times*, p.68)

Note the alliteration of the consonantal sound μcl in the first clause. In the second clause you have μU and there is μP in the last clause. Note also the alliteration of the vowel sound μD in all the clauses. There is also use of consonance μW and μS in the first and second clauses. There is also assonance in the first clause in the repeated use of μR in $\mu clogs$, μof , and $\mu upon$. In the second clause there is assonance in the use of sound μL in 'rapid' and 'ringing'. In the last clause there is use of assonance μH and μD in 'melancholy' and 'elephant'. The cumulative effect of such intense employment of phonological features together is the establishment of an invigorating rhythm. However, in the rhythm, the author brings out the monotony that characterized the industrial revolution. Note that while doubtlessly captivating, the rhythm is entrenched in harsh sounds (alliteration - μcl and μU , consonance $\pm \mu S$ and μW). These suggest the harshness that the working hands experienced at that time. Overworking for a pittance was the order of the day. The 'melancholy mad elephant' here alludes to the monotonous train that was continuously transporting the hands from one industry to another.

As we have already mentioned, rhythm in prose may also be created by alternating short and long sentences. The following example from Peter Abraham's *Mine Boy* is a good one:

The third cage filled up. Xuma was the last to get in. That was as it should be. The boss looked after every one, saw that everyone was safely in, then gave the signal and jumped as the cage began to move.

Note that the first three sentences are short and therefore quick in pace. However, the pace slows in the fourth sentence which is much longer. Note also how the rhythmicity in the fourth long sentence is enhanced by the pauses.

Alternation of dialogue and narration in prose also creates rhythm in literary texts. For example on page 79 of Chinua Achebe's *No Longer at Ease*, there is a near regular alternation of dialogue and narration which renders paragraph one, two and three very rhythmic.

Repetition in prose has the same rhythmic and sometimes semantic effects that it contains in poetry. Look at the description of Malay Camp and Vrededorp in Peter Abraham's *Mine Boy*:

And the men in the streets spoke in loud voices, and took out their purses and counted their money for others to see. And they wore their best and most colourful clothes. Red shirts and green shirts and yellow shirts and pink shirts. And they wore wide bottomed trousers that swept the ground and tight jackets that reached only as far as their waists. (p.27)

In the excerpt above, the repetitious use of 'and' even at wrong places creates 'musicality' in the prose. There is also repetition of 'shirts' and 'they'. The cumulative effect of the repetitive use of 'and' is not only to express continuity in action but also to underscore the cacophony inherent in the class-display of wealth.

Talking about the eccentric Mr. Thomas Gradgrind, Charles Dickens employs repetition in the novel *Hard Times* to reinforce the outlandish physical disposition of the character, which in effect, reflects and reinforces the character's preposterous world outlook:

«the emphasis was helped by the speaker's square wall of a forehead» The emphasis was helped by the speaker's mouth, which was wide, thin and hard set. The emphasis was helped by the speaker's voice which was inflexible, dry and dictatorial. The emphasis was helped by the speaker's hair» The speaker's obstinate carriage, square coat, square legs, square shoulders ± nay his very neckcloth, trained to take him by the throat with an unaccommodating grasp« all helped the emphasis« (p.3)

The repetition of the phrase 'the emphasis' in the example above serves to reinforce the themes on 'hard facts' that Gradgrind is enunciating presently. The 'squareness' of all that belongs to Gradgrind impresses on his over-emphasis on only all that was 'factual'. Hence, in this case, the rhythm has also imagery and symbolism veiled behind it. The reader has to unveil the symbolism to understand it. In this sense, behind the repetition there is also satire. Gradgrind is being satirized for his overemphasis on facts.

Summary

In this lecture we have looked at the manifestation of rhythmic effects in three literary genres. We have demonstrated that rhythm in Literature is attained through linguistic and extralinguistic features such as: repetition, alliteration, consonance, assonance, rhyme, intonation, stress, pause, tempo, loudness, sentence variation and structural arrangement of literary works.

Activity

With illustrations from any literary works of your choice, show why it is important to take note of rhythmic effects in literary works.

Lecture fifteen

FIGURES OF SPEECH

Introduction

This is our fifteenth lecture in this course. From rhythmic effects and their significance in literary discourse, we now embark on exploring various uses of language which transgress customary semantic construction. Ideally, figures of speech ought to have been discussed under 'Semantic Deviation' since they involve intentional departure from

the conventional order in not only construction but mostly, meaning. Figures of speech indeed expand the meaning(s) of words through the transference of meaning. In this lecture then, we shall not rigidly look at figures of speech as a form of deviation but as a common component of literary language derived from its commonality in man's languages all over the world. Our enterprise here will be to explain the manifestations of the various figures of speech while, most importantly, account for their usage in literary language.

Lecture Objectives:

At the end of this lesson you should be able to

- (a) Name the various figures of speech.
- (b) Identify their peculiar characteristics.
- (c) Evaluate the impact of their usage in Literature.

What are Figures of Speech?

In our introduction, we have said that figures of speech depart from normal construction and meaning. What exactly does that mean? Figures of speech are a semantic category and hence the deviance inherent is realized at the level of meaning. In a nutshell then, figures of speech depart from semantic construction in order to illustrate similarities in dissimilar things. Hence, in essence, figures of speech entail an aspect of comparison. In the comparison there is transference of meaning. Whereas most figures of speech operate on comparability, not all figures of speech entail a clear component of comparison. The comparison in some figures of speech such as the Litote may not be immediately clear because they may affirm or negate using the contrary but not in the absolute sense. Indeed, some figures of speech only seek to create pictorial effects which serve to make the meaning clear.

Figures of speech are therefore not just a decorative additive to language. Metaphors go beyond enlivening and dignifying ordinary language. The elements compared in a metaphor would in most cases be familiar to the people of a particular place and time. The familiar is therefore made unfamiliar through the µstrange¶ combination. 'Dead Souls' would strike one as an irregular combination ± especially to persons whose religious upbringing instructs them that whereas the physical body dies, the soul remains alive

forever. For a soul to die, then that is the very final µdeadness¶. And what would surely precipitate such µultimate deadness¶? Such an µabnormal¶ combination therefore sets one thinking of the possible implications. It comes out that moral decadence, miserliness and wantonness in all (im)moral respects can indeed precipitate such µterminal deaths¶. Hence, by combining familiar terms in an µanomalous¶ manner in a metaphor, the literary artist does not only enthrall the audience / reader. Apart from the abnormal combination attracting and ravishing the audience, it sets them thinking as to the possible signification of the seemingly uncanny association. The metaphor subsequently leads to clarity when the import of the association is seen. Clarity is brought about by reference to ordinary objects and employment of everyday words. Aesthetic delight and allure is brought about by the intellectual gratification that comes with the discernment of fresh associations in metaphors. Each µfresh¶ combination of familiar in unfamiliar ways but in an µincongruously¶ congruous fashion, comes out as a new experience and therefore psychologically fulfilling.

Note

It must be noted that the psychological fulfillment on the part of the audience is only attainable when the transference in a metaphor does not appear far-fetched or ridiculous all together. Indeed, a metaphor that appears far-fetched can only lead to obscurity or mediocrity rather than clarity.

Forms of Figures of Speech

(i) *Simile*

This is a figure of speech that entails overt comparison. Thus, the open ground of likeness is verbalized. The comparison is explicit rather than implicit. A simile would use verbal elements such as 'like' and 'as'. The formula is: X is like Y, or Y is as X. This means that in terms of interpretation a simile is limited in its semantic scope. The interpretations of the similarities or dissimilarities between X and Y have to be limited to the subject of comparability, be it tallness, foolishness, hardness or whatever it may be:

- (a) She is as stupid as a mule
- (b) He is as tall as a giraffe
- (c) Margaret is as slow as a tortoise / snail

In spite of their limited scope, similes can be of enormous semantic significance. Let us look at the following example from Okot P'Bitek's *Song of Lawino*:

The white man's
stoves Are good for
cooking White men's
food:
for cooking the tasteless Bloodless meat
of cows
That were killed many years
ago And left in the ice To rot!
For frying an egg
Which when ready Is
slimy like mucus.

For boiling hairy chicken In saltless
water,
You think you are chewing paper!
And the bones of the leg Contains
only clotted blood And when you
bite
It makes no crackling sound, It tastes
like earth!

The white man's stoves Are for
boiling cabbages
And for baking the light spongy thing They
call bread.

They are for warming up Tinned
beef, tinned fish Tinned frogs,
tinned snakes Tinned peas,
tinned beans Big broad beans
Tasteless like Cooco

They are for preparing Foods
for the toothless,
For infants and invalids.
It is for making tea or coffee!

You use the saucepan And the
frying pan
And other flat-bottomed things,
Because the stoves are flat Like
the face of the drum.

The earthen vegetable pot Cannot
sit on it,
There are no stones On which
to place
The pot for making millet bread.

The similes in the example above have a dual function ± creation of humour while satirizing a culture foreign to the persona. Indeed, the thought of a people who can feed only on food that is comparable to mucus or tasteless like earth or μCooco¶, is not only laughable but also repulsive. Lawino¶s indignance and hatred for a culture that has encroached into her society and threatened the existence of her esteemed traditions, her very being, is vividly and effectively underscored by the similes employed. The similes used are therefore more powerful than saying the white man¶s culture is detestable, disgusting, base, rotten or whatever adjective one may wish to employ.

(ii) *Metaphor*

The word metaphor originates from the Greek word μmetaphora¶. μMetaphora¶ entails compounding of two Greek words μMeta¶ and μPherein¶. While μmeta¶ on one hand means μover¶, μpherein¶ means μto carry¶; hence, to carry over. Fundamentally then, metaphors are figures of speech in which the literal and figurative attributes of one thing are transferred or μcarried over¶ to another thing without verbalizing the grounds of comparison so that the comparison is implicit rather than explicit. Whereas the literal and figurative meanings are merged in a metaphor, in a simile they are separated. Consequently, in a metaphor X simply becomes Y and Y becomes X. That is, each of the two objects being compared is spoken as if it were the other.

Metaphors are very important in Literature. In fact, metaphor is the very heart of the poetic genre. It is the very soul of poetic language. This is because metaphors vastly extend the language at a poet¶s disposal since metaphors use terms in transferred or connotative sense ± the very lifeline of a genre that demands economy of words that still carries intension of purpose and meaning. Referring to a person as a 'human elephant' may provoke a variety of interpretations bordering on physical bulkiness, political or social importance, even stupendous remunerative hugeness / wealthiness to negative aspects hinging on savage untamedness, barbarism, mercilessness, rudeness, coarseness and atrociousness in all regards. This μambiguity¶ in a metaphor which allows one to interpret a word or clause in possible fresh manifold ways, is the essence of figurative language. It is the foundation of poetic language.

Quintillian identifies four types of metaphors, distinguished by the form of transference inherent:

- (a) From inanimate to the animate ± My best friend is called 'the book' (or My arch foe is called ignorance).

- (b) From the animate to the inanimate ± The eye of a needle ± or
± The contorted face of the moon.
- (c) From the inanimate to the inanimate ± Love planted on rock.
- (d) From the animate to the animate ± The sergeant roared at the
junior.

The four kinds of metaphors above constitute four basic ways in which metaphoric transition or suggestiveness can be obtained.

From the examples given, we can also observe that a metaphor is essentially made up of two parts: (1) an image ± used in comparing the dissimilar, and (2) the 'idea' communicated. In literary terms, the former is known as the **vehicle**. That is, every metaphor employs an 'image'; an actual and tangible representation of a mental discernment or of an object that can be deciphered by one or more of the senses but which in the literary perception will ultimately involve changing the literal comprehension of the words. Thus, while seeking to provoke 'unnormal' sensations through certain words, the image ultimately seeks to extend the obvious meaning of words. This is what we see in all the four examples given above. The literal meaning of the words 'friend' and 'foe' is extended in example (a). The words can only be used with reference to animate beings. We do not conceive of plants or stones having acquaintances or companions. Also, ignorance is an abstract idea. We do not conceive of abstract ideas being capable of becoming our enemies. In the second example, the **vehicle** is the 'eye', which we usually associate with animate beings. However, in this case, a needle is given qualities appertaining to animate beings. The meaning of the word 'eye' is therefore extended. In the third example, love, an abstract idea, is seen as capable of being planted. Now, planting is usually associated with vegetation. The meaning of the word 'plant' is therefore extended to imply nurturing in all respects. In the last example, the sergeant, a human being, is accorded qualities of a lion, an animal ± roaring. Again, the meaning of the word 'roar' is extended to imply 'shout at harshly'.

Metaphors have also a second part that is known as the **tenor**. Whereas the vehicle refers to the image employed, the **tenor** alludes to the idea or ideas being communicated or signified in the transference of meaning therein. The first example above for instance underscores the importance of knowledge (books). The third example underlines the futility of love being expected to flourish in circumstances not conducive to such flourishing. The last example connotes the harshness, even cruelty with which the sergeant deals with his junior officers.

In Literature, metaphors serve various functions:

- (a) **Vividness / Clarity** ± it is assumed that the transference inherent in a metaphor, deliberately done, communicates a truth in a more clear manner than if ordinary language was used.

- (b) **Brevity** ± metaphors contribute to conciseness in Literature in the sense that manifold interpretations can be derived from a single word. In a sense then, metaphors also make literary works compact and cohesive since in interpreting a metaphor, the reader or audience must interpret the metaphors within the contexts in which the metaphors are presented, without overstretching them.
- (c) **Language etiquette** ± metaphors contribute to appropriateness in language use in Literature. Good writers steer clear of obscenities. Where such profanities are unavoidable, then the writer looks for non-offensive words to talk about the obscenities μ respectably¶ or with language that entails some sense of aptness or decorum. Visualize how Jonathan Kariara¶s poem 'The Leopard lives on a Muu Tree' would read if things were said in black and white, so to speak. Imagine phrases like "the upright post at the gate has fallen' or 'my medicine bags are torn' being uttered with μ brutal¶ frankness. Such bareness, if used, would make many not only flinch but also read (if at all) the poem with shock and disgust at the language employed. In fact, focus would be shifted from the thematic concerns to the appalling foulness of the language. Such alarming bareness may obscure even the noblest of intentions. Hence, metaphors exhibit decorum.
- (d) **Magnifying** ± Subsequent to the equivocality inherent in them, metaphors call for several possible interpretations. A single metaphor may therefore have various implications, leading to the thematic complexity of a work. A work of art could consequently grow from a single metaphor.
- (e) **Minifying** ± In binding together μ unbindable¶ objects, the metaphor ultimately clarifies various concepts and unities of experience through association. The convertibility of notions that initially seem incontrovertible; notions about material, political, social, psychological or whatever form of realities of the world, makes us comprehend life better, seeing it as a harmony of disharmony. Investment in one object of the meaning of another, taxes the reader¶s intellect, alright. However, at the end of the μ ordeal¶, the metaphor has the capacity to draw the reader¶s attention to the intrinsic correspondences between the many opposites not only existent in our world, but also opposites on which our world depends. Veritably, life is a melody of the cacophonous. The

harmony of life hinges on discordance. Thus, truth and illusion may be seen as one side of the same coin. Death may be seen as the gateway to life in the spiritual sense. The corroboration of incongruous objects or opposites in metaphors indeed expands our vision through minifying various aspects of the world.

- (f) **Ornamenting** ± Metaphors no doubt embellish language. You can imagine how language would be like if in our utterances we were to present words as bare bones, so to speak ± saying things as plainly as possible. It is no coincidence that metaphors exist in all known languages of the world. This means that at any given time the metaphors are always fashioned by social pressures. Such pressures, while obviously slanted against obscenity, also demand some decoration in language so that the art of speaking itself, an unavoidable imperative in the human world, could be done with some form of enjoyment. Just as we clothe not merely to hide our nakedness but also to gratify our senses in knowing that we are dressed 'well' (in terms of fashion or social expectations); just as we build houses not merely to have some roof over our heads but also to delight in the architectural designs; just as we manufacture cars not merely for the convenience of moving us from point A to B but also to enjoy some coziness in traveling in the vehicles; in language too man is not merely interested in communicating. That he must inevitably communicate till he expires from the earth, man ensures that he communicates enjoyably. Metaphors serve to provide this linguistic enjoyability. Metaphors and figurative language generally doubtlessly enliven ordinary language. Metaphors add some flesh to the bare bones that are ordinary words so that we may relish in devouring some savory fleshy matter before we reach the bones. And with enough flesh covering the bones, after the tasteful feasting, we do not need to chew the bones ± we just see them and apprehend ± that they are bones. In other words, metaphors help us understand the meaning better through the metaphorical transference of meaning so that we don't have to misinterpret. The flesh inherent in a metaphor pleurably leads you right to the bones.

Dead Metaphors

In as far as metaphors are concerned, it is expected that a literary writer will come up with original metaphors and not merely plagiarize from another writer. It is indeed the freshness in a new metaphor that constitutes its figurativeness. This is because sometimes

a metaphor can become widely known in terms of its figurative associations to the extent that whereas it innately remains a metaphor, its implication has become common knowledge such that one does not even have to crack his / her head thinking. Such metaphors which have become public property to the extent of losing their figurative value are known as 'dead metaphors'. Hackneyed statements or clichés such as: 'the leg of a table', 'the eye of a needle', 'to be dog-tired', 'flogging a dead horse', belong in this category. A literary writer should endeavour to steer clear of such 'dead' figurative expressions.

Note

The above observation notwithstanding, the line between dead metaphors and those that are fresh cannot be easily drawn. As we say, the cliché notwithstanding, one man's meat may as well be another man's poison, and vice-versa.

Activity

Analyze the following poem, giving special consideration to its metaphors.

Piano and Drums

When at break of day at a riverside I hear
jungle drums telegraphing The mystic
rhythm, urgent, raw Like bleeding flesh,
speaking of Primal youth and the
beginning, I see the panther ready to
pounce, The leopard snarling about to
leap, And the hunters crouch with spears
poised;

And my blood ripples, turns torrent, Topples
the years and at once I'm In my mother's laps
a suckling At once I'm walking simple Paths
with no innovations, Rugged, fashioned with
the naked Warmth of hurrying feet and
groping heart In green leaves and wild
flowers pulsing.

Then I hear a wailing piano Solo
speaking of complex ways In
tearfurrowed concerto; Of far
away lands
And new horizons with
Coaxing diminuendo, counterpoint, Crescendo.
But lost in the labyrinth
Of its complexities, it ends in the middle Of a phrase
at a daggerpoint.

And I lost in the morning mist Of
an age at a riverside keep
Wandering in the mystic rhythm Of
jungle drums and the concerto.

Gabriel Okara

Irony

Irony is a broad term that entails a reality that is incongruous, inconsistent with the appearance. The assumptions of a user of irony is that the audience will apprehend and recognize the incongruity and hence understand the concealed meaning therein.

There are various forms of irony: those that operate at the figurative level and those that transcend the figurative level:

(a) *Verbal Irony* (Figurative)

Also known as µRhetorical irony¶, this is the simplest form of irony. A speaker says something to mean the very opposite of his / her words. In Okot P¶Bitek¶s *Song of Lawino*, Lawino calls her rival, Clementina, 'The Beautiful one'. Yet, in describing Clementina, we can easily tell that Clementina is the very opposite of µbeautiful¶. Whereas this example borders on sarcasm, that is not always the case. Indeed, there are those who confuse the term irony with sarcasm. But one can be purely ironic without being sarcastic. For example, when one says: 'My daughter did her exams badly that she became the overall best student in the country', he / she is definitely being ironic without being sarcastic in any way. In fact, in this example, the speaker uses the word 'badly' to emphasize the opposite ± exceptionally well. In Dongala¶s short story 'The Man', in the anthology *Encounters From Africa*, while looking for the killer of the president, the leader of the army says 'I know he is here' to mean that the president¶s assassin is in a particular village. Yet, it is obvious that he does not really know where the assassin is. The military personnel subsequently go on a killing spree in lieu of apprehending the killer whom they claim to 'know'.

(b) *Situational Irony*

This type of irony occurs not at the level of grammatical utterances or pronouncements. Rather, this form of irony is µseen¶ when there are certain discrepancies, inconsistencies in particular situations. For example, fighting in a lecture room would constitute situational inharmoniousness since the lecture room is associated with academic activities rather than physical brawls. Singing a dirge at a wedding or vice-versa would also constitute situational irony. There is something incongruous in the examples cited. It is this incongruity / incompatibility that is referred to as 'Situational Irony'.

Situational irony is effective in satirizing characters. Think of the judge in Nicolai Gogol¶s play *The Government Inspector*, who keeps poultry in the courthouse. In

the novel *Shrine of Tears*, Francis Imbuga demonstrates the common irony of politicians using burial ceremonies of their constituents to boost their image. Honourable Gasia is such a politician. He goes to the extent of declaring that the burial of Kanaya would not take place without cameramen. In David Mulwa's *Redemption*, Rebecca and Antoninus have sex in the latter's father's very bedroom.

(c) *Dramatic Irony*

This type of irony too is unrelated to grammar. Initially only confined to Drama, dramatic irony occurred in a play when the audience was conscious of certain truths which the characters in the play did not know. For example, in Gogol's *The Government Inspector*, while the corrupt city officials run helter-skelter to please the windbag Hlestakov, whom they mistake for the dreaded Government Inspector, the audience knows that Hlestakov is not the inspector. In Shakespeare's *Romeo and Juliet*, Paris is convinced that he will eventually marry Juliet while we (the audience) already know that he won't. At one point, when Juliet is found mourning, the parents think that she is mourning the death of Tybalt while we know that she is grieving for the exiled Romeo.

Sophocle's *King Oedipus* is considered one of the best examples of dramatic irony. In this tragic play, Oedipus is unaware of many facts that the audience is cognizant of. For instance, when he runs to Thebes to avoid the prophecy of marrying his own mother and killing his own father, we are very aware that he is actually running towards the danger zone. When eventually he searches for the murder of King Laius, we are only well informed that he is actually looking for himself - a fact that he discovers later. Hence, dramatic irony entails some sense of paradox, incongruity perceived by the spectators of a drama, who watch characters performing in total ignorance of their situation.

Note

We have said that dramatic irony was originally confined to drama. This is no longer the case. In modern times, dramatic irony percolates into other genres such as the novel and short story.

(d) Tragic Irony

Tragic irony occurs where a character expects to succeed and, indeed, all events point towards success, but he / she fails. In Chinua Achebe's *Things Fall Apart*, Okonkwo strives to achieve greatness in his land. With the uncharitable image of his deceased father hanging over his head, Okonkwo aims to obliterate the image of a good-for-nothing, indolent simpleton, that was his forbearer, and carve a niche for himself. And indeed, he works diligently and becomes a big name: a great wrestler, a wealthy man and eventually, an *megwugwu*. However, a number of things happen that change his fate and when later he kills a court messenger, his clan denounce and condemn his action. Unable to come to terms with his changed society and condemnation of what he thought was a noble course (of maintaining some traditional mores which were being execrated by the invasion of the white man), Okonkwo kills himself; thereby dying an abominable death just like his father. Thus, in the novel *Things Fall Apart*, there is a contradiction between what Okonkwo expects and what he achieves.

(e) Comic Irony

Comic Irony is the opposite of tragic Irony. Here, a character faces a lot of difficulties to an extent that he expects nothing but total failure. However, the character eventually succeeds. Many of Henrik Ibsen's plays are written in this mode.

Remember

- (1) The essence of irony is the ability to perceive what lies beneath the ironical mask. Irony is paramount in Literature. Also, Irony in Literature is a serious matter. Just like science, Literature would be rendered superfluous if the appearance of things always coincided with the reality.
- (2) Not all ironies qualify as figures of speech. For example, dramatic and situational ironies are not figures of speech as such but have been illustrated here for our academic benefit

(iv) *Satire*

This term, which escapes simplistic, straightjacket definitions, alludes to the kind of irony that entails recognizing the laughable or ridiculous. Satire criticizes / ridicules human weaknesses and faults through laughter. It is therefore cruel and kind at the same time. It ridicules with the ultimate noble aim of bringing about reform or keeping other human beings from falling into similar folly or vice

Satire encourages people to embrace the positive values in an enjoyable and entertaining manner. It must be emphasized here that Satire only qualifies to be called so if the utterance is invested with literariness to the extent that it does not slide into either empty opprobrium or mere clownish jesting. The satirical censure of foibles and faults must entail a fusion of the aesthetic and moral for it to qualify as satire. That is, the criticism must be done in an aesthetic manner. It is the aesthetic relaying of the ridicules in a satire that makes the censuring not only tolerable but also convinces the consumer of the satire to notice his / her weaknesses, apprehend the effects of such weaknesses and therefore shun the vices. Hence, in satirizing, literary writers employ language that will persuade their readers to loathe the vices or weaknesses.

Satire is achieved through various literary techniques, purposely employed: irony, imagery, sarcasm, sardonic questions and statements, caricature, apostrophe, hyperbole, parody, lampoon, humour, burlesque and allegories. Since some of these terms may not be familiar, we will now define them:

(a) *Sarcasm*

Sarcasm can briefly be defined as a bitter or cutting expression intended to wound the feelings. It is a cruel statement intended to hurt. For example, if after a class a student tells an instructor that he did not understand certain components of the lesson, and the latter responds, with a heavy tone: 'Well, I wouldn't expect you to understand, then the instructor is purely being sarcastic. In John Ruganda's *The Burdens*, Tinka refers to Wamala as 'Our adorable father' to imply the opposite ± that Wamala is a good-for-nothing person who cannot even provide for his family.

(b) *Sardonic Questions*

Sardonic questions are jocular yet tinged with reproach and disapproval. The humour in sardonic questions is disguised to the extent that it can easily go unobserved. In Okot Bitek's *Song of Ocol*, Ocol employs sardonic questions to disparage African politicians who are unoriginal and hinge on borrowed philosophies like Marxism and communism:

Did Senegalese blood
Flow in the veins Of
Karl Marx?
And Lenin
Was he born
At Arusha? (p.253)

In the example above, the sardonic questions serve to ridicule African politicians who embrace foreign political ideologies blindly. Sardonic questions serve to deride and belittle their target while eliciting laughter at the same time.

(c) Caricature

Caricature is a mode of characterization where a writer exaggerates certain attributes of a character to the point of presenting such characters as cartoon- strips rather than beings of flesh and blood that have both positive and negative features. The exaggeration of certain aspects, while evoking humour, most significantly serves to criticize the character presented. In *Song of Lawino*, Okot 3rd Bitek uses caricature to satirize alienated Africans who subscribe to foreign beauty standards. Such a person is Ocol's Westernized second wife, who in her endeavours to look like a white woman, comes out non-human owing to what she has done to her body:

Some medicine has eaten up Tina's face; The skin
on her face is gone And it is all raw and red
The face of the beautiful one
Is tender like the skin of a new born baby.

Her body resembles
The ugly coat of the hyena, Her
neck and arms Have real human
skins!
She looks as if she has been struck By lightening
Or burnt like the Kongoni In
a fire hunt (p.42-43)

The above description of Clementina borders on exaggeration in the sense that it is almost impossible to visualize someone without skin ±
 'raw and red'. While the caricatured description of Clementina is humorous, it serves to satirize a character who, in her ludicrous efforts to change nature with the intention of qualifying to belong in the Western conceptualization of 'the beautiful', achieves shockingly repugnant results, ending up looking horrid - the very opposite of her assumption.

(d) Hyperbole

If the prefix 'hyper' means 'to an excessive degree', **Hyperbole** can be defined as a statement that entails extravagant exaggeration. Saying 'millions of people attended my birthday party' may be considered a hyperbole since it is unrealistic for millions to attend someone's birthday party. If an anniversary fete for a prominent person may attract huge numbers but short of millions, what about a party hosted in respect of an ordinary citizen? However, it should be noted that when a speaker or writer exaggerates or overstates a point, he / she does not do so in order to fool the hearer / reader. Rather, hyperbole is employed for the sole purpose of emphasizing the extent of something. While discussing caricature in relation to satire, we noted how Lawino exaggerates Clementina's hideous physical appearance with a view to lashing at those who despise themselves to the extent of damaging themselves in pursuit of alien prescriptions of beauty. To emphasize the beauty of his mistress, Andrew marvel employs hyperbole thus:

Had we but world enough, and time, This
 coyness, Lady, were no crime. We would sit
 down and think which way To walk and
 pass our long love's day. Thou by the
 Indian Gange's side
 Shouldst rubies find; I by the tide Of
 Humber would complain. I would Love
 you ten years before the Flood, And you
 should, if you please, refuse Till the
 conversion of the jews.

My vegetable love should grow Vaster than
 empires, and more slow; An hundred years
 should go to praise Thine eyes and on thy
 forehead gaze; Two hundred to adore each
 breast, But thirty thousand to the rest;
 An age at least to every part,
 And the last age should show your heart. For, Lady,
 you deserve this state,

Nor would I love at lower rate.

(e) Parody

Parody entails mimicry. Satiric parody ridicules and mocks the original through negative portrayal of what is imitated. In *Song of Lawino*, Lawino portrays Christianity negatively in her imitation of Christian prayers.

(f) Lampoon

A lampoon constitutes personal verbal assault where an assailant makes direct Oral attack on an object. In *Song of Lawino*, presenting himself as an adherent of societal values, Lawino lampoons Ocol's and Clementina's Westernized mannerisms. Selecting specific traits of Ocol and Clementine, Lawino mocks these features.

(g) Burlesque

Burlesque is a literary technique that either trivializes, diminishes the dignified, serious and esteemed subject or dignifies / glorifies the low, cheap, inferior or despicable with scornful worthiness. The trivialization of a serious subject is known as *Low burlesque*, while the elevation of a frivolous or commonplace subject is called *High Burlesque*. In *Song of Lawino*, Lawino trivializes everything Christian: the Holy Communion, baptism, the birth of Christ, and the creation story, among many other tenets of the faith. Indeed, Lawino ridicules the content of the Bible to the point where Christianity in its entirety is made to look a laughable religion that would only make sense to the senseless. See how Lawino paints the creation story as foolish, absurd and implausible:

Where did he dig the clay For moulding things? «
And the clay for moulding Earth?
From the mouth of which River? « W
here did the hunchback live? « W here
did the hunchback
Dig the clay for moulding things? On
the mouth of which River? W here
did he put the clay To season
overnight? « On which rock

Remember

- (1) Satire does not constitute a figure of speech as such but is realized

through or may be a cumulative effect of a figure of speech or a conglomeration of several figures of speech or non-figures of speech.

- (2) Satire involves a double aspect: (i) The laughable and also (ii) the important ± beneath the satirical mask there is something very serious which the writer is criticizing.

(v) Litote - Understatement

Litote is the opposite of Hyperbole ± a figure of speech in which a pronouncement is made by denoting the negative of its antonym. Litotes are therefore ironical statements which essentially use a negative to emphasize the positive. For example, saying 'It was not easy' to mean 'it was very difficult'.

Summary

In this lecture we have looked at figures of speech and a few aspects of the cumulative effect of such figures of speech. We noted multiple functions of similes and metaphors. We have looked at irony at the figurative level and beyond and noted that irony in all regards either entails some unmasking of some mask or some contrariness that masks some bitter realities / truths. Lastly, we have looked at satire as a cumulative end product of some figures of speech.

Activity

Attempt the following questions:

- (1) Why are figures of speech such a significant component of literary style?
- (2) With concrete illustrations from literary works of your choice, explain what you understand by the term 'Irony'.
- (3) 'Irony and sarcasm are not the only satiric devices'. Giving examples, discuss.

Lecture sixteen

SOCIO-DYNAMIC ASPECTS OF STYLE: Diction, Register and Dialect

Introduction

This is our sixteenth and last lecture in this unit. In this lecture we will focus on aspects of language variation at a writer's disposal. The only access to a literary piece of writing is through words. The success of a literary writer is therefore judged on his / her ability to communicate effectively. The ability of the writer to communicate will depend on his / her skills - skills that hinge on the choice of words. But the choice of words in Literature must be seen to be realistic depending on the people, situations and locations being presented. The language given a character must be seen to be plausible against the backcloth of the character's age, educational level, geographical location and suitable under the context presented. In this lecture we will therefore look at how the aspects of language variation that take into account the rhetorical situation (actors, occasion and purpose) serve to not only enhance literary realism but also meaning.

Lecture Objectives

At the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- (a) Define the terms ***diction***, ***register*** and ***dialect***.
- (b) Identify the difference(s) therein.
- (c) Explain their significance in literary discourse.

DICTION

In simple terms, **Diction** may be described as the choice, patterning and application of words. In literature, **diction** would refer to the aggregate or complete impression accorded by a writer's employment of words. Indeed, the meaning of any piece of writing will spring from the interplay amongst individual words. Since language is the medium used by literary writers to communicate their thoughts, ideas and even feelings, proper selection and manipulation of words is necessary. Each word must be chosen with care so that a sentence means precisely what the writer intends.

In relation to diction, a language may be broken into two broad categories:

(a) Standard and (b) Non-standard. However, further sub-division may be done to show exactly where a writer may choose words from depending on his purpose, occasion and actors and audience (consumers). In this regard, diction would have six categories:

- | | |
|------------------|------------|
| (a) formal | (b) |
| informal | (c) |
| colloquial | (d) |
| slang | (e) jargon |
| (f) non-standard | |

Formal Diction

Formal diction employs polished vocabulary. It is the language used in professional journals and public speeches. Formal diction is seen in the speeches of the elders in Achebe's ***Things Fall Apart***. While being grammatical in all regards, the speeches are characterized by extravagant use of proverbs and idioms. This marks the elders off as non-ordinary citizens.

Informal Diction

While the vocabulary of informal diction is less dignified than formal diction, it is nonetheless more polished and more careful than language used in free conversation. It is the language used in journalism, general textbooks and also in most literary texts.

Colloquial Diction

This is a type of informal language. It is conversational. It is purely spontaneous, characterized with the use of current words, contractions (e.g, don't, let's, it's e.t.c) and other levels of free conversation.

Slang

Slang is faddish language. It is used for a while by a group of people and it often disappears. An expression like 'chill' in the local English dialect is the current slang word for sexual abstinence rather than making something cold. In fact, slang is language whose vocabulary means something to a limited audience. It may be adopted by a wider public for a short while but it often gets out of fashion. In Meja Mwangi's *Going Down River Road*, the slang word *ufagi* is used to refer to a cigarette.

Locally, *Sheng* is the equivalent of Slang. It will be remembered that some time in the 1980s and early 1990s, Cigarettes were called *ufegi* (a translation of the English slang word *ufagi*). Later, Cigarettes became *umwozo*. At one point in time, thugs were called *Wagondi*, then *mathegi*, then *makauzi*.

Jargon

Jargon vocabulary is used and generally understood by a particular professional group such as doctors, lawyers, biologists, agriculturalists, (and others) to communicate with each other. It is the so-called *shop-talk*. To lay persons, Jargon may sound vague or incomprehensible. A phrase like *pedaductile limbs* (a scientific reference to hands) may only make sense to scientists. Likewise, a term like *Periphrasis* may only make sense to a literary person or linguist. When Odili Samalu, a graduate teacher in Achebe's *A Man of the People* becomes a politician, he endeavours to use political jargon full of political catchwords.

Non-Standard Diction

The vocabulary of non-standard diction is characterized by poor spelling, poor pronunciation and irregular usage. Such diction is ungrammatical and is generally expected only of the uneducated, illiterate or downright careless. Hence, diction in a literary work is dictated by participants. For instance, we do not expect illiterate characters to speak Oxford English. Imbuga has illustrated this in his works. Mulili is such a character in *Betrayal in the City*. Agege is another character in *Aminata*. While in *Betrayal in the City*

Imbuga satirizes a society where the illiterates govern simply because they are related or affiliated to the powers-that-be, in *Aminata*, Imbuga is ironic or paradoxical: that the idiocy of the idiots could be more intellectual / rational than the cleverness of the intelligent, and the wisdom of the intelligent could be more foolish than the foolishness of the stupid.

REGISTER

Closely related to *diction* is *register*. *Register* is an aspect of language variation. It is the choice of language one makes depending on:

- (a) Prevailing social circumstances. (b) Field of discourse.

When we observe language activity in various contexts in which it takes place, we find distinct differences in the types of language considered appropriate in the various circumstances. Sometimes it could be the same thing being communicated.

However, the circumstances affect the way the idea is relayed. Look at the following example:

Speech A: Anne says to the first character:

Know what Josh? That fool Maina gave me the sack yesterday coz I refused his stupid sexual advances. Just imagine? I want my job back!

Speech B: Anne says to the second person:

Do you know my boss Mr. Kenneth Maina? Yesterday he fired me from my job in circumstances that I do not understand. Don't you think that is unfair?

Speech C: To the third person Anne says:

My name is Anne Bosire Sir, who used to work in the printing department until yesterday sir. Sir, I am here to appeal to you kindly to reconsider giving me back my job. Sir, I do not really understand the circumstances under which my boss relieved me of my job. I am sorry sir if I failed in my obligations in any way. I am ready to make amends. Please give me a second chance sir!

The foregoing is a good illustration of how the social situation determines the language we employ. Certain forms of language are essentially more appropriate than others for particular circumstances. For example, when speaking to a large audience, the speaker needs prior preparation and careful choice of words. Also, such a speaker does not expect immediate response from the audience. Therefore, the language employed does not call for any instant responses (or at least may only call for reflections on an issue). However, when people speak individual to individual, the language changes. Therefore the two situations call for two linguistic approaches.

When we examine categories of *Register*, we are trying to account for what people do with language in the various contexts in which it takes place.

We also said that language variation may be determined by the field of discourse. Indeed considerable linguistic differences can be observed in the technical languages of various professions. These differences are usually marked at the lexical level. This is because different occupations have different vocabulary. Others will use similar vocabulary but for different impact. For instance, to a legal expert the word *µcase¶* differs from the layman understanding of the term. While to the layman the term simply refers to a circumstance, a condition, an occurrence, to a legal mind the word *µcase¶* involves a dispute between a litigant and defendant. An accountant would also use the familiar word *µreconcile¶* differently from the way we commonly apprehend it. In our first year ³Introduction to Literary Genres' course, we also saw how our (literary) understanding of terms such as ³tragedy', ³drama', ³poetry' and others differs from other professional (or lay person¶s) understanding of the same. Terms like: tempo, pitch, diction and rhythm are also used in music. However, their conceptualization in Literature is markedly different. Hence, what we call *µtechnical vocabularies¶* are words or usage restricted to one area of operation. These technical vocabularies as we have shown vary from profession to profession. When people of the same profession meet, they commonly engage in discourse that is completely out of reach of people of other professions. Talking using technical vocabularies of one's profession is what we refer to in Literature and Linguistics as ³*talking shop*' / ³*shop-talk*'.

Since social situations determine the language we use, the individual speaker, listener or reader has been socialized into adjusting, almost unconsciously, constantly, from one situation to another, from one set of speech or writing to another. The same person

therefore at one point becomes an eloquent formal speaker, at another a preacher who delves into biblical language of 'thou' and 'thee', an auctioneer at another moment, a doctor at another moment, a casual talker at another moment, a parent at another. This adjustment from one type of language to another is what we refer to in Linguistics as 'Codeswitching'. The person switches to / adjusts perfectly into all these roles linguistically such that an agriculturalist father does not begin mouthing terms like 'Casuarinas Cunningamiana' (To refer to a common tree) or 'Donialis Coffra' (to refer to a common hedge) while speaking to his unenlightened brood.

Determinants of Register

- (1) **Intimacy** - the relationship between the addresser and addressee will determine the kind of register a person would use. It will be absurd, almost clownish to talk to one's fiancé / fiancée, wife, husband, mother, father or child in a very formal manner with the employment of 'Sir' or 'madam' respectively. Speech A shows some familiarity / intimacy between the two speakers. Such familiarity is lacking in the subsequent speeches.
- (2) **Status** ± We are expected to use appropriate language depending on the status or supposed standing of a person. An employee talking to his boss would vary his language accordingly. Speech C in the example afore-given illustrates this. One must use formal language that does not only have decorum but that also shows respect, sometimes, even reverence. On the other hand, for self-image, the superiors employ a language of self-importance - a language that states categorically that they belong in a higher pedestal. However, should the relationship between a Boss and secretary descend into that of intimacy, then the language might change.
- (3) **Age** ± The age of the speaker and addressee also determines the kind of register we use. While we should find 'I want to urinate' normal if said by a child, such an utterance from an adult with all his senses intact would be preposterous, outrageous and contemptible. An adult using such words as 'transcendental', 'profligate', 'bumptiousness' or 'lugubrious' to a five-year-old child would either be silly or scatter-brained. Hence, adults speaking to children will often speak deliberately slowly and clearly, using simple, crisp words. This would be called **Child Register**. Even when children speak to each other their language is markedly different from that of adults. Adults speaking to children must therefore take note of this fact. Thus, within the educational system also, the teacher is constantly adjusting his language levels and complexity of ideas to match the students being taught. Adults speaking to fellow adults

unconsciously find themselves changing their manner of speaking, employing adult register.

- (4) **Education** - This is partly covered in our explanation in No. (3). The educational level of the speaker and addressee will determine the kind of register use. When a University professor, who is a member of some rural clan's elder's council addresses the semi-literate clansmen, he will endeavour to employ language that is penetrable to them, different from the abstruse, flamboyant and sometimes pretentiously show-offish language he may use in a University classroom. Likewise, when we speak to non-native speakers of our language, who have not totally mastered our language, we adjust our language accordingly; using register that we feel is appropriate. We adjust our lexical choice, pitch, intonation and other elements so that we may communicate better.
- (5) **Occupation** - We have already explained that different occupations have their own jargon and that people of the same profession would use a language unique to that particular occupation.
- (6) **Sex** - The sex of the listener also determines the language we use. While addressing persons of the opposite gender, we are careful to use words that do not offend them. These days of radical and increased feminism, we are also careful to use all inclusive language in order not to be labeled Chauvinists. However, on our own, we may engage in language characterized by chauvinism towards the other sex.

Note

From the illustrations given, it can be seen that almost every individual has a command of a number of registers which he uses in different situations in his life ± at work, home, with friends of his own age and sex, language which he / she would use at public meetings or other fora. The choice of register depends on the circumstances of communication.

REGISTER IN LITERATURE

Just as in normal life, register is important in Literature. As a reflection of reality, Literature is truthful to the registers employed in life. As a reflection of such realities therefore, Literature cannot avoid reflecting on the registers used in communication. However, 'Literary registers' go beyond mere reflection of realities. They are connotatively communicative of truths beyond the literal utterances. For instance, David Mulwa does not use religious register in his play Redemption merely to be appropriate to the religious context he has created. The irony inherent in the religious context comes out clearly in the register ± one purporting to be holy, yet fiendish intrinsically. The political register employed by Machore, a construction site worker in Meja Mwangi's Going Down River Road, serves to distinguish him as politically enlightened and therefore mark him off from the other workers who come out as political imbeciles who do not even fathom what a trade union is. Similarly, in the poem 'Building the Nation', Henry Barlow effectively uses political jargon to demonstrate the insincerity and insensitivity of politicians. Indeed, these days phrases like 'My people', 'My constituents', 'Our country needs...' have become political jargon in Kenya. Even unambiguously egotistic and narcissistic leaders (Do they even deserve this label?) these days will shamelessly talk of 'my constituents' when they actually mean 'me, myself and I' or 'my family'. 'My nation' would be used when they actually mean 'my homestead'. 'People-driven constitution' would be mouthed by some politician when he really means: 'A constitution that gives me power, that has loopholes to allow me to enrich myself and get away with it'.

Thus, in Literature, choice of register depends on many factors, and use of register does not aim at mere reflection of verbal realities but also aims to communicate beyond the utterances.

DIALECT

A dialect is a variety of language determined by: (a) geographical differences and (b) social class. In dialects are therefore discerned differences in the same language as used by different speakers.

Geographical dialects occur because some natural landmark or geographical feature keeps speakers of a language apart. This apartness leads to changes in vocabulary, sound preferences and intonation and at other time, grammatical structuring. It is believed that a speaker will use one dialect throughout. However, some speakers may master more than one dialect. Lexical choices and meaning, phonological inclinations and grammar indeed are the three main defining dimensions of dialects.

Now let us look at some of the dialect markers more elaborately:

Dialect Markers

- (i) **Phonology** - The sound system marks one dialect from another. Intonation differentiates the British English from American or Canadian English dialects. Locally, languages like Kiswahili and Luhya (the latter is the most complex in terms of dialectal differentiation) are also dialectally differentiated by the variation in pronunciation. For example ³An¶kuja¶ and ³Amekuja' in two different Kiswahili dialects mean ³He / she has come'.
- (ii) **Syntax** - How words are ordered or written may also differentiate various dialects. For example, the following dissimilarities can be observed in the way British and American English dialect speakers write the following words:

British

Neighbour
Favour
Honour
Metre

American

neighbor
favor
honor
meter

- (iii) **Lexis** - Vocabulary is an important dialect marker. Different dialects may prefer divergent words for the same thing. For example: μbathroom¶ or μrest-room¶ (American) in place of μtoilet¶ or μlavatory¶ (British), μelevator¶ (American), μLift¶ (British); μcandy¶ (American) instead of μsweets¶ (British), μpants¶ (American) in lieu of μtrousers¶ (British); μtruck¶ (American) in place of μlorry¶ (British), and many others.
- (iv) **Semantic** - Speakers of the same language may use a word to derive variant meanings. A word like ³khubaya¶ (Luhya) may mean μto play¶ (Lukhayo, Lusamia, Lunyore, e.t.c.). But in Kimaragoli dialect, the same word *but* pronounced μKuvaya¶ means μto go for a walk¶. A word like ³okhuisaba' or ³Kuisava' may mean μto wash one¶s hands¶ in the former dialects while signify μto bathe¶ in Kimaragoli.

Dialect and Social Class

The term **dialect** can also be used to describe differences in speech according to social groups or classes. Hence, there are **regional dialects** as well as **social dialects**. Whereas **regional dialects** are geographically founded, **social dialects** originate from social groups and subsist on a variety of factors: class, religion, ethnicity, profession, place of residence and other factors.

Dialects and Literature

Creative writers normally face a challenge of which dialect to choose when writing. Lack of proficiency in a dialect that a writer selects limits the options open to the writer and leads to synthetic and humdrum writing; sometimes, even mediocrity. A writer must pay attention to the geographical location being delineated in his work. The various social groups must also be taken into account. For example, a writer using English to portray the Kenyan situation currently must take cognizant of the fact that we have our own dialect of the English language which is very different from the Ugandan, South African or West African dialectal variations of the same. For example, Kenyan English is currently characterized by code-mixing and code-switching (in this regard, even from one language to another). These are characteristics of everyday conversation. ³Ati what? You are not serious Mazee. But wacha jokes! Let us continue now' is a normal way of communicating even in our electronic media. Some time, as we had mentioned before, an existent English word such as ³chill' has been given a totally different meaning in our local slang. A word like ³matt' is but a Kenyan coinage / lexicon to refer to a special transportation system ± ³Matatu'. ³I board a matatu / matt to work every morning' is therefore an expression that may only make sense to Kenyans or foreigners who have been to Kenya or are acquainted with Kenya's mode of transportation since the Matatu phenomenon may not exist elsewhere. Where it exists such as in Tanzania, it is not labeled ³umatatu but ³udaladala (again a name peculiar to Tanzania). It is in the same regard that Marjorie Oludhe Macgoye (in ³A freedom Song') uses the expression ³Atieno Yo' most typical of Luo expression to suggest surprise. Ngugi Wa Thiong'o, Chinua Achebe, Margaret Ogolla, among other African writers, are also known to engage in this code-mixing and switching in their writings. Most important is that some of the borrowed or coined words have become part of the Kenyan dialect of English.

Therefore, it can be observed that when a writer has ample knowledge of a region's dialect, this will enhance the credibility of his / her presentation. At the same time, a reader's knowledge of a certain region's dialects will enhance his / her understanding of a literary work and subsequently heighten his appreciation of the work.

Summary

In this lecture, we have looked at social-dynamic aspects of style, mainly, aspects of language variation: diction, register and dialect. We have endeavoured to distinguish these three confusing terms while pointing their importance in literary art. We have seen that choice of words from the three aspects is determined by many factors, mainly context. Therefore, we have seen that register, dialect and diction are important in Literature and their knowledge vital to writers and critics alike for the production of a good work of art, and to the audience, for better comprehension and appreciation of a literary work.

Activity

Show what you understand by the following terms:

- (a) Register
- (b) Dialect
- (c) Diction

FURTHER READING

Burton, S.H. ± *The Criticism of Prose*

Chapman, R. ± *Linguistics and Literature ± An Introduction to Literary Stylistics*

Cluysenaar, A ± *Introduction to Literary Stylistics*

Cook and Rubadiri ± *Poems from East Africa*

Crystal, A & Davy, O. ± *Investigating English Style*

Davis & Stratton - *How to Teach Poetry*

Fowler, R. (1975) ± *Style and Structure in Literature*

Halliday, M.A.K. & Hassan, R. ± *Cohesion in English*

Indangasi, H. (1988): *Stylistics*

Leech, G & M. Short - *A Linguistic Introduction to English Poetry*

Leech, G & M. Short v(1981) - *Style in Fiction*

Levin, S.R. ± *The Semantics of Metaphor*

Mugubi, J (2002): ± *Introduction to Literary Genres*

Ngara, E. (1982): - *Stylistic Criticism and the African Novel*

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Richards, I.A. ± *Principles of Literary Criticism*

Turner, G.W. (1973): - *Stylistics*

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